

**12** विश्वास के, विकास के, जनकल्याण केसत्यमेव जयते
राजस्थान सरकार

माननीय प्रधानमंत्री श्री नरेन्द्र मोदी जी

के द्वारा राजस्थान को दी गई

1 लाख 5 हजार करोड़ रुपए से अधिक की अभूतपूर्व सौगातों

के लिए

आभार

₹79 हजार करोड़ से अधिक की
लागत से तैयार राजस्थान रिफाइनरी
का राष्ट्र को समर्पण₹13 हजार करोड़ से
अधिक लागत की
जयपुर मेट्रो फेज-2 का शिलान्यासजोधपुर एयरपोर्ट के नए
टर्मिनल भवन का उद्घाटनयमुना जल परियोजना के लिए MoA
किशाऊ बहुउद्देशीय बांध परियोजना से
वर्ष पर्यन्त यमुना जल की उपलब्धता

ऊर्जा, सड़क एवं रेलवे की विकास परियोजनाएं | 7 कार्य | 13 हजार 443 करोड़ रुपए

53,977 युवाओं को सरकारी नौकरी का नियुक्ति पत्र

जिला	अभ्यर्थियों की संख्या
अजमेर	1121
अलवर	2037
बालोतरा	435
बांसवाड़ा	1648
बारां	947
बाड़मेर	1116
ब्यावर	513
भरतपुर	1730
भीलवाड़ा	1199
बीकानेर	1728

जिला	अभ्यर्थियों की संख्या
बूंदी	1080
चित्तौड़गढ़	600
चूरू	1671
दौसा	2405
डीग	592
धौलपुर	864
डीडवाना-कुचामन	1480
झुंझुनू	1709
हनुमानगढ़	1748
जयपुर	5852

जिला	अभ्यर्थियों की संख्या
जैसलमेर	461
जालौर	593
झालावाड़	842
झुंझुनू	1695
जोधपुर	1971
करौली	1560
खैरथल-तिजारा	381
कोटा	1209
कोटपूतली-बहरोड़	951
नागौर	2051

जिला	अभ्यर्थियों की संख्या
पाली	766
फलोदी	359
प्रतापगढ़	898
राजसमंद	402
सलूम्बर	342
सवाईमाधोपुर	1482
सीकर	2505
सिरोही	488
श्रीगंगानगर	1206
टोंक	1661
उदयपुर	1679

Cargo ship under attack in Red Sea off Yemen, says British military



Associated Press
Cairo, July 5

A CARGO ship came under attack Sunday off the coast of Yemen in the Red Sea, the British military said, the latest maritime attack off the conflict-torn Arab country. The United Kingdom Maritime Trade Operations center reported the attack off the coastal city of Hodeida, which is under control of the Iranian-backed Houthi rebels.

The UKMTO said the ship reported being “under attack by unknown armed assailants” 30 nautical miles (55 kilometers) southwest of Hodeida.

A skiff approached the bulk carrier and opened fire, forcing the ship’s security guards to return fire, before sailing back to a larger ship about 2 nautical miles (3.7 kilometers) away with its automatic identification system switched off, the UKMTO said.

The cargo ship and crew were reported safe, the British military agency said, adding that authorities were investigating. No group immediately claimed the attack. The Houthis have threatened to begin attacking ships again, though they have not been carrying out attacks. A Houthi spokesman did not respond to a request for comment.

The rebels previously fired drones and missiles at ships that pass by territory they control near the narrow Bab al-Mandab Strait at the southern end of the Red Sea.



Iran’s top officials attend funeral prayers for late Ayatollah Ali Khamenei and his family at Tehran’s Imam Khomeini Grand Mosalla, on Sunday. REUTERS

3 sons of Khamenei appear at funeral, but not his successor

Mojtaba, the new supreme leader of Iran, makes no public appearance

Reuters
Tehran, July 5

THREE SONS of slain Iranian leader Ayatollah Ali Khamenei prayed beside his coffin and those of four other family members on Sunday, but Mojtaba, the son who succeeded him as Iran’s supreme leader, did not make an appearance.

State TV showed Mostafa, Meysam and Masoud Khamenei praying behind the coffins laid out in the vast courtyard of Tehran’s Imam Khomeini Grand Mosalla, a sprawling religious complex.

Their father, alongside several other members of the family, was killed in an airstrike when US and Israel launched a war on Iran on February 28.

In a show of public devotion to the state and revolutionary zeal, the Islamic Republic is staging a week of mass funeral processions for Khamenei, including taking his remains to Shi’ite religious sites in neighbouring Iraq. After a day lying in state indoors for senior Iranian leaders and foreign officials to visit, Khamenei’s coffin was displayed outdoors on Saturday under glass, along with those of his daughter, son-in-law, daughter-in-law and 14-month-old granddaughter.

On Sunday, tens of thousands more mourners, including soldiers, seminary students and ordinary men and women filed into the Mosalla to pay their respects to Khamenei and his family, waving flags emblazoned with promises of revenge against America and Israel.

(AP adds: Posters and graffiti at the Grand Mosalla called for the killing of Trump and Benjamin Netanyahu. “Why is... (he) still alive?” Mohammad Rasouli, a poet who emceed the event before the prayers, said referring to

Trump. “I came here to shout and seek revenge,” said Gholamreza Sabooni, a 29-year-old man who works in a grocery.)

There has still been no public sighting or image released of Mojtaba, said to have been injured in the attack that killed his father and the other family members on February 28, when Israel and the US bombed Iranian targets at the start of the war. Mojtaba Khamenei’s face was disfigured and he suffered a significant injury to one or both legs, people close to his inner circle told Reuters.

One disappointed mourner said she had hoped to see the new supreme leader during the funeral events. “Until the last moment... I kept telling those around me that I hoped (Mojtaba Khamenei) himself would come. That was our only wish,” a young woman told *Tasnim* news agency.

On Sunday, Iranian President Masoud Pezeshkian and Parliament Speaker Mohammad Baqer Ghalibaf prayed behind the coffins.

A FUNERAL... AND ACROSS THE WORLD, A CELEBRATION

Trump warns of ‘Communist cancer’ at a campaign-style July 4 speech

250th anniversary of US: President says Iran defeated

Reuters
Washington, July 5

PRESIDENT DONALD Trump marked the 250th anniversary of the United States on Saturday with a campaign-style speech that repeated his calls for new voting restrictions, warned that “communists” could gain ground in the country and cycled through what he touted as his achievements.

After a storm-related delay of nearly two hours, Trump appeared on the National Mall in Washington to deliver a speech that mixed broad appeals to patriotism with pointed attacks on perceived ideological threats at home and abroad.

Trump lauded American achievements such as war victories, the lunar landing and the Wright brothers’ pioneering flight, as well as the US system of government in general. But he also urged Congress to pass stalled legislation that would limit mail ballots and require proof of citizenship to register to vote, said he had “wiped out” Iran’s military and cautioned against a rise of communism in the United States.

“We like to stop a threat like that immediately and before it begins. It’s like a cancer – you’ve got to cut it out and you got to cut it out fast,” he said.

The Republican president has in the past repeatedly referred to left-wing Democratic candidates who have won a string of primary elections as “communists,” though he did not explicitly do so on Saturday.

Before Trump, presidents generally avoided in-person appearances at July 4 celebrations, but he has blurred the line between official commemoration and campaign-style politics. Aside from a similar address that Trump gave in 2019, no US presi-



(Top) Fireworks during Salute to America, an Independence Day event honouring the nation’s 250th anniversary at the National Mall in Washington, on Sunday; President Donald Trump speaks with First Lady Melania Trump during the fireworks show in Washington. AP



dent has delivered a July 4 speech on the Mall since 1951.

Visitors had waited hours to get into the event, contending with stepped-up security and temperatures that reached 103 degrees Fahrenheit (39 degrees Celsius). The record-breaking heat wave forced the cancellation of several parades and other events in the area.

Authorities ordered an evacuation when a line of thunderstorms approached, forcing spectators to shelter in nearby museums and government buildings before they were allowed to return.

Trump had said this week he would “make a really long speech” for Saturday’s rally “just to show that I can do anything.”

Instead, it lasted less than 40 minutes, far shorter than many of his past speeches.

Other visitors included the white nationalist organization Patriot Front, which marched through the capital earlier in the day and rode on Metro trains serving the region. Police said they had not received any reports of violence.

The Trump administration’s Freedom 250 group has largely sidelined a nonpartisan body set up in 2016 to handle the 250th anniversary and has fenced off much of the 2.4-km Mall for a “Great American State Fair” featuring attractions such as a Ferris wheel alongside displays by conservative groups and defence contractors.

Vessel removed from New York ship parade over political banners

New York: The US Coast Guard said “politically charged” messages led to the removal of an environmental group’s vessel from a fleet of sailing ships gathered in New York Saturday to celebrate the country’s 250th anniversary.

A ship owned by the Hudson River Sloop Clearwater environmental organization was forced out of the Sail4th 250 parade in New York Harbor, the Coast Guard said in a statement emailed to Reuters. The ship had banners that read, “Save the Clean Water Act” and “Indigenous Rights, Racial Justice, Climate Solutions”.

Participants in the event had agreed to refrain from displaying political or politically charged messages or statements, according to the Coast Guard, which said it enforced the agreement on behalf of Sail4th. REUTERS

Trump offers to help Putin, Zelenskyy find a way to end Ukraine war

Reuters
July 5

US PRESIDENT Donald Trump, speaking to Russian leader Vladimir Putin by telephone for nearly 90 minutes, offered to help find a solution to the Ukraine war, Kremlin aide Yuri Ushakov said in comments made public early on Sunday.

Ushakov said Trump made the offer during the call on Saturday, US Independence Day, in the context of his participation next week at the NATO summit in Turkey. “The American president once again confirmed his readiness to work towards a rapid end to the fighting and find solutions to overcome the crisis,” Ushakov said of Trump’s call with Putin.

Ushakov, who described the conversation as “business-like and quite constructive,” said Russia sought “a political-diplomatic resolution of the conflict, with due account of Russia’s fundamental approach.”

Ushakov accused Kyiv and



(Left) Volodymyr Zelenskyy, Vladimir Putin. FILE

its European allies of “counting on extending and even escalating the conflict, and on terrorism against civilians.” He was referring to Ukraine’s long-range strikes on Russian targets, mainly linked to the oil industry, which have triggered fuel shortages in several Russian regions.

Ushakov said Putin “depicted the real situation on the battlefield where the Russian armed forces are confidently advancing, liberating one locality after another.”

Meanwhile, Zelenskyy described his conversation with the US president as “very good,” saying: “There is a real prospect to end this war and American resolve will have a crucial meaning.”

11-year-old to face trial for shopping plaza fire which killed 72 in Karachi

Karachi: An 11-year-old boy will stand trial after being named as an accused in the chargesheet filed by police related to the fire incident that killed 72 people at a shopping complex in Karachi in January.

The inferno gutted the Gul Plaza shopping plaza on Karachi’s famous M A Jinnah Road in the commercial Saddar area on January 17 and it took a week for firefighters and rescue teams to bring it under control.

The chargesheet filed on Saturday named the boy as an accused along with his father and four others, who are all absconding since the fire broke out.

The minor was managing an artificial flower shop in the shopping complex in his father’s absence and allegedly started the fire while playing with matchsticks, according to prosecution witnesses.

District Prosecutor Abdul Razzaq Gujjar said that the boy will be tried in court along with the four others named in the chargesheet. PTI



Control, Alt, Goal

Humanoid robots compete during a Large Division final match between Team Hephaestus of Tsinghua University and Team Mountain and Sea of China Agricultural University at the RoboCup 2026 international robot competition in Incheon, South Korea, on Sunday. REUTERS

4 kids among 8 killed in shooting near New York’s Coney Island

New York: A shooting at a Fourth of July cookout near New York’s Coney Island beach wounded eight people, including four children, police said.

One of the victims, a 21-year-old woman, was in critical condition while the others were described as being stable and expected to survive, Police Commissioner Jessica Tisch said Sunday.

The shooting broke out Saturday night in the courtyard of an apartment building about a block from the famed Coney Island boardwalk and not far from the site of the Nathan’s Famous hot dog eating contest held earlier on the holiday.

The police commissioner said a suspect wearing a black mask fired into the courtyard where a family had gathered for a cookout. The shooter fled but police did recover a gun, Tisch said. The four children shot are ages 6, 7, 12 and 14, Tisch added.

There were no reports of any earlier disturbances at the gathering, she said. AP

• BRIEFLY

NORTH KOREA

Kim observes weapons tests from his new naval destroyer



The destroyer Kang Kon during a military drill at an undisclosed location.

NORTH KOREAN leader Kim Jong Un observed the test firing of a strategic cruise missile and evaluations of anti-ship, anti-submarine and air defence systems aboard the naval destroyer Kang Kon, state media KCNA reported on Sunday. The tests were conducted on Friday as part of an assessment of the newly built warship’s combat systems. They included checks of target-detection and information-processing capabilities, KCNA said. REUTERS

CONGO

20 killed after boat capsizes

A WOODEN boat transporting students back from state exams sank in central Congo, killing at least 20 people, authorities said. “There were 80 survivors and 20 bodies,” said Francois Kabula, administrator of the Ilebo territory in Kasai province, where the incident happened Friday. AP

NEPAL

2 Indians held with marijuana

TWO INDIAN nationals were arrested in separate incidents in Nepal for allegedly possessing marijuana, police said Sunday. Hari Chhetri, 57, of West Bengal, was held at Kathmandu airport with 2.8 kg after arriving from Bangkok. Raju Nishad, 36, of Uttar Pradesh, was held with 2 kg. PTI

• ACTORS BRADLEY COOPER, HUGH GRANT & ETHAN HAWKE, MODELS GIGI HADID & KARLIE KLOSS, COMIC CHRIS ROCK, DIRECTOR STEVEN SPIELBERG REPORTED TO HAVE BEEN SEEN AT GALA EVENT

No phones, ban on social media: Taylor Swift, Travis Kelce wed in a garden ceremony

Associated Press
New York, July 5

TAYLOR SWIFT and Travis Kelce married Friday night at Madison Square Garden, where actor Adam Sandler was the surprising officiant at a ceremony and Stevie Nicks performed among a crowd packed with stars of sports and entertainment. The deep secrecy that surrounded the buildup to the nuptials lifted when a marquee outside the Midtown Manhattan arena proclaimed “JUST&T MARRIED” once the deed was done.

The couple did not have bridesmaids or groomsmen, instead having Swift’s younger

brother Austin Swift serve as her man of honor with Kelce’s big brother and podcast co-host Jason Kelce his best man, Swift’s publicist Tree Paine said in an email.

The bride and groom’s outfits came from Christian Dior Haute Couture and its designer Jonathan Anderson with shoes custom-made by Christian Louboutin. She wore Cartier jewelry.

The long anticipated union of sports and song brought hype to new heights at a venue made more for historic NBA games and bucket-list concerts. The Kansas City Chiefs’ superstar tight end and the music megastar married as fans and spectators gathered outside in blister-

ing heat, eager to be part of the occasion, even though the event was almost entirely hidden.

Actors Bradley Cooper, Zoë Kravitz, Hugh Grant and Ethan Hawke; models Gigi Hadid and Karlie Kloss; comic Chris Rock; director Steven Spielberg; singer Camila Cabello and author Jenny Han were among the guests from the world of arts and entertainment.

Kelce’s coach Andy Reid and Chiefs teammates including running back Kareem Hunt were among the sports figures in the arena, along with retired NFL superstar Tom Brady, Seattle Seahawks receiver and recent Super Bowl champ Cooper Kupp, New York Giants receiver



A Just Married sign is displayed at Madison Square Garden in New York after the wedding of singer Taylor Swift and NFL player Travis Kelce on Saturday; Taylor and Travis at a NFL match in 2025. AP

JuJu Smith-Schuster and ESPN personalities Joe Buck and Stephen A. Smith.

In a culture obsessed with

famous couplings it may have been the apex celebrity wedding, with perhaps only royal unions getting more attention.



Holding such a ceremony in a huge, iconic space that sits at the center of the US media universe while keeping all the de-

tails secret made for a surreal scene, but it was a mix of hype and hush that is not out of character for Swift.

An Associated Press camera outside the arena showed a long line of black SUVs dropping off wedding-goers in tuxedos and evening gowns, surrounded by New Yorkers in shorts and Swifties amassing for the occasion. Rain briefly cut the heat shortly after the marriage was announced.

There was a seemingly total lack of social media posts from guests once they had entered the arena, with phones apparently banned. However, on Saturday, hosts of *Good Morning America* who had been invited

to the wedding, confirmed that Nicks performed and described the space as “intimate.”

“As intimate as it could possibly be given it was Madison Square Garden. Really this garden inside the garden, just so beautiful,” said George Stephanopoulos. “It’s hard to imagine a place that big and a wedding with such stars could feel so personal and so intimate.”

Robin Roberts added that both Swift and Kelce wrote their own vows.

Weddings have been a constant subject in Swift’s songs since she was a teenager, and her actually walking the aisle for the first time at age 36 added to the drama.

MONDAY, JULY 6, 2026



The Indian EXPRESS

JOURNALISM of COURAGE

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Happening today

● **ALLAHABAD HIGH COURT** is set to hear a writ petition seeking a survey of the Taj Mahal to examine a claim that a temple originally existed on the monument's premises.

TRACK THIS AND MORE ON WWW.INDIANEXPRESS.COM

POLITICS

DR SYAMA PRASAD MOOKERJEE: A LIFE DEVOTED TO INDIA'S UNITY & PROGRESS
By PM NARENDRA MODI
PAGE 8

Business as Usual

By EP UNNY



Diljit Dosanjh's *Satluj* pulled from ZEE5 in India two days after release

Kamaldeep Singh Brar & Alaka Sahani
Amritsar, Mumbai, July 5

JUST TWO days after it premiered on streaming service ZEE5, Diljit Dosanjh-starrer *Satluj*, a film based on the life of human rights activist Jaswant Singh Khalsa, has been made unavailable in India.

In a social media statement on Sunday, ZEE5 said, "In light of the current developments, *Satluj* will be unavailable in India until further notice. We remain committed to exploring every appropriate avenue through due process to bring the film back to our audiences at the earliest opportunity."

Directed by Honey Trehan and produced by Ronnie Screwvala's RSVP alongside MacGuffin Pictures, *Satluj* was released on ZEE5 on July 3 after certification troubles held up the film for around three years.

While it has now been pulled from India, the film remains available to stream abroad through ZEE5 Global.

Director Trehan told *The Indian Express*, "I got to know about the removal of *Satluj* from ZEE5 in India at around 8.15 pm on Sunday. I am at a loss right now. I don't know how to react to this development."

In a statement on its official X account, ZEE5 thanked viewers for what it described as an overwhelming response since the release of the movie, and said that it stood by "the

»CONTINUED ON PAGE 2

AGNIPATH SCHEME

Armed Forces seek larger retention of Agniveers after end of 4-yr tenure

Navy likely to seek 75% retention, Army and IAF up to 50%; current retention for each arm is 25%

Amrita Nayak Dutta
New Delhi, July 5

THE ARMED Forces are seeking an increase in the percentage of Agniveers who can be retained in the services after completing their four-year tenure, even as the overall percentage agreed upon remains 25 per cent for each of the three services at present.

Agniveers recruited under



The initial batches of Agniveers recruited under the Agnipath scheme will complete their 4-year tenure with the services later this year. PTI FILE

the Agnipath scheme began their training in early 2023. The initial batches of Agniveers will complete their four-year tenure with the services later this year. All of them would initially

be released from the services, and the selected number of Agniveers who volunteer to serve in the defence forces would be enrolled back as regular

»CONTINUED ON PAGE 2

Behind the move: More experienced manpower, training on new platforms

Amrita Nayak Dutta
New Delhi, July 5

THE KEY reason why the Armed Forces are seeking an increase in the percentage of Agniveers who can be retained after completion of their four-year tenure is the need for a bigger pool of experienced troops in the services, particularly in the event of a conflict.

This, people familiar with the matter told *The Indian Express*, was among the lessons learnt from Operation Sindoor

last year.

While the Agniveers performed extremely well in operations, there were instances when experience gained across various field tenures and multiple training exercises came in handy, in terms of faster and more effective reactions in operational situations.

With a constant number of soldiers retiring every year, a lower retention of Agniveers might lead to a shortfall of manpower in the

»CONTINUED ON PAGE 2

SAVES ON WATER, LABOUR COST

Direct-seeded rice gains traction among farmers amid El Nino shadow on monsoon



A farm worker transplants paddy seedlings at a field on the Delhi-Haryana border. HARISH DAMODARAN

Harish Damodaran
New Delhi, July 5

FOR BASMATI paddy grower Satyavan Sehrawat, the two biggest challenges are water and labour.

The traditional method of cultivating the cereal grain crop — by puddling (flooding the field and tilling repeatedly to break down soil clods, plug large pores and create a soft seedbed) and transplantation (of seedlings initially raised in nurseries) — is highly water-intensive.

"Puddling itself consumes water equivalent to three irrigations. For the first three weeks

after transplanting, the field has to be irrigated every second day to maintain a standing water depth of 4-5 cm. You need to irrigate even thereafter once a week," said the 56-year-old Sehrawat, who farms basmati on 50 out of his 54-acre holding in Delhi's Daryapur Kalan village.

Depending on the crop's duration (115-120 days from seed to grain for Pusa Basmati-1509 and 140-145 days for Pusa Basmati-1121), and also how much it rains, the total irrigations can be anywhere between 20 and 30. Each irrigation uses over 200,000 litres of water per acre.

»CONTINUED ON PAGE 2



'As long as you do not overpower us, we are equal. That message is very strong within Assam'

HIMANTA BISWA SARMA, ASSAM CM **PAGE 14**



Mumbai rain fury continues: 7 dead

Seven people were killed as heavy rainfall continued to affect life in Mumbai, Sunday. While six people were killed after a building collapsed in Mankhurd, one died after a tree fell on him in Kurla. **AKASH PATIL**

SUNDAY'S CASUALTIES took the death toll in rainfall-related incidents in Mumbai to 10 in less than a week.

THE IMD's five-day forecast issued on Sunday has declared an orange alert for the city on Monday.

THE AUTHORITIES declared a holiday for all schools and colleges in Mumbai, Thane and Palghar on Monday. **PAGE 9**

LAMINE YAMAL FACES CRISTIANO RONALDO

In Spain vs Portugal, a star racing future vs a superstar chasing past



Sandip G
Philadelphia, July 5

ALL HIS life, Lionel Messi's shadow has loomed over Lamine Yamal. He was just an infant when a photographer arranged a shoot wherein Messi was bathing Yamal. Years later, when he stepped into Barcelona's La Masia Academy, he was



Lamine Yamal, 18, is the youngest goal-scorer in a World Cup since Pele; Ronaldo, 41, is the oldest ever in the knockouts. **AP**

Messi's blessed inheritor, the wunderkind beyond his years. Every record he broke in the league was once the Argentine's.

But in the wee hours of Tuesday in India, when Spain



takes on Portugal in a World Cup knockout game, the silhouette behind Yamal will not be that of Messi. It will be of Messi's grand rival, another

»CONTINUED ON PAGE 2

EXPRESS special

Panel probing Kota maternal deaths flags lapses in monitoring, infection control

Oxytocin was under scanner earlier; now experts say that may not be reason behind deaths

Anonna Dutt
New Delhi, July 5

AN EIGHT-member expert committee, set up by the Rajasthan government to probe the recent maternal deaths, has flagged several procedural lapses, including poor monitoring of high-risk pregnancies, insufficient medical treatment records and gaps in infection control mechanisms. *The Indian Express* has learnt.

Earlier, the World Health Organisation (WHO) had sought information on the possible link to ineffective oxytocin — an injection used to induce labour and to contract the uterus for preventing blood loss after delivery. The Rajasthan Drug Testing Laboratory had found a batch ineffective, saying tests revealed that the injections contained no trace of oxytocin, its active ingredient.

Additionally, the licences of the units of Jackson Laboratories, the manufacturer of oxytocin, in Punjab and Himachal Pradesh were cancelled for



At New Medical College Hospital in Kota, one of the hospitals which saw maternal deaths. PARUL KULSHRESTHA

non-compliance of a 2023 order to stop production. Sources said the current inspections found widespread irregularities, including the absence of evidence of key tests regarding drug purity, and proof of data fudging.

The Union Health Ministry had sought a detailed report on women developing complications following caesarean operations across several government hospitals in Rajasthan.

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NATION **PAGE 9**
LEGENDARY PANDAVANI SINGER TEEJAN BAI DIES AT 69

RAM TEMPLE DONATION 'THEFT' ROW

Trust meeting today, treasurer distances himself: 'Catch guilty, give strict punishment'

Maulshree Seth
Ayodhya, July 5

SIGNALLING DEEPENING discontent within the Shri Ram Janmabhoomi Teerth Kshetra Trust over the alleged embezzlement of donations at the Ram Temple in Ayodhya, its treasurer Swami Govind Dev Giri sought to distance himself from the controversy and called for strict action against those responsible, irrespective of their position.

In the first detailed public response by a senior functionary of the Trust on the controversy, Giri also sought to separate his statutory responsibilities as treasurer from the day-to-day handling of donations and financial administration. In a two-page statement, he asserted that his responsibility



Ram temple Trust treasurer Swami Govind Dev Giri. FILE

POLITICS **PAGE 8**
AS TRUST MEETS, RSS KEEPS WATCH

was limited to maintaining audited accounts and records.

"The police and investigating agencies should catch the guilty. No matter how big the

»CONTINUED ON PAGE 2

● **PROTEST CROSSES FORTNIGHT MARK, WITH LEADING POLITICAL AND CULTURAL FIGURES HAVING VISITED JANTAR MANTAR TO EXTEND SUPPORT**

One night at CJP protest: Crash course in politics & an ex-mail worker's dream

Drishti Jain
New Delhi, July 5

AROUND 3 am Saturday, at Jantar Mantar in the heart of Delhi, Vikas Kumar opens his small bag and pulls out a crumpled A4 sheet announcing his political party. The 20-year-old, wearing a white kurta with a blue scarf around his shoulder, stands with folded hands. The sheet carries his picture which, he says, is enhanced with AI. He runs his finger down it: "Apna Bharat Sena Party-ABS Party", it reads.

For the past 15 days, Kumar, from Hajipur in Bihar, has been part of the Cockroach Janta

Party (CJP) protest demanding the resignation of Union Education Minister Dharmendra Pradhan over the NEET exam paper leak. Now, he is preparing to start his own political party.

Kumar is one among several volunteers — from artists to workers — for whom the protest site has also become a "political classroom" of sorts.

On the stage, activist Sonam Wangchuk, who is on a hunger strike, and CJP founder Abhijeet Dipke, sleep with a table fan for relief. Others lie on thick black sheets on the floor. A few fan their neighbours with plastic fans, while many sit in circles, ex-

changing ideas with strangers about everything under the moon.

Kumar, for his part, is busy learning. "Just like people pay money to take courses in digital marketing and computers, I'm doing a course in politics here. I get food and a place to sleep. It's been 15 days since I started the 'course'. Once it's over, I'll become a politician. Already 17 people have joined my party here," he says.

After completing a polytechnic course at Ambala in Haryana, Kumar says he moved to Noida for a job at a hardware firm and has since switched jobs across Delhi-NCR. On June 19, he left his



The protesters at Jantar Mantar on Saturday night. ABHINAV SAHA

"supervisor job" at a mall in Gurgaon to join the protest.

"My family's financial condition is not good, so I had to

start earning. I know the value of education and how important it is to reach higher. Rich fathers can hand over estab-

lished businesses to their children, while middle and lower-class parents struggle to even give an education. When I become a politician, I won't become rich, but I'll have the power to raise the voice of these people," he says.

"Here, I'm meeting people who have studied arts. They have ideologies and different views, and they are patient in their approach. They think deeply. I'm watching and learning. I take decisions impulsively," he says, before playing a 3-minute-20-second AI-generated video of his "party's roadshow" in Bihar, adding that his friends in his village are more excited than he is.

The protest, which started after Dipke arrived in Delhi from the US, has crossed the fortnight mark. So far, prominent figures who have visited the venue to extend support include author Arundhati Roy, CPM leaders Brinda Karat and John Brittas, Swaraj India founder Yogendra Yadav and AAP leader Sanjay Singh.

The fight will continue, say volunteers, even as the silence of the night is broken by chatter, chalk scraping on canvases, songs and slogans demanding the Minister's resignation.

At the first stall near the stage, Zahid, who says he travelled two days from Baramulla in Kashmir to reach the

site, is joined by two friends from Sopore and Srinagar. The 32-year-old wears a white T-shirt printed with the image of a cockroach and has a card hanging from his left wrist that reads "Volunteer Marshal". Past midnight, he is still serving food and water to supporters on site, along with others.

Zahid says he could not make it to Delhi for the June 6 CJP protest but managed to reach the site after the extended agitation started at Jantar Mantar on June 20. "I came across the party's social media page on May 15 and felt it was right, after reading the demands," he says.

»CONTINUED ON PAGE 2

Six fishermen go missing at sea, search underway off Visakhapatnam

Sreenivas Janyala
Hyderabad, July 5

AT LEAST six fishermen are missing off the coast of Visakhapatnam after a fishing boat reportedly developed a mechanical fault in the Bay of Bengal, prompting the Andhra Pradesh government to seek the assistance of the Indian Coast Guard in the search operation.

The fishermen are from Bhogapuram in Vizianagaram district and Bheemunipatnam (Bheemili) in Visakhapatnam district.

According to East Coast Mechanised Fishing Boat Owners Association president V Janakiram, seven fishermen had sailed out of the Visakhapatnam Fishing Harbour on July 1 and were scheduled to return by July 4.

He said that on July 3, officials from the Fisheries Department, Marine Police, port authorities and the boat owners' association contacted the crew and warned them about rough sea conditions due to a low-pressure area over the Bay of Bengal, asking them to return immediately.

"The fishermen informed us that the boat had developed a mechanical problem and was moving very slowly. They assured us they would return by July 4. Since then, we have had no contact with them. Their mobile phones should be within network range by now, but calls are not going through. We are worried, and so are their families. If the engine has failed completely, the boat could be drifting," Janakiram said.

Chief Minister N Chandrababu Naidu on Sunday directed officials to intensify the search

after the crew of a passing ship reported rescuing one person from the sea, but said they did not know the whereabouts of the others.

According to the Chief Minister's Office, the Coast Guard is searching for the missing fishing boat in the Bay of Bengal. Officials said the boat suffered a mechanical failure off the Gangavaram coast.

Search operations involving the Indian Coast Guard, the Navy and the Marine Police, supported by Navy helicopters, have been underway since Sunday morning.

The Chief Minister directed the Marine Inspector General and the Visakhapatnam Commissioner of Police to coordinate the search operation and provide regular updates. He also asked Fisheries Minister K Atchannaidu and local public representatives to extend all possible assistance to the families of the missing fishermen.

Former Chief Minister and YSR Congress Party president Y S Jagan Mohan Reddy also expressed concern over the incident.

In a statement, Jagan urged the state government to intensify the search and deploy additional vessels and helicopters, if required. He also appealed to the government to provide immediate support to the families of the missing fishermen and keep them informed about the progress of the search operation.

Jagan said the YSR Congress Party would stand by the affected families and directed party leaders in the Visakhapatnam region to remain in touch with them and extend all necessary assistance.

Elephant that faced off with tigers, patrolled Kaziranga laid to rest with guard of honour

Sukrita Baruah
Guwahati, July 5

ONE OF Kaziranga National Park's most iconic patrol elephants, 66-year-old Joymala, died on Saturday night and was laid to rest on Sunday with a guard of honour by Forest Department personnel in Kaziranga.

Stories about Joymala's 30 years of service as a patrol elephant are well known in the region.

In 2004, Joymala and its then 25-year-old mahout Satyaban Pegu were part of a team from the Assam Forest Department on the lookout for a large tigress that had killed cattle in a village close to the boundary of the national park. In a series of events well recorded and remembered among those who work in wildlife, the tigress at one point leapt towards Joymala's head while the elephant was carrying the range officer, a veterinarian, and a guard on its back, along with its mahout. A record of the incident by the Wildlife Trust of India says the tigress swiped at Pegu, injuring him, and did not land on Joymala, who stepped back. It says that as the tigress landed on the ground, Joymala tried to pin it

down with a foot, and the tigress struggled loose and ran away in the ensuing commotion.

A video of the incident, taken by the then divisional forest officer, R K Das, who was riding on another elephant just behind them, went on to be widely viewed.

Pegu, however, lost three of his fingers in the incident, bringing an end to his time as a mahout. However, Joymala continued as a patrol elephant for over 15 years, under the care of another mahout, Nilakhanta Koch, participating in anti-poaching patrols, wildlife monitoring, rescue operations, and routine forest protection duties.

"The elephants are not engaged in active duties after they cross 60 years of age, but she was in the camp post-retirement and was a motherly figure for younger calves. At least three of her own calves are currently patrol elephants in the national park," said current DFO Arun Vignesh.

According to a statement by the national park, the elephant died on Saturday night at the Naloni area under Agoratori Range of the national park, after being treated for illness for nearly a year.

[FROM PAGE 1 | FULL REPORTS ON WWW.INDIANEXPRESS.COM]

Agniveer retention

soldiers based on merit.

It has been learnt that the Navy will likely seek a higher retention percentage of sailors who joined under the scheme at around 75 per cent, while the Army and the IAF might seek an increase to around 50 per cent from the current 25 per cent.

The defence forces have maintained so far that the retention percentage remains at 25 per cent at present.

The Indian Express sent queries to the Army, Navy and IAF on July 1 on whether they are seeking to retain a greater percentage of Agniveers in the three services and the reasons for that, but is yet to receive any response.

The need for more retention has been felt keeping in view the requirement of a larger pool of trained and experienced soldiers, who have participated in multiple operations over the last four years and are experienced in handling new technologies and weapons.

This is likely to be discussed further between the services and the Department of Military Affairs (DMA) to explore feasible options.

According to sources, even if an increase in the retention percentages of Agniveers is not approved, certain specialised units might induct a higher percentage of soldiers from among the retained Agniveers, who are more experienced, while other units may take a larger number of soldiers from among the Agniveers who will still be serving their four-year tenure.

This may be done while keeping the overall retention

percentage at 25 per cent, which is the current approved percentage.

For instance, the newly raised Bhairav battalions of the Army may eventually have a larger percentage of retained soldiers as compared to regular infantry battalions, which might have a larger percentage of Agniveers undergoing their four-year tenure.

A proposal seeking higher retention percentages had been forwarded to DMA in the past, but was returned for re-evaluation.

People privy to the development said the training of soldiers, sailors and airmen under the Agnipath scheme has been underway in full swing in all services.

In the last training year, around 70,000 Agniveers were undergoing training in the Army alone, across all regimental centres. In the next training year, around 90,000 vacancies are

likely to be released to increase the recruitment of Agniveers in the Army.

By increasing the number of vacancies for Agniveers progressively over the next two years, the Army plans to make up for the shortfall of around 1.8 lakh troops in the force, The Indian Express had reported in November last year.

In the last four years, a series of MoUs with various banks have been signed towards various schemes for the Agniveers. Their allowances, such as leave, are also at par with regular soldiers.

In October last year, *The Indian Express* reported that Army Commanders would likely discuss the retention percentage of Agniveers at the Army Commanders' Conference that month. In response to the report, the Army subsequently said that such a plan did not feature in the official agenda of the conference.

Kota maternal deaths

with some resulting in casualties.

Five women died after undergoing caesarean deliveries in Kota in May; seven others had severe complications, some requiring dialysis after suffering kidney failure. This was followed by two more deaths in June, after six women developed kidney failure in Bikaner. Also in June, two women developed complications after undergoing C-sections in Paota, Jodhpur. The Rajasthan authorities have denied a link between the deaths.

In its report submitted in June-end, the eight-member panel blamed procedural lapses in managing high-risk pregnancies. "We also note that clinical presentations are different in almost all cases... drugs leading to any reaction or causing shock is negligible. Committee views that absence of active pharmaceutical ingredient oxytocin cannot be attributed mortality," it said.

The report, reviewed by *The Indian Express*, said the women died of different medical conditions, with no single common cause linking the deaths. Instead, it flagged poor monitoring of high-risk pregnancies, missing treatment records, deficiency in taking informed consent, and poor infection control.

"There were several factors that led to these deaths and the committee has recommended improving the protocols in the hospitals. While both hospitals (in Kota) do see such deaths as they tend to receive the most complicated cases, unfortunately, the deaths were clustered

and therefore got highlighted," Gayatri Rathore, Rajasthan's principal health secretary, told *The Indian Express*.

The findings

The report, based on review of clinical records of 12 women who died or developed severe complications, also analysed the report of a separate six-member committee from AIIMS.

According to the state committee's report, the AIIMS report raised some "major points of concern" regarding sterilisation and OT infection control practices, post-operative critical care monitoring deficiencies, pharmacovigilance, drug storage and administration related practices. "These need to be taken cognizance of and followed up to adhere to protocols," it said.

The state committee noted that the cause of death was different in all cases. According to the report:

- At J K Lone Hospital in Kota, one woman died due to a pre-existing heart disease, and another due to complications from excessive blood loss in postpartum haemorrhage.
- At New Medical College Hospital in Kota, one woman died due to pulmonary embolism caused by disseminated intravascular coagulation, a condition where the body's clotting mechanism goes into overdrive which led to a clot in the pulmonary artery in this case.
- Another woman at the Kota hospital died of hypovolemic shock, a condition in which severe blood loss causes multiple organ failure, including kidney failure.
- A third death at the same

hospital was due to chorioamnionitis, where a stitch on the cervix to prevent premature birth led to infection of the membranes surrounding the foetus and amniotic fluid.

The report also flagged lapses in record-keeping at the hospitals, including inadequate notes on the patient's history, treatment given, monitoring data on parameters like blood pressure and pulse rate. "This is noted not only in clinical case notes but also in operation theatre notes and nursing documentation," it said. "There is an urgent need to strengthen record-keeping practices," it said.

"An assumption is being made that routine checks were not performed since none of them has been recorded," said a person privy to the matter.

The committee also found that the hospitals were using pre-printed clinical notes and treatment orders. "Such practices are not consistent with accepted standards of individualised patient care," it noted.

It also found deficiencies in the process for getting informed consent. "There is a need to strengthen the consent process to ensure that procedure-specific risks, benefits, alternatives and potential complications are clearly explained and documented," the report said.

The committee found these deficiencies were a matter of routine practice in these hospitals. "Certain protocols related to obstetric emergency care, post-operative monitoring, and management of high-risk pregnancies require review," it said.

Based on the findings of the AIIMS committee, which included a microbiology expert, the state committee noted that while there was no evidence to link the deaths to infection ac-

quired in the hospital, there was a need to strengthen infection control practices. The AIIMS committee had flagged gaps in infection control mechanisms.

The hospitals also did not have mechanisms to monitor the availability, inventory, and use of various drugs, the state committee said. It underlined the need for SOPs on "procurement, storage, maintenance, dispensing, and monitoring of drugs and consumables." "In no case there has been any mention of having been given additional oxytocic or uterotonic medications as per clinical records," it said.

"There is also conspicuous absence of protocols for storage and infusion of blood products," the report said.

Dr T Shubhamangala, head of the Rajasthan committee and assistant mission director of Rajasthan's National Health Mission, did not respond to phone calls.

Dr Hrishikesh Pai, former president of the Federation of Obstetric and Gynaecological Societies of India, said: "Unless the deaths can be conclusively linked to faulty oxytocin by a death review committee, we have to assume they happened because of complications of high-risk pregnancies. These numbers are not unlikely for bigger hospitals that usually receive the most complicated cases".

He said an important indicator of whether these deaths were unusual would be a spike in maternal mortality rates. While the New Medical College Hospital in Kota recorded 14 maternal deaths in 2025, there have been three deaths so far this year. J K Lone Hospital in Kota recorded 25 maternal deaths in 2025 and four so far this year.

CJP

Struggling to adapt to the Capital's weather, the construction contractor says it was unbearable at first, but the nightly discussions have kept him going. "Sometimes they call me over there, sometimes over here, as if I've known them for a long time," he says, adding that his worried family calls him several times a day.

Having rented a room for Rs 1,800 a day in Lajpat Nagar, he says he only goes there at 7 in the morning to freshen up and sleep a little before returning, stressing how much he wants to "learn from the field".

Asked about the protests he took part in Kashmir, Zahid laughs. "It is safe to protest in Delhi, at least I feel it is," he says.

"In Kashmir, even when we protest on the road, police stand right opposite us. There, we would be able to protest for half-an-hour or an hour at most. After that, there would be stone-pelting, pellet guns, tear gas... It's different here. Here, people are listening, they're letting us speak, everyone notices what's happening," he says.

As the clock marks 3.30 am amid rising humidity, a few people leave while others settle in, as police personnel occasionally walk by.

For Vinod (28), a student at Delhi University and a member of the collective Progressive Artists' League, his three nights at the site have taught him "a lot" about things he "just knew but never discussed". "CJP must have a different perspective, but we are seeing how this opens a larger platform under an umbrella issue. A movement has now made young people, students and older generations, who genuinely care about the education system, slowly start pouring in."

More manpower

forces in the immediate future, although officials have maintained that the issue will be resolved in a few years.

Agniveers recruited under the Agnipath scheme began their training in early 2023. The initial batches of Agniveers will complete their four-year tenure with the services later this year.

Before that, the Armed Forces are seeking an increase in the percentage of Agniveers who can be retained in the services after completing their four-year tenure, even as the defence forces have emphasised that the overall percentage agreed upon remains 25 per cent for each service at present.

Sources said significant procurement of new technologies, modern platforms, and equipment following Operation Sindoor has created a growing need for extended specialised training on these systems. To ensure that soldiers gain sufficient experience, it may be necessary for them to train on these systems for longer durations.

This will be particularly relevant for the sailors in the Navy and certain airmen and soldiers, who are trained to handle highly technical equipment and weapon systems.

Retaining a greater percentage of Agniveers will balance the need for keeping a younger

profile for the manpower across the three services, while also having adequately experienced personnel in the Armed Forces, sources said.

There are other factors as well. Longer tenures as soldiers, particularly in the initial years in the forces, are considered to build better camaraderie between colleagues when they go through hardships and difficult tenures together.

Former Army chief General Upendra Dwivedi, in an interview with *The Indian Express* last month, said the Agnipath scheme should be seen as a major manpower reform aimed at making the Army younger, more energetic, disciplined and future-ready, and that the Agniveers are making a positive contribution to the Indian Army.

(ten times the nursery area). Nor is there need for puddling and flooding of fields.

In DSR, the paddy seeds are directly sown in the main field, just like wheat. In transplanted paddy fields, the standing water acts as a natural herbicide, depriving weeds of oxygen and sunlight for their seeds to germinate or already-emerged seedlings to survive. Continuous flooding is necessary to prevent weed growth, especially during the crop's early stage.

DSR basically replaces water with chemical herbicides. It means growing paddy varieties or hybrids that can "tolerate" their application — in this case, of Imazethapyr, a herbicide that controls a wide spectrum of grassy and broadleaf weeds.

The normal Pusa-1509 and Pusa-1121 varieties Sehrawat cultivates cannot "tolerate" Imazethapyr, as the chemical does not distinguish the crop from the weeds and ends up killing both. What he is, however, growing now are Pusa Basmati-1985 and

Pusa Basmati-1979. These are the Imazethapyr herbicide-tolerant (HT) versions of the same popular basmati varieties bred by the Indian Agricultural Research Institute (IARI) in New Delhi.

The HT varieties have been developed through non-genetically modified mutation breeding, involving altering the ALS (acetolactate synthase) gene. This is a gene naturally present in rice plants and not introduced from soil bacteria and other unrelated species (as with genetically-modified Bt cotton or hybrid mustard).

"The ALS gene codes for an enzyme responsible for the synthesis of leucine, isoleucine and valine, which are essential amino acids for plant growth and development. Imazethapyr sprayed on normal paddy binds itself to the ALS enzyme, inhibiting the production of these amino acids," explained A K Singh, former IARI director.

The two HT basmati varieties bred by him and fellow

Trust treasurer

accused may be, they should be brought before the court and given strict punishment without regard to their name or position," he said.

Giri's statement came a day after Ayodhya's Sant Mandal sought to fix accountability on the Trust's treasurer over the alleged irregularities.

"I have never sought or made any effort to obtain any position," Giri said, adding that he had accepted the responsibility of treasurer "only as a service to Lord Ram". He said he visits Ayodhya "only once every one-and-a-half to two months" because of religious engagements across the country, and has never claimed reimbursement for his travel or stay.

"My responsibility is limited to maintaining audited records of income and expenditure; accepting donations, operating bank accounts or authorising payments is not part of my role... As treasurer, all audited records of income and expenditure from the beginning have been securely maintained and can be examined by authorised agencies at any time," he said.

Explaining the accounting system, Giri said the Trust's chartered accountants and full-time accounting staff maintain and verify the accounts every month, while he reviews the audited records during his periodic visits.

Seeking to distance himself from devotees' offerings, Giri said, "Since becoming a trustee,

I have never personally accepted any cash donation or material offering for the temple from anyone." He said the only exceptions were donations from two close relatives — Rs 11,000 from his late elder sister and a 9-kg silver brick from another relative — both of which were immediately deposited with the Trust.

Giri said the Trust's financial dealings are conducted entirely through the banking system. "An expenditure on behalf of the Ram Temple is made directly through banks. We do not have a chequebook, and no payments are made in cash; all transactions are through bank transfers," he said, adding that he was not an authorised signatory to any bank account of the Trust and had no role in approving payments.

On the management of donation boxes, Giri said, "Since the beginning, I have never had any connection with the place where offerings deposited in the donation boxes by devotees are counted."

According to him, the opening of donation boxes, counting of cash and valuables, and documentation of collections are carried out under an SoP prepared jointly with the State Bank of India, and he had personally witnessed the process only once, during a visit last month.

Acknowledging that the controversy had shaken the faith of devotees, Giri proposed strengthening the Trust's administrative framework.

Football

great, and a voluminous record-setter in league and world football: Cristiano Ronaldo.

It's tempting to pin the encounter as a clash of eras, of generations, a marker to measure how football has changed between Ronaldo's first World Cup in 2006 and Yamal's in 2026. But look closer, and you find two similar personalities when they were 18.

Yamal is the boy from Spain's immigrant-heavy Rocafonda. He played football with his large crew of cousins — his father was a painter — and his favourite haunt was his uncle's bakery. Yamal first travelled out of his town when he was eight.

Ronaldo is from the working-class parish of Santo Antonio in Portugal, on the island of Madeira. He grew up sharing a bedroom with his brother and two sisters. His father was a gardener and his mother a cook. He was expelled from school at 14, after he flung a chair at his teacher. He never attended school again. The first time Ronaldo travelled by flight was when he flew to Old Trafford in England, aged 18.

Their spirit isn't much different, either.

Yamal is unlike Messi, the footballing recluse who turned away from bling and bluster. He splurges on parties, inviting lawmakers' wrath for roping in people with dwarfism to serve drinks at his 18th birthday — although he is not as self-obsessed with his looks and hair, or the folds of his jersey, as Ronaldo.

Both hold an affinity for the theatrical. Ronaldo in his nascent Manchester United years was all step-overs and dribbles, a shining gem but with unpolished edges. Awed old-timers of the training grounds gushed in excited tones and rediscovered their George Best reincarnation. Senior pros wondered about the heights he

could reach. His coiled locks were dyed at the edges.

Yamal, too, colours his hair but is seemingly averse to gelling. He strode into the Barcelona dressing room with an aura and an air that he was the best in the world. "He had this presence, the feel and personality of someone who believed he was the best in the world. He wanted to be better at everything," Sergio Busquets, the former Spain international, has said.

After Tuesday's World Cup game, they might never meet on a football field, but they are conjoined by the irresistible quest to produce their best. At this World Cup, Yamal has scored just one goal in four games, even though that was enough to make him the youngest goal-scorer in a World Cup since Pele. Ronaldo, at 41, is the oldest player ever in the tournament's knockout phase, as well as its oldest goal-scorer. Yet neither is the happiest man, each weighed down by contrasting burdens. Yamal's is to become the future great; Ronaldo's is to match his stupendous past. One man wants to leap into the future; the other wants to time-travel.

They have met before, in the Nations League final, where the older man triumphed. Ronaldo spoke sympathetically at the time: "He's going to win a lot of titles, both collective and individual... He's only 17 years old... I repeat: he's a kid with a lot of room for improvement. He's a phenomenon, but we have to leave him alone; that's what ask."

Yamal is careful to sidestep the shadows of both Ronaldo and Messi. "In the end, I think it is better not to compare yourself to anyone. Players like Cristiano Ronaldo did what they did because they wanted to be themselves and not compare themselves to others. I want to build my own path," he has said.

But for one evening in Dallas, it will be Ronaldo's shadow that will fall on Yamal, not Messi's.

Satluj

creative vision behind" the film.

"At ZEE5, we stand firmly by Satluj and the creative vision behind it. We believe powerful storytelling has the ability to inspire, endure and leave a lasting impact. We remain committed to championing authentic and meaningful narratives," the statement said.

"Our commitment to creators and to stories told with conviction, artistic integrity and purpose remains unwavering," it added.

Earlier, before the announcement that the film would be pulled from India, Dosanjh had addressed apprehensions regarding such a situation during a live interaction on social media.

"There was a fear that it could be removed. I think you might have downloaded the movie by now. So, now there is no fear," he had said.

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अजो नित्यः शाश्वतोऽयं पुराणो न हन्यते हन्यमाने शरीरे ॥

The soul has no birth or death. It has no being and hence will never cease to be. The soul is eternal, immortal, and ageless.

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RS 700-CRORE PROCUREMENT CASE LINKED TO CPA, DGHS

Medical supplies fraud: Key suspect who ‘manipulated tenders’ absconding, hunt on

Alok Singh
New Delhi, July 5

THE ANTI-CORRUPTION Branch (ACB) of the Delhi government has conducted multiple raids after Rajiv Rangila, a “supplier and pharmaceutical trader” accused of manipulating tenders linked to the Rs 700-crore procurement fraud case, was found missing from his home in East Delhi’s Laxmi Nagar area, sources told *The Indian Express*.

Rangila (50) was summoned for questioning by the ACB last week in connection with the fraud case linked to the Central Procurement Agency (CPA) and the Directorate General of Health Service (DGHS). After serving him multiple notices, when he failed to appear before the agency, ACB officials launched searches for him across Delhi-NCR, and Uttarakhand, sources said. Rangila has been actively supplying medicines and medical equipment in Delhi and Uttarakhand for over a decade, according to investigators. The agency is also planning to issue a look out circular (LOC) against him, sources added.

Rangila, said officers, is a key suspect in the case. He has been named in the FIR for allegedly creating fake com-

THE MISSING SUSPECT

- Accused of coordinating between govt officials and manufacturers
- Allegedly created fake firms with fictitious owners
- Accused of colluding with manufacturers to fix supply rates, kickbacks
- Tenders allegedly drafted to favour chosen firms

panies and firms using fictitious owners. He is accused of colluding with manufacturers of medical equipment to fix supply rates and the kickbacks that were to be paid back in cash.

“Some of these firms include F Med Devices, Technocrats, Raj Shree, Ashi Surgical and Pharmaceuticals, and M Sahib and Sons Pvt. Ltd. Even as these firms were created with others registered as owners, the actual operator is Rajiv Rangila,” the complaint filed by the Vigilance Department with the ACB states. The ACB converted the complaint into an FIR on June 2.

The alleged irregularities first came to light in May this year when the Vigilance Department conducted raids at the offices of the Central Procurement Agency (CPA), the nodal agency responsible for procuring and supplying medicines, vaccines and medical equipment to Delhi government hospitals and healthcare facilities, following complaints.

Sources said the tender specifications and terms were allegedly drafted to favour chosen firms and fake companies were put on records to create confusion.

Rangila allegedly prepared restrictive specifications in collusion with manufacturers, after which the documents were routed to Dr Vinod Kumar Ranga, Head of Office (HOO) of the CPA, who placed them before the tender committee. Ranga was the first one to be arrested in the case on June 18.

According to the complaint, members of the tender committees were allegedly coerced into approving these tailor-made specifications.

Former DGHS chief Dr Vatsala Aggarwal, who was arrested on June 27 in connection with the case, allegedly gave the final approval to the skewed tender conditions. Along with Aggarwal, Deputy Controller of

Accounts (DCA) Neeraj Chopra was also arrested.

Officials alleged that fake companies controlled by Rangila submitted bills for supplies made to the CPA, and payments were released within one or two days.

As per the complaint, several tenders that have already been awarded and fully paid for continue to appear on the Government e-Marketplace (GeM) portal as “active”, “under process”, or at the stage of “financial bid evaluation”.

According to officials, this modus operandi prevented the public and competing firms from knowing whether a tender had been finalised, who had secured it, and at what rates.

“It has also been informed that payments to medicine suppliers that had been supplying medicines to the CPA/DGHS in previous years have remained pending for the last two years. However, payments for tenders awarded since October, in which Rajiv Rangila is allegedly involved, were made on the same day or the following day,” an official said.

Officials added that Rangila’s family members are also being contacted to ascertain his whereabouts.

DU plans to replace 6 programmes at College of Vocational Studies with ‘more popular’ courses

Vidheesha Kuntamalla
New Delhi, July 5

WITH DU’s undergraduate (UG) admissions currently open, faculty members at the College of Vocational Studies (CVS) have raised concerns against a proposed overhaul to discontinue six UG programmes of Vocational Studies, *The Indian Express* has learnt.

According to minutes of meeting of the college’s Department of Commerce, held on June 26, faculty members discussed the university proposal to discontinue the B.A (Vocational Studies) programmes — Human Resource Management, Marketing Management and Retail Business, Materials Management, Small and Medium Enterprises, and Insurance Management — and replace them with new interdisciplinary B.A programme combinations such as Commerce with Economics, Commerce with Computer Science, Hindi with Commerce, Economics with Mathematics and History with Political Science.

The department unanimously resolved to oppose the move and decided to submit representations to the DU Vice-Chancellor, Dean of Academics and Dean of Admissions “requesting that the existing B.A. (Vocational Studies) programmes be continued”.

The developments follow an earlier decision by the College Staff Council and Govern-



College of Vocational Studies

ing Body. According to the Governing Body minutes dated February 7, the college resolved to discontinue the B.A. (Vocational Studies) in Modern Office Management (MOM) that had 111 sanctioned seats. Those seats were to be redistributed by introducing one additional section of B.Com. (Honours) with 60 seats and increasing seats in B.A. (Honours) English, History and Economics. According to DU’s official curriculum document, “the course aims to prepare the Executive Secretary with proper knowledge of different types of communication and correspondence, presentation skill along with effective reports”.

The row has its origins in a university-wide exercise launched earlier this year. In the wake of persistent seat vacancies since UG admissions were centralised through CUET in 2022, DU constituted a committee to examine if low-demand B.A. programme combinations, particularly in off-campus colleges, could be realigned to improve

seat utilisation.

The committee recommended that colleges reassess discipline combinations where student preferences remained low and merge less popular subjects with more sought-after ones. At DU, previous years’ trends show that Commerce continues to dominate as the most opted-for stream, with B.Com and B.Com (Hons.) consistently emerging as the most preferred UG programmes year after year, drawing lakhs of preference entries during the Common Seat Allocation System (CSAS) choice-filling. Close behind are BA (Hons.) English, along with BA (Hons.) History, Political Science, Economics, and Psychology, which remain the most sought-after arts programmes. B.A. (Hons.) Economics stands out for offering one of the highest number of confirmed seats across DU colleges.

The faculty of CVS, in last month’s meeting, recorded that the existing vocational courses are “in consonance with the spirit and objectives of the National Education Policy (NEP), as they are interdisciplinary, skill-oriented, and enhance the employability of students”, and warned that the proposed restructuring could reduce the department’s teaching workload, “resulting in the loss of approximately 8-10 faculty positions”.

Yet, in a representation submitted to Vice-Chancellor Yogesh Singh on June 29, faculty members claimed that the ex-

ercise has since expanded far beyond what either the college’s statutory bodies or the university had approved.

They contend that proposals are now being pursued to discontinue six vocational programmes and introduce entirely new B.A. programmes — changes they describe as “completely illegal” as they have not received the approvals required from the DU’s statutory authorities, saying: “The employment opportunity in B.A. (Vocational Studies) Programmes are far better than B.A. Programme”.

However in April, the DU Executive Council, recorded that overall, colleges will not change the sanctioned total intake capacity for a programme. “A college may, however, offer additional seats in an existing programme, provided there are adequate faculty members and infrastructural facilities to meet the additional requirements... No new programme will be added and similarly, no existing programme will be discontinued,” it stated.

DU Director of Admissions, Haneet Gandhi, told *The Indian Express*: “Certain courses have been replaced with other programmes, keeping in mind how many students have been opting for them. The courses that have seen less interest have been replaced, and programme combinations have also been rejigged accordingly.... None of these programmes are completely new in DU colleges”

SALUTE THE SOLDIER

141 FIELD REGIMENT (KARGIL) GNR (DMT) JOGAL RAMESH KUMAR VIKAM BHAI
On the occasion of SHAHEEDI DIWAS of Gnr (DMT) Jugal Ramesh Kumar Vikam Bhai of 141 Field Regiment (KARGIL) on 06 July 2026, the Commanding Officer, all ranks, their families and the Buzurgs of the Paltan pay homage to the martyr who made supreme sacrifice for the Nation during OP VIJAY. His valour & heroism continues to inspire all of us. On this day, We pledge to take the name of the paltan to even greater heights and glory in the times to come.

CO & All Ranks 141 Field Regiment (KARGIL) GORKHA RIFLES 9418956A LNK TIKA DHWOJ LAWATI
No 9418956A Lnk Tika Dhwoj Lawati 1/11 Gorkha Rifles (BATALIK) had made the supreme sacrifice during ‘OP VIJAY’ (Kargil) in 1999 in a true act of valour. The brave soldier will always be remembered for his raw courage and indomitable spirit. To this braveheart, we pledge that we shall always be guided by his immortal spirits.

CO AND ALL RANKS, 1/11 GORKHA RIFLES (BATALIK) 14 MAHAR FAMILY
With profound grief and sorrow, we mourn the supreme sacrifice of **459273BW Sep Rishikesh Choubey** who laid down his life in the line of duty on 06 July 2022. A valiant soldier of exceptional courage and devotion to duty, he will always be remembered by entire family of 14 MAHAR for his supreme sacrifice.

BORDER SECURITY FORCE
Director General and all Ranks of Border Security Force remember its gallant Jawans on their Balidan Diwas.

 HEAD CONSTABLE SULTAN ALI 32 BN BSF 13.06.1969 – 06.07.2010	 CONSTABLE K HARI PRASAD 32 BN BSF 15.02.1986 – 06.07.2010	 CONSTABLE HEM RAJ 120 BN BSF 01.04.1966 – 06.07.2001	 CONSTABLE/ TRADESMAN PRASANNA KUMAR DUTTA 08 BN BSF 21.01.1970 – 06.07.1998
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 LANCE NAIK H V VENGGATA 153 BN BSF 01.01.1964 – 06.07.1999	 CONSTABLE RAMAN KUMAR 191 BN BSF 08.07.1976 – 06.07.2019	 CONSTABLE SURENDRA SINGH 121 BN BSF 02.07.1987 – 06.07.2013
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INDO-TIBETAN BORDER POLICE (ITBP)
ITBP salutes its braveheart **Constable Anil Kumar T.** of 4th Battalion, who made the supreme sacrifice in the line of duty on this day in Punjab in 1990.

INDO-TIBETAN BORDER POLICE (ITBP)
ITBP salutes its braveheart **Constable Sai Dass** of 1st Battalion, who made the supreme sacrifice in the line of duty on this day in J&K in 1999.

CENTRAL RESERVE POLICE FORCE
Veer Balidani Naik/Driver Sub Inspector H. S. Negi 81 Bn
DG and all Ranks of CRPF pay solemn tribute to Sub Inspector H. S. Negi of 81 Bn, on deputation with NSG, who made the supreme sacrifice in a fierce encounter with terrorists in Punjab on 6 July 1990. CRPF salutes the braveheart and pledges never to let his sacrifice go in vain.

Veer Balidani Naik/Driver Sohan Singh **RTC- Srinagar** 01-06-1951 To 06-07-1992
Srinagar on 6 July 1992. CRPF salutes the braveheart and pledges never to let his sacrifice go in vain.

Veer Balidani Constable P. N. Mark **42 Bn** 29-11-1961 To 06-07-1996
DG and all Ranks of CRPF pay solemn tribute to Constable P. N. Mark of 42 Bn, who was grievously injured in an encounter with insurgents on 5 July 1996 in Khonsa, Arunachal Pradesh and succumbed to his injuries on 6 July 1996. CRPF salutes the braveheart and pledges never to let his sacrifice go in vain.

HARYANA GYM TRAINER MURDER

2 Lawrence gang members shot dead

Alok Singh
New Delhi, July 5

TWO MEN, allegedly wanted in connection with the murder of a gym trainer in Haryana’s Hansi last month, were shot dead on Sunday during a joint operation by the Delhi Police Special Cell and the Haryana Police Special Task Force (STF), officers said.

The incident occurred in Haryana’s Bahadurgarh after the accused, Parvesh and Himanshu, both residents of Hisar, allegedly opened fire on the police team. Officers said the police retaliated in an act of “self-defence”. Both suspects sustained gunshot injuries during the exchange of fire. They were rushed to a hospital, where doctors declared them

dead on arrival, police added.

An officer said that Parvesh and Himanshu were allegedly members of the Lawrence Bishnoi gang and were following the directions of gangster Anil Pandit, who was operating from abroad. “The duo were wanted in a case registered at the Special Cell and were accused in the Hansi gym trainer murder case.

ADVERTISEMENT NO: 30373/INV REV/2027-28/ST-25

MG ASC HEADQUARTERS NORTHERN COMMAND, UDHAMPUR:

SHOWCASING AND DISPLAY OF SPECIAL RATION ITEMS FOR ADDITION OF ITEMS TO THE INVENTORY FOR THE CY 2027-28

1. There is requirement of addition of certain items in the inventory of Special Ration Items (packaged food products) in respect of Northern Command for the consumption year 2027-28 & onwards.

2. A showcasing/display/trial is being organised in two phases by this Headquarters at Udhampur as per details given below:-

2.1 Phase-I **Item initial screening.** Interested Original Equipment manufacturers are required to submit **item details/ catalogue/ product description of items alongwith one sample being offered alongwith the following details so as to reach by 1200h on 20 July 2026.**

S No	Item	Brand name	Type & Size/quantity of Package	Estimated Storage Life	MRP	Manufacturing Plant Location	Any Additional Information
2.3.1.	Yoghurt Powder (Freeze Dried)						
2.3.2.	Flax Seeds						
2.3.3.	Canned Fruit Juices						
2.3.4.	Multigrain Bar						
2.3.5.	Tetra Packed Fruit Juices						
2.3.6	Dal Khichdi (Ready to Eat)						
2.3.7	Muesli (Crunchy -Fruit & Nuts / No added Sugar)						
2.3.8	Freeze Dried Sprouts						
2.3.9	Digestive Biscuit						
2.3.10	Mix Seeds						
2.3.11	Chia Seeds						
2.3.12	Trail Mix (Dry Fruits/ Nuts/ Seeds)						
2.3.13	Date Bites						
2.3.14	Electrolyte Drinks						
2.3.15	Electrolyte tablets/Powder						

2.2. **Phase-II Technical Evaluation. ONLY selected items** from Phase - I, will be held for one day at Udhampur wherein 10 samples of items alongwith the OEM representative will be called for display and evaluation, likely between 05-10 Aug 2026.

2.3. The List of new products/items earmarked/ invited for addition of items in special ration inventory are as under:-

S No	Existing Category of Items	S No	New Introduction
2.3.1.	Yoghurt Powder (Freeze Dried)	2.3.6	Dal Khichdi (Ready to Eat)
2.3.2.	Flax Seeds	2.3.7	Muesli (Crunchy -Fruit & Nuts / No added Sugar)
2.3.3.	Canned Fruit Juices	2.3.8	Freeze Dried Sprouts
2.3.4.	Multigrain Bar	2.3.9	Digestive Biscuit
2.3.5.	Tetra Packed Fruit Juices	2.3.10	Mix Seeds
		2.3.11	Chia Seeds
		2.3.12	Trail Mix (Dry Fruits/ Nuts/ Seeds)
		2.3.13	Date Bites
		2.3.14	Electrolyte Drinks
		2.3.15	Electrolyte tablets/Powder

Note:-

1. Preferably the life of ibid items should be best before nine (09) months & above.

2. Tentatively delivery stations are Chandigarh, Leh, Srinagar and Roorkee.

3. Only Original Manufacturers / Authorised Managers or Managing Directors can participate in the above event.

4. The above event is on 'No Cost No Commitment basis' and HQ Northern Command reserves the right to reject any item/ firm without assigning any reasons.

5. Interested firms may submit their item details/ catalogues/ product description alongwith one sample in a sealed envelope duly mentioned “**SHOWCASING AND DISPLAY OF SPECIAL RATION ITEMS FOR ADDITION OF ITEMS TO THE INVENTORY FOR THE CY 2027-28**” addressed to MG ASC, Headquarters Northern Command (ST Branch), PIN-908545, C/o 56 APO so as to reach by 1200 Hrs on 20 Jul 2026 (No documents will be accepted thereafter).

6. Any other details can be obtained from this office of the Executive authority on any working day between 1100hrs to 1300 hrs on under mentioned details:-

6.1. Email address -

rls64@nic.in

6.2. Contact No-

01992-242153 & 242265*

(Extn 2763/3360)

*(Udhampur Exchange Helpline No)

MG ASC

HQ Northern Command

CBC 10602/11/0002/2627

Express News Service
New Delhi, July 5

A 28-YEAR-OLD woman was found dead at a New Delhi Municipal Council (NDMC) apartment complex in South Delhi’s Lodhi Colony on Saturday evening, police said, adding that an investigation has been launched into the circumstances of her death. Even as a suicide was suspected initially, the family of the woman, identified as Akriti, who got married barely two months ago, alleged harassment by her husband and in-laws.

Police said Akriti was found injured on the ground floor of the three-storey Palika Kunj apartment complex around 7.30 pm and was taken to the All India Institute of Medical Sciences, where doctors declared her “brought dead”.

Officers said they initially suspected that she had jumped from the building’s terrace after recovering her purse, mobile phone and sandals there, but added that all possible angles were being examined.

According to investigators, Akriti worked at a private company in Chhatarpur. On Saturday evening, she had called her mother when she left office around 6 pm. She again called her around 6.40 pm, informing that she had reached Saket. Later, she was allegedly not reachable. She allegedly travelled by Metro from Chhatarpur towards Saket before

reaching Lodhi Colony.

CCTV footage showed her entering the apartment complex alone, officers said.

“It has been found that she took the Metro from Chhatarpur to Saket to go to Pushp Vihar, but later went to Lodhi Colony. So far, no links have been found to anyone known to her staying in this apartment complex. However, we are continuing our investigation,” another police officer said.

Akriti got married to Arastu Sikka on April 24, according to officers. “It was apparently a love marriage... both families had agreed to it,” said an officer. After the wedding, she had been living with her husband and his family in Pushp Vihar.

Arastu is currently unemployed, said police.

Deputy Commissioner of Police (South) Anant Mittal said



Akriti; (left) the apartment complex in Lodhi Colony where she was found dead.

the investigation is underway and all possible angles are being examined. A crime team and forensic experts inspected the site of the incident.

On suspicion related to suicide, her family claimed that appeared to be in good spirits earlier in the day as she hosted a party for her colleagues.

The woman’s family also questioned the circumstances surrounding her death, alleging that there were no visible blood stains at the spot where her body was found, and demanded that police investigate the role of her husband and in-laws.

Police said an inquiry has also been initiated by the local Sub-Divisional Magistrate (SDM).

Further legal action, they added, will be taken after the post-mortem examination report is received.

Initiative to upgrade infra in govt schools nears completion

Devansh Mittal
New Delhi, July 5

THE DELHI government’s initiative to upgrade infrastructure in government schools — Mission Kayakalp — is on the anvil of completion, according to officials.

Chief Minister Rekha Gupta earlier said the objective of the project was to transform government schools into “safe, clean, modern and inspiring learning spaces” rather than “limiting them to centres of education”. The programme focuses on addressing infrastructure gaps such as leaking roofs, damaged toilets, outdated science laboratories, inadequate drinking water facilities and poor campus maintenance, according to a statement from the CMs Office.

While summer vacations were on, Gupta had instructed officers concerned to undertake renovation work to improve basic facilities, and upgrade classrooms and campus conditions, sources said.

**GMDC**
Gujarat Mineral Development Corporation Ltd.

TENDER NOTICE
E-Tender Notice No.: GMDC/GEO/04/2026
GMDC invites Request of Proposal (RFP) for Core Drilling at Ambadungar Fluorspar Mine, Taluka: Kawan, District: Chhota Udepur -Gujarat.
RFP document is available on following website www.gmdcltd.com
<https://www.gmricts.com> & <https://gmdctender.nprocure.com>.
General Manager (Geology)
Ph: 079-27913501/27912322

Gujarat Mineral Development Corporation Ltd.
(A Government of Gujarat Enterprise)
Khanji Bhawan, 132 Feet Ring Road,
Near University Ground, Vastrapur, Ahmedabad-380052

PROCLAMATION REQUIRING THE APPEARANCE OF A PERSON ACCUSED
See Section 82 Cr. P.C. / 84 BNSS
Whereas complaint has been made before me that accused person **Rajendra Kumar S/o Hem Chand R/o H. No. C-138, Gali No. 6, Bhajanpura, Delhi also at D-87, Gali No. 5, Subhash Mohalla, Bhajanpura, Delhi** has Committed (or is suspected to have committed) the offence in **CC No. 413/2020 U/s 138 NI Act, P.S. Bhajanpura, Delhi** and it has been returned to a warrant of arrest thereupon issued that the said accused **Rajendra Kumar** cannot be found and whereas it has been shown to my satisfaction that the said accused **Rajendra Kumar** has absconded (or is concealing himself to avoid the service of the said warrant).
Proclamation is hereby made that the said accused **Rajendra Kumar of CC No. 413/2020 U/s 138 NI Act, P.S. Bhajanpura, Delhi** is required to appear before this Court to answer the said complaint on or before **05.08.2026**.

By Order

Ms. Kirandeep Kaur

Judicial Magistrate First Class-01

Court No. 5,

Karkardooma Courts, Delhi

DP/9186/NE/2026 (Court Matter)



Ministry of Culture
Government of India



Commemoration of the 125th Birth Anniversary of Dr. Syama Prasad Mookerjee

An educationist, thinker and true nationalist who
stood for the unity & sovereignty of India

“Dr. Mookerjee’s sacrifice remains etched in our collective memory. We reaffirm our commitment to building a strong and developed India, guided by the values he cherished and served till his last breath.”

- **Narendra Modi**
Prime Minister



Chief Guest

Shri Amit Shah

Hon'ble Union Home Minister and Minister of Cooperation

Date: Monday, 6th July, 2026 | Time: 5:00 pm onwards
Venue: Milan Mela Prangan (Hall B), Kolkata

Program Highlights

‘Melody, Culture & Nation’:
A musical tribute by CCRT to
Dr. Syama Prasad Mookerjee

A visual showcase of
125 feet statue of
Dr. Syama Prasad Mookerjee

Special exhibition with archival
material on the life of
Dr. Syama Prasad Mookerjee

In August Presence

Shri Suvendu Adhikari

Hon'ble Chief Minister of West Bengal,
Government of West Bengal

Shri Gajendra Singh Shekhawat

Hon'ble Minister of Culture & Tourism,
Government of India

Watch the live telecast on Ministry of Culture’s social media handles



Scan to watch Live

Odisha SIR: 20 lakh deletions in draft rolls; Opp claims genuine voters were removed

Sujit Bisoyi
Bhubaneswar, July 5

NEARLY 20.14 lakh names of electors have been identified for deletion in Odisha, according to the draft electoral rolls published on Sunday, following a month-long enumeration process as part of the Special Intensive Revision (SIR) of the state voters' list. While the number of electors before the SIR was 3.33 crore, it has come down to 3.13 crore in the draft rolls. This includes 1.60 crore male and 1.53 crore female electors.

The Opposition BJD raised concerns over the draft electoral roll, saying more than 10,000 voters were identified for deletion from 75 of the total 147 Assembly constituencies in the state. "Many genuine names were excluded in the draft electoral roll because of minor anomalies, which need to be included during the claims and objection process," said senior BJD leader Debi Prasad Mishra.

Among the names deleted from the draft rolls, 8.32 lakh were found to be deceased. While 10.07 lakh names were deleted because they had moved elsewhere or were absent during the process, 1.58 lakh were found to have been enrolled in multiple places.

Odisha's Chief Electoral Officer R S Gopalan, said the claims and objections period starts from Sunday. The final roll, will be published on September 6. "If anyone's name is not found in the draft voter list, he/she has to fill and submit a Form 6 with a declaration form and other documents to get the name included in the final roll," said Gopalan.

"No name can be deleted without notice and a speaking order by ERO/assistant ERO. Any aggrieved elector may appeal to District Collector and thereafter to CEO under the relevant sections of the Representation of the People Act, 1951," he said.

Prashant Kishor to contest from Bankipur in upcoming bypoll

Himanshu Harsh
Patna, July 5

IN A major political development that sets the stage for a high-stakes electoral showdown in Bihar, the Jan Suraj Party (JSP) on Sunday officially announced its founder and political strategist-turned-politician Prashant Kishor as its candidate for the Bankipur Assembly bypoll. Polling will be held on July 30 with counting on August 3.

The development marks a significant transition for Kishor, who is making his electoral debut after deciding against contesting a seat in the 2025 Bihar polls. The Bankipur seat fell vacant following five-time MLA and BJP national president Nitin Nabin's election to the Rajya Sabha.

Accepting the party's decision, Kishor said the responsibility was another step towards his long-term mission of transforming Bihar. "Jan Suraj has been my life for the last four years and for at least the next 10 years, until the idea of changing



Jan Suraj founder Prashant Kishor with state party president Manoj Kumar Bhati and other leaders in Patna on Sunday. EXPRESS

Bihar is realised, I have no other purpose," he said, adding that a victory in Bankipur would not only strengthen the party but also revive the broader movement for political change after the disappointment many supporters felt following the 2025 Assembly polls.

In the weeks leading up to the formal announcement, Kishor had been active on the ground in Bankipur, signaling a major shift in his grassroots strategy. In a departure from his approach of organising mega rallies, Kishor has spent the last

few weeks quietly conducting micro-level public meetings and neighbourhood town halls across Bankipur.

During these ward-wise meetings, Jan Suraj teams have been directly documenting local grievances while Kishor delivers tailored pitches to urban voters with his interactions focusing heavily on convincing residents to "vote for their children's future", rather than traditional caste calculations, in an attempt to chip away at the ruling BJP's unchallenged dominance in Bankipur

for more than three decades.

Kishor has localised his attacks against the BJP by targeting the long-standing political monopoly over the seat, asking voters what decades of loyalty to Nabin and his father Navin Kishore Prasad Sinha before him has yielded in terms of basic infrastructure.

The Bankipur constituency, an urban seat that falls within Patna, has long been regarded as an impregnable fortress for the BJP. The party's dominance here dates back over three decades, rooted deeply in the legacy of one political family.

Before the 2008 delimitation exercise, Bankipur came under Patna West constituency. Nabin Kishore Prasad Sinha won Patna West for four consecutive terms starting 1995. Following his demise in 2006, his son Nitin Nabin won the seat in a by-election. After the seat was redrawn in 2008, Nabin shifted his candidacy to the newly created Bankipur. He maintained an unbroken winning streak, securing victory in the 2010, 2015, 2020, and 2025.

Former Gujarat minister Mohansinh Rathva dies

Express News Service
Ahmedabad, July 5



Rathva was elected to Assembly for a record 10 times

MOHANSINH RATHVA, a former minister who got elected to the Gujarat Assembly for a record 10 times, died in Chhota Udepur district on Sunday. He was 82. A former Congress leader who joined the BJP, Mohansinh Rathva is survived by three sons. His son Rajendra-sinh Rathva, the BJP MLA from Chhota Udepur constituency, confirmed death due to old age.

Considered among the senior most tribal leaders of Gujarat, Mohansinh was first elected to Gujarat Assembly in 1972. He went on to win every election after that until 2017. The Assembly elections of 2002 was the sole

exception when Mohansinh lost to BJP's Vechat Baria. In his long career as member of Gujarat Assembly, he also held the post of a minister twice and was the leader of opposition. In 2022 Assembly elections, he joined the BJP. He took political retirement after that.

EXPRESS Careers



PRAVARA INSTITUTE OF MEDICAL SCIENCES
(Deemed to be University)

Established under section (3) of UGC Act 1956
Loni-413736 (Near Shirdi), Tal. Rahata, Dist. Ahilyanagar, Maharashtra
NAAC Re-Accredited with 'A' Grade (CGPA 3.17 on a 4 point scale)

APPLICATION FOR THE POSITION OF VICE-CHANCELLOR
Applications are invited for the Position of Vice-Chancellor of Pravara Institute of Medical Sciences (Deemed to be University). The selection shall be made as per Regulations given U/S 23. B. of UGC (Institution Deemed to be Universities) Regulations, 2023.
ELIGIBILITY: The Vice Chancellor is expected to be
1. A visionary with proven leadership qualities, administrative capabilities as well as teaching and research credentials.
2. Having outstanding academic record throughout and a minimum of 10 years' experience as a Professor in a University system or in an equivalent position in a reputed research and / or academic / administrative organization.
TERM: Vice Chancellor shall hold the office for a term of five years, Provided that in no case shall the person appointed as Vice Chancellor hold office beyond the age of 70 years.
SALARY AND PERKS: As per UGC pay scales.
Application form along with a Xerox copy of qualification, experience and other relevant documents (pasted with one Photograph) along with one soft copy should reach within 15 days to the office of **The Registrar, Pravara Institute of Medical Sciences (Deemed to be University), Loni-413736 (Near Shirdi), Tal. Rahata, Dist. Ahilyanagar, Maharashtra** from the date of the publication of this advertisement by Registered / Speed post only. The soft copy is to be sent on: registrar@pmtpims.org
Application be super scribed as "Application for the Position of Vice Chancellor". For application form and other details visit: www.pravara.com
* The University is not responsible for Postal Delay

Nodal Officer
Search cum Selection Committee

19.34 lakh in Manipur draft rolls, 1.58 lakh did not submit forms

Express News Service
Imphal, July 5

THE MANIPUR draft voters' list, published on Sunday, contained 19.34 lakh electors of the state's 20.93 lakh or 92.42% across 60 Assembly constituencies, under the Special Intensive Revision (SIR) exercise conducted between May 30 and June 28, said Chief Electoral Officer (CEO) Arun Kumar Sinha.

A total of 1.58 lakh electors (7.58%) did not submit their enumeration forms during the SIR process, the CEO said. Of the 19.34 lakh electors, 9.40 lakh are male, 9.93 lakh female and 293 third-gender, according to the draft rolls. 20,442 electors

are in the 18-19 age group.

Sinha assured that no elector's name would be deleted from the draft rolls without due process. "Nobody can remove anybody from the draft electoral roll unless he has been given an opportunity of hearing. Only after hearing and passing a speaking order, can a person's name be deleted from the draft electoral roll."

Even after the publication of the final voters' list on September 6, aggrieved electors can appeal under the provisions of the Representation of the People Act, 1950. Those whose names are missing from the rolls for failing to submit enumeration forms can still apply for inclu-

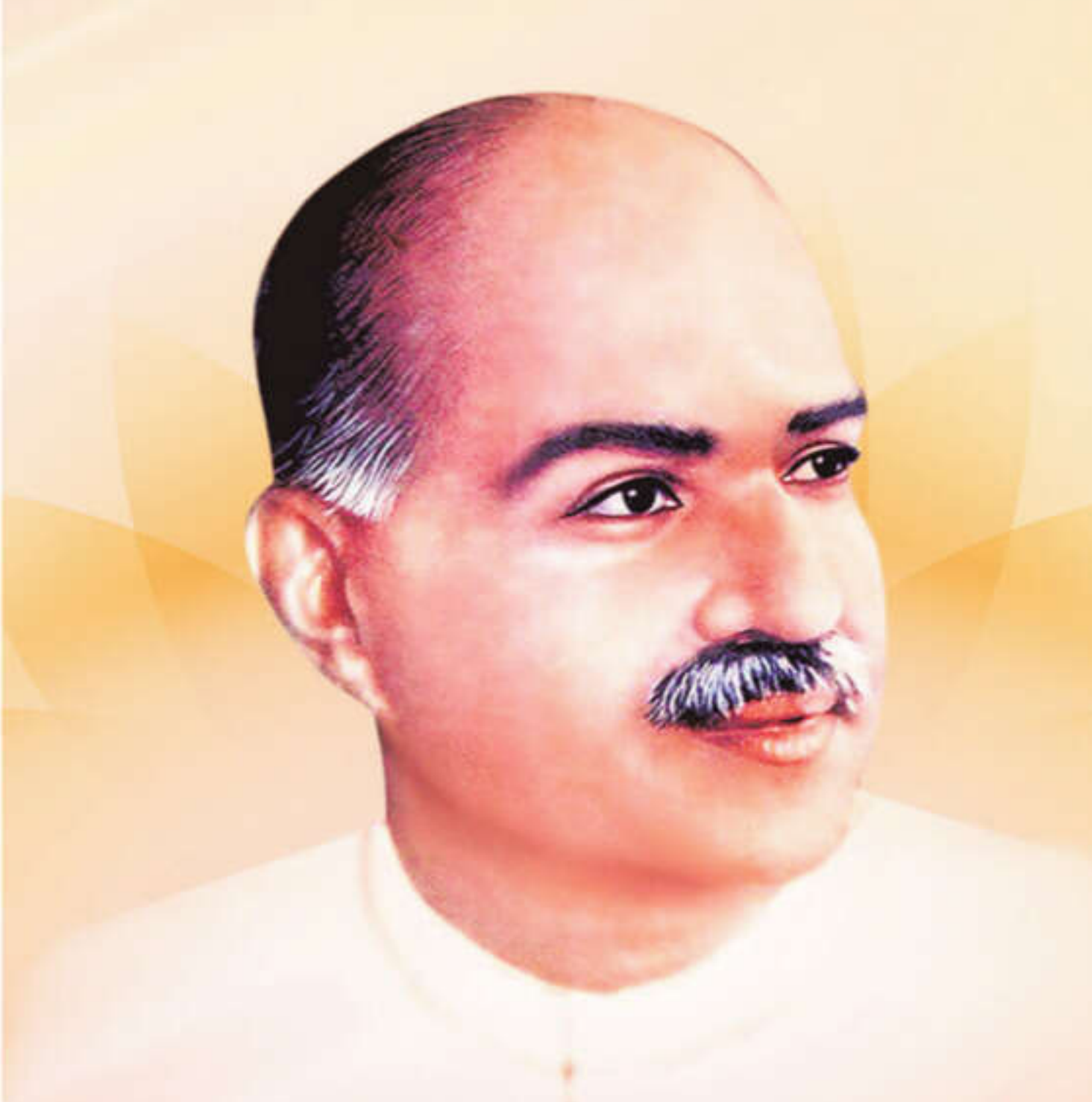
sion by filing Form-6, along with the prescribed declaration, during the Claims and Objections period from July 5 to August 4, 2026, Sinha said.

He said that the Notice and Verification Phase will continue from July 5 to September 2, during which EROs will scrutinise claims and objections and issue notices, wherever required. He said electors whose records require verification will be given an opportunity to produce the necessary documents before a decision is taken. For correction of particulars such as name, address and change of Assembly constituency, electors may submit Form-8.



CENTRAL COUNCIL FOR RESEARCH IN AYURVEDIC SCIENCES
Ministry of AYUSH, Government of India
J.L.N.B.C.E.H. Anusadhan Bhawan
No. 61-65, Institutional Area, Opp. "D" Block, Janakpuri, New Delhi - 110058
Email: dg-ccras@nic.in, Website: www.ccras.nic.in Tel: 011-28525852

ADVERTISEMENT - 2026
PANCHAKARMA TECHNICIAN COURSE
The Central Council for Research in Ayurvedic Sciences (CCRAS), Ministry of AYUSH, Govt., of India invites applications for 12th pass students for One year, full time and self-financed Panchakarma Technician Course conducted by CCRAS, Ministry of AYUSH, Govt. of India, New Delhi at following 6 Training Centres affiliated to Healthcare Sector Skill Council (HSSC) -National Skill Development Corporation (NSDC) i.e. (1) CARI, New Delhi (10 Seats), (2) NARIP, Cheruthuruthy (30 Seats), (3) RARI, Jammu (15 Seats), (4) CARI, Guwahati (10 Seats), (5) RARI, Lucknow (10 Seats) & (6) CARI Bhubaneswar (10 Seats).
Please visit the Council's website www.ccras.nic.in for the details of the Advertisement, Application Form, Course, How to apply, Course Fee, Age limit, Reservation and Last date for receipt of application etc.
Administrative Officer (Estt.)
CBC-17216/11/0010/2627





सत्यमेव जयते
दिल्ली सरकार

भारतीय जनसंघ के संस्थापक

“एक देश में दो विधान,
दो प्रधान और
दो निशान -नहीं चलेंगे।”

के उद्घोषक,

प्रखर राष्ट्रवादी एवं महान शिक्षाविद्

डॉ. श्यामा प्रसाद मुखर्जी जी

की 125वीं जयंती पर

कोटिशः नमन



रेखा गुप्ता
मुख्यमंत्री, दिल्ली

DIP/Shabdarth/Display/053/26-27

epaper.indianexpress.com

New Delhi



Seeking Transparency

EVEN AS the row over alleged financial irregularities in the Shri Ram Janmbhoomi Teerth Kshetra Trust continues to simmer, CPI(M) Rajya Sabha MP John Brittas has written to Union Home Minister Amit Shah urging the Centre to revisit its stand that the Trust is outside the ambit of the Right to Information Act. In his letter, Brittas argued that since the Trust was constituted through a government-approved scheme following the Supreme Court's Ayodhya verdict and the Centre played a foundational role in its creation, it ought to qualify as a "public authority" under the RTI Act. He also pointed to the presence of serving government officials in the Trust's governing framework to contend that the institution retains an enduring governmental association. He urged the Home Ministry to reconsider its legal position and place a revised stand before the High Court, calling for greater transparency.

Missing the Opp?

IT IS not every day that those closely associated with the BJP and RSS look back fondly at the UPA years. But at an event to mark the 80th anniversary of RSS-affiliated *Organiser* weekly last week, nostalgia was in the air. Former editor R Balashankar recalled that the magazine's articles and editorials were closely tracked by those in power, including the then PM Manmohan Singh, who, he claimed, looked forward to reading *The Indian Express*'s "View From the Right" column, which summarised the weekly's content. "We were always criticising the PM..." In those times writing anything critical was fine. Criticising Sonia Gandhi was great fun. The UPA government took note of it, and the Prime Minister reading it was a compliment," Balashankar said. He also teased current *Organiser* editor Prafulla Ketkar, suggesting that with an ideologically aligned government now in power, finding room for criticism must be far more difficult. Later, RSS general secretary Dattatreya Hosabale echoed the sentiment, acknowledging the challenge of bringing out a journal when a government with the same ideology is in office.

Dr Syama Prasad Mookerjee: A life devoted to India's unity and progress



NARENDRA MODI

TODAY, JULY 6, is a special day for countless people who cherish the ideals of nationalism and selfless service. We commemorate the 125th birth anniversary of Dr Syama Prasad Mookerjee, whose life remains a timeless example of courage and unwavering commitment to Maa Bharti. Few leaders in modern India embodied the seamless confluence of intellect, public service and moral conviction as profoundly as Dr Syama Prasad Mookerjee.

The young Syama Prasad was born into circumstances that could easily have assured him a protected and comfortable life. His father, Sir Ashutosh Mookerjee, was among the foremost educationists and intellectuals of his age. Yet, while destiny placed before him a path of privilege, his conscience led him towards one of sacrifice and national service. He was convinced that he could not remain a mute spectator to the turbulence of his times — be it fighting colonialism, communalism, humanitarian challenges and more.

Along this journey, he endured profound personal tragedies, including the loss of an infant child and, later, his wife. Yet, these tragedies only deepened his resolve and strengthened his unwavering commitment to serve.

If there was one ideal that defined Dr Syama Prasad Mookerjee's public life above all else, it was the indivisibility of India. He stood firm during the upheaval of Partition to ensure that West Bengal remained an integral part of India. A few years later, that very conviction drew him to Jammu and Kashmir. Imprisonment did not deter him and isolation did not diminish him. His life came to an abrupt end in detention, far from the countless people whose cause he had made his own.

There are moments in history when an individual's final sacrifice transcends politics and enters the realm of national memory. Dr Mookerjee's last journey remains one such moment. Acharya Vinoba Bhave said that Dr Mookerjee sacrificed himself for a cause in which he had faith. Years later, the revocation of Articles 370 and 35(A) in 2019 was the most fitting tribute to his martyrdom.

Dr Mookerjee put India First and Indian values first. And he did it by building institutions and nurturing systems that defied conventional mindsets of those times. He became the youngest Vice Chancellor of the University of Calcutta. In his unique style, he brought positive changes that were patriotic and futuristic. Addressing a



Prime Minister Narendra Modi in West Bengal's Hooghly on June 20

There are moments in history when an individual's final sacrifice transcends politics and enters the realm of national memory. Dr Mookerjee's last journey remains one such moment. Acharya Vinoba Bhave said that Dr Mookerjee sacrificed himself for a cause in which he had faith. Years later, the revocation of Articles 370 and 35(A) in 2019 was the most fitting tribute to his martyrdom.

conference of educators, Dr Mookerjee put it wonderfully when he said, "It is incorrect to look upon educational institutions as factories to produce potential clerks and low-paid staff. We have to turn out students who are capable of providing leadership to our self-governing institutions, such as municipal corporations, provincial and central legislatures and also of directing the affairs in various fields of life such as financial, commercial and industrial ones."

Under his leadership, Calcutta University undertook unique efforts such as improving library infrastructure, boosting research in sciences, encouraging the study of artefacts and establishing courses in agriculture. To instil a sense of pride among students and alumni, he began a practice of marking 24th January as the foundation day of the university. He requested none other than Gurudev Tagore to compose a song for the university.

Yet another example of this spirit can be seen in the later part of his life, when he decided to form the Bharatiya Jana Sangh.

At a time when the Congress Party was omnipresent, he felt that there was all the more reason for an alternative voice to speak up for India's progress while staying attached to our cultural roots. It was perhaps fitting that the party's symbol was the Diya, the earthen lamp. A single lamp may appear modest, yet it possesses the power to dispel darkness far beyond itself.

It is exactly what the Jana Sangh did both during the years it was active and beyond.

Dr Syama Prasad Mookerjee's tenure as India's first Minister for Industry and Supply reveals a statesman whose conception of development was remarkably comprehensive and humane. He viewed industry as a means of restoring dignity, opportunity and confidence to a newly independent nation. He respected wealth creation and value addition. While laying the foundations of modern industrial India through pioneering initiatives such as the Damodar Valley Corporation, the Sindri Fertiliser Plant and a robust industrial policy, he simultaneously ensured that India's traditional strengths were not neglected. Handlooms, cottage industries, artisans and textile workers found in him an equally

committed champion.

Here, I would like to share a personal experience. The Sindri plant, which Dr Mookerjee worked to establish with a clear vision of self-reliance, was ignored by those who ran the nation for several decades. I feel honoured that our Government had the opportunity to contribute to its revival. It was indeed among the most special moments to have been there for that programme.

India's civilisational tradition has long celebrated dialogue and discussions. Dr Mookerjee embodied this democratic spirit. He joined Pandit Nehru's Cabinet, believing that the task of nation-building in the early years transcended political differences. He served with sincerity and a constructive spirit. But when he felt that questions of national importance demanded a different course, he relinquished office with dignity and devoted himself wholeheartedly to the political work he believed the nation required.

Seventy-five years ago, Pandit Nehru brought the First Amendment, which was a direct assault on free speech. Dr Mookerjee was among its staunchest critics. He understood fully what the Congress was capable of doing. And he was proven right.

Those who brought the First Amendment 75 years ago imposed the Emergency in 1975 and 50 years ago, brought in the 42nd Amendment Act, which again struck at the core of liberal democratic values.

Dr Mookerjee also stood out for his humanitarian efforts. When the most tragic famine struck Bengal in 1943, Dr Mookerjee immersed himself in serving those affected. He ensured that several canteens and relief centres were opened to feed people. On one hand, he was deeply shaken by the plight of his people, while on the other, he was repulsed by the insensitivity of the colonial rulers. He even wrote a book, *Panchasher Manwantar*, in which he expressed his angst. When a super cyclone hit Medinipur in 1942, his efforts to restore normalcy were widely lauded.

Speaking at a college in Kolkata, Dr Mookerjee urged the youth, "Whatever work you undertake, do it seriously, thoroughly and well; never leave it half-done or undone, never feel yourself satisfied unless and until you have given it your very best."

As India advances towards the goal of a Viksit Bharat, the finest tribute we can pay him is to strive every day to build the strong, united, self-confident and compassionate India that he so deeply believed in. And knowing today's youth, I am certain they will rise to the occasion and do exactly that.

The writer is the Prime Minister of India

DECISION ON CHAMPAT RAI, ANIL MISHRA RESIGNATIONS LIKELY

As temple trust meets today, RSS keeps a close watch

Maulshree Seth, Deeptiman Tiwary & Shyamal Yadav
Ayodhya, New Delhi, July 5

AMID AN ongoing investigation into the alleged embezzlement of donations at the Ram Temple in Ayodhya, Shri Ram Janmbhoomi Teerth Kshetra Trust is set to meet on Monday to take a call on the resignations of its general secretary Champat Rai and trustee Anil Mishra and decide who will be in charge of the temple's daily affairs until the SIT completes its probe.

Sources said Trust members were divided over the resignations of Rai and Mishra, with one section in favour of letting them go. Another group advocates waiting for the SIT to submit its report by July 15 and appointing someone to take over the temple management in the interim. While some Trust members are of the view that the management system should remain in the hands of an official, others are pushing for a new administrative structure to be devised.

The meeting was initially scheduled to be held at Mani Ram Chhawani, the ashram of Trust president Nritya Gopal Das, but is now likely to take place on the Ram Temple premises, said sources. Trust treasurer Govind Dev Giri has asked all 11 regular members and the ex-officio members to attend. Senior trustee K Parasaran, who cannot travel due to health problems, may join via video conference.

Why RSS is concerned

The RSS is keeping a close watch on the developments and has dispatched its senior leader Suresh "Bhaiyaji" Joshi, its VHP in-charge, to Ayodhya for the meeting. Sangh sources said the episode was also set to dominate the organisation's



An Uttar Pradesh Police team at the district jail in Ayodhya to question the arrested accused, on Sunday. ANI

three-day annual conclave that begins in Karnataka's Belagavi later this week. The Sangh is likely to discuss the fate of some of its functionaries involved with temple operations, *The Indian Express* has learnt.

The alleged theft is a matter of concern for the Sangh since the Ram temple has become the most visible symbol of its ideological movement over the past several decades. Senior RSS functionaries said the controversy carries consequences beyond a criminal investigation and has become an issue of credibility for the organisation. While the three-day Akhil Bharatiya Prant Pracharak Baitak, starting July 10 was initially set to discuss the Census and other contemporary national issues, it will now focus on the Ayodhya episode.

"While the Census, along with other contemporary issues, will be discussed, the Ram Temple issue is obviously on everyone's mind and it will be discussed. It has cast a shadow on the Sangh Parivar and all workers and senior office-bearers are likely to bring it up. The issue is creating a negative image of Sangh among people and we need to arrest that slide," said a senior RSS functionary.

An RSS office-bearer from UP described the controversy as more damaging than the "Hindutva terror" allegations levelled against the Sangh during the UPA years. "When the UPA government accused the Sangh of Hindutva terror, nobody believed it. But this one is hurting us in public perception. People think the Ram Temple and the Sangh are the same. Even if no one from the Sangh may be involved, this is a controversy that will be hard to shake off," the office-bearer said.

On July 3, RSS general secretary Dattatreya Hosabale said it was natural for the entire Hindu society, "including the RSS", to expect the Trust to treat the episode as an "extraordinary matter" and take effective steps to rectify shortcomings in the temple's operations.

A UP Police senior officer in Ayodhya said the final assessment of the missing donation amount was not yet complete and that the probe would be expanded to SBI employees involved in the counting process. "We have yet to make any final assessment about the total loss, but I can say the amount being banded about is exaggerated. The total loss should not be more than a few crores."

'Your legacy is firing on Hindus, bloodshed': BJP chief targets Opp

Lalmani Verma
Lucknow, July 5

IN THE first remark from the BJP top leadership amid allegations of theft and embezzlement of donation at the Ram temple in Ayodhya, BJP chief Nitin Nabin assured on Sunday that the government will take action and bring in reforms while he targeted the Opposition, saying that "those who once questioned the existence of Lord Ram are today talking about aastha (faith)".

Addressing the BJP's Shakti Kendra Sammelan in Lucknow, Nabin tore into the Congress, SP and AAP for questioning the RSS, BJP and the VHP. "Some people still raise questions... the same people who once questioned the very existence of Lord Ram, filed affidavits in the Supreme Court calling Him imaginary, and even questioned the existence of Ram Setu. These are the same people who ordered firing on kar sevaks in Ayodhya... Today they talk about aastha (faith). Those shed-

ding crocodile tears can never raise the issue related to the faith of Hindu religion," he said.

Recalling that his father went from Patna to Ayodhya as a kar sevak and was lodged in jail for two months, Nabin said, "And you question our faith? Your legacy is bloodshed and firing on Hindus while our legacy is to make sacrifices for the faith of our deities."

"Today we can see the struggle of the BJP, RSS and VHP people in the form of the grand Ram temple in Ayodhya," Nabin said. "Even if our blood is shed, we will not allow anyone to harm the faith linked to Lord Ram's temple. We are prepared to make any sacrifice for it."

Nabin said that "anti-Hindu forces" have always insulted Hindu religion and deities, and played with sentiments of Hindus. "Today if those opponents try to take political advantage... I am telling Rahul Gandhi, Akhilesh Yadav and Kejriwal (Arvind)... do not consider Hindu dharma so weak that they can be misled by you," he said.

Hindus won't forgive those behind temple loot: Uddhav

Vallabh Ozarkar
Mumbai, July 5

DAYS AFTER losing six Lok Sabha MPs and MLCs Sachin Ahir to the Eknath Shinde-led Shiv Sena, Shiv Sena (UBT) chief Uddhav Thackeray on Sunday accused the BJP of betraying the Ram temple movement and alleged that those who came to power in the name of Lord Ram have allowed the alleged loot of devotees' donations.

At the party's "Ram Raksha Andolan" at Dadar, Thackeray said, "We are staunch and patriotic Hindus. If someone loots a temple by taking advantage of our faith, Hindus won't forgive."

"When slogans of 'Mandir wahin banayenge' were raised, Shiv Sainiks did as much, if not more, than anyone else. We participated in shila puja, the Rath Yatra and kar seva. Many kar sevaks shed blood... sacrificed their lives," he said. On the alleged embezzlement of temple fund, Thackeray said, "If this is the condition in Ayodhya, what will happen in Kashi & Mathura? Today Hindus are being looted."

On radar: 900 kg silver sent for purity check and melting, spending lakhs

Maulshree Seth
Ayodhya, July 5

AS FINANCIAL records of Shri Ram Janmbhoomi Teerth Kshetra Trust are being looked into following allegations of donation theft, sources said that the claim of the Trust that over 900 kg of silver in different forms was sent to the government-run Security Printing and Minting Corporation of India Ltd, Hyderabad, for purity checking and then being melted into bricks, has come under the scanner of police.

Sources said that lakhs of rupees were spent on sending the

silver to Hyderabad amidst security. "Over Rs 1 lakh was spent on just safely carrying the large amount of silver to SPMCI, and much more (around Rs 20 lakh), in the entire process of checking of impurities and later converting them into bricks for easy upkeep," said an official.

Sources said that while this was indicated in the meetings of the Trust in November 2024 as well as in March 2025, suggestions were also made for setting up a separate accountable "system" within the main Ram temple complex for dropping precious ornaments and also for those seeking a receipt.

"All we know is that during a meeting of the Trust last year the information was shared that a little less than 1,000 kg of silver received in different forms in donation was sent to the government-run minting unit in Hyderabad for testing and melting. The silver sent in different forms, when melted and checked for purity had come to around 900 kg after removal of impurities. As samples were taken, close to about 90% purity was found," said an official.

Sources said over Rs 20 lakh were spent in the process of checking purity. Sources said these claims are being verified.

Why NDA faces hurdles in fresh women quota Bill push

Vikas Pathak
New Delhi, July 5

WITH THE BJP-led NDA government apparently mulling introduction of a fresh constitutional amendment Bill to advance reservation for women to 2029 — along with the Delimitation Bill for expansion of the strength of the Lok Sabha from 543 members up to 850 MPs — in the Monsoon Session, the NDA will still need more parties on board to fulfil the requirement of a two-thirds majority in both Houses.

The NDA strength in Lok Sabha is 293, and after the switching of sides by 20 TMC and six Shiv Sena (UBT) MPs, the ruling alliance's strength will reach 319 if the Speaker deems the crossover of these MPs valid. However, even this number will be 41 below the required 360 for a two-thirds majority in Lok Sabha. In the RS, the NDA is at 152 MPs now, while the two-thirds mark is 161.

This means NDA needs backing from more parties, either through support or through sig-

nificant abstentions that would reduce the two-thirds mark in both Houses. For this, the Bills to be introduced should unequivocally fulfil the demands of parties opposed to it.

The demand of DMK, which has 22 Lok Sabha MPs, has been to continue with the status quo on the allocation of seats in the LS through an extension of the freeze on delimitation. The party had aggressively opposed the Centre in the run-up to the Tamil Nadu elections, with its chief MK Stalin warning that the state would not tolerate any imposition from Delhi. But there are indications that its aggression vis-a-vis the BJP has been diluted after the rise of C. Joseph Vijay's TVK to power.

Asked about the DMK's present position, party MP Tiruchi Siva told *The Indian Express*, "It would be speculative to say anything until there is a proposal to look at." A source in the government had said in June that the Centre would bring a new Bill whenever it had the numbers to pass a constitutional amendment legislation.



Home Minister Amit Shah said during the Budget Session that proportion of seats allocated to states won't change at the time of Lok Sabha's expansion. FILE

During the Budget Session earlier this year, the Constitution (131st Amendment) Bill to amend the Nari Shakti Vandan Adhiniyam, 2023, to expedite women's reservation in LS and Assemblies had fallen for want of numbers, and the accompanying Delimitation Bill requiring a simple majority was subsequently not taken up.

At that time, while Union Home Minister Amit Shah had said the proportion of seats allocated to states would not change at the time of the LS's expansion — the government

had said each state would gain 50% seats — this was not mentioned in the Bills circulated.

The statement of objects and reasons of this amendment Bill noted that the Nari Shakti Vandan Adhiniyam, 2023, had laid down that women's reservation would be implemented following delimitation on the basis of the first Census after the Act was passed. However, as this would delay the process given the Census is still in its early stages, the 2026 Bill stated that it aimed to operationalise women's reservation following delimitation on the basis of the 2011 Census.

The Bill, however, did not propose to amend the "one-person, one-vote, one-value" principle enshrined in Article 81 (2) (a) of the Constitution, which says, "There shall be allotted to each state a number of seats in the House of the People in such manner that the ratio between that number and the population of the state is, so far as practicable, the same for all States."

The only exception the Article makes to the norm of population-based delimitation is for very small states with a



AFTER GUNFIGHT Security forces tighten cordon in Shopian, say 2 militants hiding

Bashaarat Masood
Srinagar, July 5

A JOINT team of forces tightened its cordon around Chanapora village in Shopian on Sunday after a gunfight with militants on Saturday evening. A joint team of Jammu and Kashmir Police, Army and paramilitary forces intensified search operations on Sunday morning as they believe the militants are still hiding in the dense orchards of the village.

On Saturday evening, a brief gunfight erupted in south Kashmir's Shopian when a joint team of forces launched a cordon and search operation after inputs about the presence of militants in the area. Police sources said two militants are believed to be hiding in the area.

The gunfight has erupted at a time when the annual Amarnath yatra is underway.

Govt issues notice to Meta on Insta ads linked to child sexual abuse

Soumyarendra Barik
New Delhi, July 5

THE MINISTRY of Electronics and Information Technology (MeitY) has issued a notice to Meta-owned Instagram, directing the social media platform to disable all advertisements and content promoting and facilitating access to child sexual abuse material (CSAM).

The government has also asked Meta to provide a detailed explanation, within a week, on why and how the platform had allowed users to post paid advertisements containing such material.

The notice was sent Saturday evening after BBC reported that Instagram was allowing paid advertisements promoting child sexual abuse material in India.

"The government has issued a stern notice to Meta on the issue. MeitY has ordered Instagram to disable all ads and

content promoting and facilitating access to CSAM, and sought a detailed explanation within seven days," a senior government official said.

A Meta spokesperson said the company has a "zero-tolerance" policy on sharing such content, and that Instagram deploys artificial intelligence (AI) tools to proactively detect it.

"Meta has a zero tolerance policy for soliciting or sharing CSAM, including in ads. We use advanced AI technology to proactively detect violating content and individuals, but we are in a constant battle with criminals who hide among our 3.5 billion users and try to evade our detection. That is why our expert teams are constantly working to improve our defences, develop new technology to root out predators, block links to violating websites, and share intelligence with other companies so they can take action too," the spokesperson said.

The episode has ignited an important conversation surrounding safe harbour available to social media companies, under which they are allowed legal immunity from hosting third-party, user-generated content on their platforms. The key idea behind the immunity is that companies do not have prior knowledge of what users might post on their platforms, and as a result cannot be held liable for them until such content is brought to their notice, under a legal provision called "actual knowledge".

However, the government is now considering whether such protections should be available to companies for hosting advertisements, given that there is a preliminary moderation that platforms are expected to carry out while reviewing advertising material.

"It cannot be a case where a social media platform is allowed to host such deeply

problematic advertisements, and have no consequences due to safe harbour protections. We are discussing whether advertisements on social media should have the same protections as regular content," an official said.

Broadly, many are also seeing the development as a potential precursor that could kickstart conversations within the Centre around regulatory protections for children on social media.

Countries like Australia, the United Kingdom and the United Arab Emirates, among others, have moved to ban social media access for children. India is learnt to have discussed a graded approach to such limits but a concrete step is yet to be taken, The Indian Express had reported earlier.

This is the second instance within a week when Meta has found itself in the crosshairs of the Indian government.

Earlier, the government asked Meta-owned WhatsApp to not roll out its upcoming username feature over concerns of impersonation and fraud. In a notice issued to the company, the IT Ministry gave WhatsApp three days to furnish a detailed explanation on the username feature.

In its notice, the government is understood to have told WhatsApp that the feature may materially increase the incidence of online fraud, phishing, digital arrest scams and impersonation attacks, by enabling bad actors to solicit and message unsuspecting users. The government has also flagged that the feature may facilitate impersonation of individuals, public authorities, financial institutions and government agencies, by permitting the adoption of usernames closely resembling those of genuine people and institutions.

• BRIEFLY



Indian Navy's Sail Training Ship *Sudarshini* at the US International Naval Review and Sail celebrations in New York. PTI

250th ANNIVERSARY OF U.S.

INS *Sudarshini* participates in maritime spectacle on Hudson River

INDIAN NAVY'S sail training ship — INS *Sudarshini* — carrying the tricolour sailed into the New York port and past the Statue of Liberty on July 4, joining vessels from the US and several other countries for a grand event marking the 250th anniversary of the US' independence. The ship's presence in the International Naval Review and Sail 4th 250 celebrations hosted by America, also reflects the "enduring friendship, mutual respect, and expanding maritime partnership between India and the United States", the Indian Navy said on Sunday. The visit is part of the ship's 10-month transoceanic expedition, Lokayan 2026. PTI



Security personnel stand guard as people block a road and stage a protest in Baruipur, South 24 Parganas district, on Sunday. PTI

Minor's 'rape-murder' sparks protests in Bengal's Baruipur; mob lynches youth

Sweetie Kumari
Kolkata, June 5

VIOLENT PROTESTS erupted at Baruipur in West Bengal's South 24 Parganas district on Sunday morning after a minor girl, missing since Saturday afternoon, was found dead in a pond. A mob allegedly lynched a local man suspected of being involved in the crime after the girl's family alleged she was raped and murdered before her body was dumped in the pond.

The incident took place at a village in Baruipur, around 30 km from Kolkata. Angry locals initially refused to hand over the minor's body to the police and blocked key transportation routes. The mob also set several vehicles on fire. Train services on the Sealdah-Namkhana line were completely disrupted for about an hour due to the protests. Road traffic also remained suspended for nearly five hours as locals sat in protest on the streets with the girl's body. A massive contingent of security personnel, including the central forces, was sent to the spot.

Police sources said a mob lynched a 26-year-old man as he was allegedly spotted with people believed to be the prime suspects. Police, however, have not revealed the identity of the person.

"...the CM (Suvendu Adhikari) spoke to us directly over the phone. He assured us that no person involved in this crime will be spared... We urge everyone to cooperate with the government and police..." Presidency Range Inspector-General Kankarprasad Barui told the locals.

Later, a six-member SIT, headed by the Additional Superintendent of Police, was constituted to investigate the incident.

'Mamata prevented from leaving home'

Meanwhile, the incident took a political turn with the Opposition TMC claiming that the state government deployed security forces outside party chief Mamata Banerjee's Kalighat residence to stop her from visiting Baruipur.

In a post on X, the TMC wrote, "Our chairperson, Mamata Banerjee, wanted to visit Baruipur. Upon learning this, a massive deployment of police personnel and barricades was put in place outside her residence to prevent her from leaving. Despite these attempts to stop her, our demand remains unchanged: #JusticeForBaruipur. Didi stands firmly with the victim's family and is committed to ensuring they receive justice."

Seven rain-related deaths in Mumbai in a day: 6 killed in chawl collapse, tree falls on 1

Pratip Acharya
Mumbai, July 5

SEVEN PEOPLE died in rain-related incidents across Mumbai on Sunday, taking the city's monsoon death toll to 10 in less than a week. While six people were killed after a ground-plus-three-storey chawl collapsed in Mankhurd on Sunday night, a 63-year-old man died earlier in the day after a tree branch fell on him in Kurla. An 18-year-old boy died after a tree branch fell on him in Aarey Saturday night.

According to officials, a portion of a ground-plus-three-storey chawl collapsed in Mankhurd around 8.30 pm at Chawl No. 5 in Janta Nagar, behind Hanuman Mandir, trapping several residents under the debris. One person was declared dead at the spot, while five others — four women and a man — were brought dead to Shatabdi Hospital. The deceased were yet to be identified, while one person who sustained injuries is undergoing treatment.

Officials said the death toll could rise as search operations continued late into the night.

The cause of the collapse is yet to be ascertained.

Earlier in the day, a 63-year-old man who was going to attend the inauguration of his son's shop died after a tree branch collapsed on him in Kurla.

On Saturday, 18-year-old



Uprooted by heavy rain, a tree lies across a footpath near Shiv Sena Bhavan in Mumbai on Sunday. AKASH PATIL

Hasan Sayyad from Saki Naka area lost his life after a tree branch fell on him in Aarey, while he was travelling on his motorcycle. Prior to this, a 11-year-old boy died after a tree collapsed on a school bus in Chembur on June 30 while a 55-year-old fell in an open manhole in Sakinaka on July 2.

Akin to the Chembur school bus incident, the road where the tree branch fell on the 63-year-old man, identified as Yunush Kundawala, too, had been recently concretised. In the aftermath of the Chembur incident, there have been discussions on

the impact that road concretisation was having on the health of Mumbai trees.

As per officials, Kundawala was a resident of Bandra (East). On Sunday morning, he arrived on bike at a shop leased by his sons that was to be inaugurated. As he was getting off, a large branch of a tree snapped and fell onto the shop, fatally injuring him. Kundawala's sons were standing a few feet away from the spot. "I was standing at a nearby panshop when we heard a loud thud. We rushed to the spot and saw that a huge tree branch had collapsed. I was in

shock because I had passed through the same spot barely two minutes earlier," said Irfan Babu, a local resident. Civic officials said the preliminary inquiry indicates that the branch broke due to strong wind.

The accident occurred on an internal road adjoining Lal Bahadur Shastri Marg in Kurla. BJP corporator Harish Bhandirge told *The Indian Express* that the road on which the tree stands was concretised in March this year. Sunday's incident also drew criticism from Opposition leaders targeting the ruling Mahayuti alliance in the BMC.

IMD issues heavy rain alert in several states

Anjali Marar
Bengaluru, July 5

WITH THE formation of season's first depression over the Bay of Bengal, eight states across India's central and west coast are expected to receive extremely heavy to heavy rainfall over the next two days.

For Monday, IMD has issued a 'red alert' for Chhattisgarh, Konkan and Madhya Maharashtra, and eastern Gujarat. The alert will continue for Tuesday

in Konkan, Madhya Maharashtra and eastern Gujarat while it will be downgraded to 'orange alert' in Chhattisgarh, which will experience very heavy rainfall (110-200mm in 24 hours) on Tuesday, the IMD said.

Overall, Chhattisgarh, Konkan and eastern Gujarat are likely to experience extremely heavy spells (more than 200mm in 24 hours) during the next two to three days, the IMD has warned.

Meanwhile, on Sunday, sev-

eral areas in Mumbai and ghats of Pune in Madhya Maharashtra recorded very heavy spells of rainfall. Some of the wettest areas recorded along the west coast of Maharashtra were Raigad district's Bhira (386mm); Pune district's Tamhini (310mm) and Shrigaon in Palghar (275mm). Besides, Colaba in Mumbai (265mm), Lonavala in Pune district (263mm), Vikhroli in Mumbai (257mm), Shirpur in Dhule district (249mm), Koyana in Satara district (210mm), be-

sides Byculla (188mm) and Bandra (163mm) in Mumbai also recorded significant rainfall.

Outside Maharashtra, Odisha saw extremely heavy spells with the highest 24-hour rainfall (ranging from 190mm to 280mm) recorded across Kandhamal, Cuttack and Nawapara districts.

India Meteorological Department (IMD) officials said that the heightened rainfall activity is due to the formation of the season's first depression.

J&K minister vows strict action over books 'glorifying' separatists, police search publisher

Arun Sharma
Jammu, June 5

AFTER THE Jammu and Kashmir government withdrew two books from its school libraries on the grounds that they contained "highly inappropriate content" on separatism, the counter-intelligence wing of the J&K Police conducted searches at the Jammu premises of the publisher of one of the books after an FIR was registered under the Unlawful Activities Prevention Act.

Meanwhile, J&K Education Minister Sakina Itoo on Sunday described the matter as "unfortunate" and a "deliberate conspiracy", saying that strict action would be taken against those found involved in the supply of such books to schools. She said "suspension orders have been issued and an enquiry ordered" into the matter.

On Saturday, eight officials from the school department

were suspended, and one contractual employee was terminated from service after the row broke out. The withdrawn books, 'Personalities and Legends of J&K' by Hilal Ahmed and Santosh Meena, and 'Great Personalities of Jammu and Kashmir' by Dr Sushant Giri, were published by Oberoi Book Service, Jammu, and Anurag Prakashan, Delhi, and supplied to school libraries as part of Samagra Shiksha for higher secondary classes.

According to an order by the Commissioner/Secretary, School Education Department, the books contained references with the "potential to create law-and-order issues", and their selection reflected "serious negligence, dereliction of duty and lack of due diligence". The order also blacklisted the authors and their publishing houses from publishing any other material in the Union Territory.

{ TEEJAN BAI • 1956-2026 }

Folk icon who broke centuries-old cultural barriers to transform Pandavani

Suanshu Khurana
New Delhi, July 5

AS A young girl, when Teejan Bai decided to sing her family folk form, Pandavani, she was beaten by her father.

"No woman had ever dared to sing this style of music," she recalled in an interview with this reporter in 2014. In the Pardhi community — the indigenous nomadic community she came from — music by women outside of one's home was considered blasphemous. Determined to pursue music despite her parents not allowing her to sing, Teejan ran away from home to a village called Chandkhuri in Durg district, 25 km from Chhattisgarh's capital, Raipur. It was a decision that cost her a place in her community, but one that would go on to

change the trajectory of Pandavani as a folk form. She would go on to become one of its most well-known artists.

Teejan Bai, the noted Pandavani exponent who broke centuries-old cultural barriers and became the first woman from her Pardhi community to perform the folk form, eventually making it popular globally, passed away at AIIMS Raipur in the early hours of Sunday after a prolonged illness. She leaves behind a legacy that transformed one of Chhattisgarh's oldest oral traditions into a popular art form that found many takers internationally. Teejan would have been 70 in August, was unable to speak for over six months and was communicating with hand gestures.

Pandavani is a traditional performing art form where art-

istes musically narrate and enact stories from the Mahabharata. While it originated in Chhattisgarh, it is also performed in Madhya Pradesh and Odisha.

Born in Ganiyari, near Bhilai in Chhattisgarh, Teejan Bai grew up listening to her mother's bhajans at home and was fascinated by the Pandavani ballads narrated by her maternal grandfather, Brijlal Pardhi.

At the time, the tradition was performed only by men. But when Teejan Bai decided she was going to sing, her family was not comfortable with a woman propping herself up on the stage as a singer.

Married off at 12, Teejan refused to give up music and left her husband's home at 13. Ostracised by the Pardhi commu-



Teejan Bai turned one of Chhattisgarh's oldest oral traditions into a popular art form

nity for singing a form reserved for men, she spent years living in a small hut away from everyone.

In Chandkhuri, Teejan performed her first show at the age of 13 for Rs 10. In the Kapalik style, in which the performer

stands, moves freely across the stage and enacts various characters from the Mahabharata epic, her swagger on stage with a dotaara on her shoulder would captivate audiences instantly.

The people embraced the artiste that a community had rejected.

Teejan soon began receiving invitations to perform, taking her far beyond the boundaries of her village. One of her notable performances was at the prestigious Bharat Bhawan in Bhopal on the invitation of the Adilashi Lok Kala Parishad. But there was another that changed her life completely — while performing in Madhya Pradesh in the 1970s, Teejan was discovered by famed Urdu playwright Habib Tanvir, who was awestruck by her guttural voice

and confident performance of a relatively unknown folk form. He integrated her into his Naya Theatre Group and arranged a showcase for then Prime Minister Indira Gandhi, one that catapulted her to national and later international fame. She particularly enjoyed performing in Paris. "I have been there eight times," she told *The Indian Express* in 2014.

Teejan Bai's talent and her work in the arts eventually earned her some of the country's biggest honours, including the Padma Shri (1988), Padma Bhushan (2003) and Padma Vibushan (2019), as well as the Sangeet Natak Akademi Award (1995).

Prime Minister Narendra Modi paid tribute to Teejan Bai in a post on social media, saying, "I am deeply saddened by

the passing of the renowned Pandavani singer Teejan Bai ji. Through her grand performances, she gave this folk art form of Chhattisgarh a unique identity across the world. Her departure is an irreplaceable loss to the world of art and culture."

In her personal life, Teejan suffered tragic losses, with the deaths of two of her three children. Her surviving son runs a shop.

Her secretary Manharan Sarva, who is also a dancer and musician, said one of Teejan's grandchildren performs Pandavani. "Among her seven grandsons and five granddaughters, just one grandson, 27-year-old Saurabh, performs," said Sarva, who was with Teejan for over two decades.

She also trained over 200 students, many of whom carry

forward the art she devoted her life to. One of them is Taruna Sahu, who is posted as an inspector with the Railway Protection Force (RPF) in Rajnandgaon. She remembers meeting Teejan when she was just 10 and was selected to be trained by the noted performer.

"With 15 days of training, we performed the Draupadi Swayamvar with her. Since then, I performed over 50 times with her. I was a small-town girl. Teejan didi gave me an identity," said Sahu, who lived with Teejan for 16 years.

A major part of Teejan Bai's legacy is the courage she showed in breaking the barriers she faced, paving the way for other women performers who continue to perform Pandavani globally. (WITH INPUTS BY JAYPRAKASH SNAIDU IN RAIPUR)



El Niño, Iran sharpen food prices challenge

THE SOUTHWEST monsoon was 39.8 per cent below normal in June, with the all-India average rainfall of 99.5 mm the fifth lowest recorded for that month after 2014, 2009, 1926 and 1905. This month, which coincides with the peak plantings of the kharif crop, has been better so far. Not only has the cumulative rainfall deficit for the season (June-September) narrowed to 24.1 per cent as on July 5, the monsoon has advanced to cover roughly 95 per cent of the country's area. That should, in turn, help boost kharif sowing acreages, which were overall 22.7 per cent lower compared to last year's coverage till June 25. The lag was even more for oilseeds (53.3 per cent), pulses (30.5 per cent) and cotton (34.6 per cent). Those gaps can potentially close with the monsoon's revival from June 30.

But the outlook, on the whole, is still not great. The India Meteorological Department has forecast average rainfall over the country for July, too, to "most likely to be below normal". Worse, the dreaded El Niño is in a "moderate" phase now, while predicted to intensify into a "strong" event during the second half of the monsoon season and turn "very strong" over October-January. The impact wouldn't be limited to the monsoon rainfall and the kharif crops grown during this season. Since El Niño is known to suppress rainfall and also raise temperatures, it could result in a relatively short and warm winter, affecting the upcoming rabi season crops like wheat, mustard, *chana*, *masoor* and potato as well. The last "strong" El Niño event of 2023-24 led to annual retail food inflation averaging over 8.5 per cent between July 2023 and December 2024. Without proactive supply-side management, there is every risk of a repeat of that protracted episode of elevated food prices.

India imported a record 16.9 million tonnes (mt) of vegetable oils in 2025-26 and 7.3 mt of pulses the previous fiscal. El Niño — which has overtaken Iran as the No 1 risk factor for the Indian economy today — will make further imports inevitable. While keeping the import window open, the government must ensure minimum support prices for pulses, oilseeds, millets and cotton through payment of the difference over open market rates. It will incentivise farmers to cultivate these crops, instead of water-intensive rice, wheat and sugarcane. The year 2026-27 will also test the flagship crop insurance (PMFBY) and rural employment (VB-G RAM G) schemes. Their implementation on the ground matters as much as the supply-side measures to control food inflation.

Bengaluru creche ordeal points to a crisis of care

FOR MOST working parents, leaving a toddler at a daycare is as much an act of necessity as a leap of faith — that the vigilance and kindness of well-meaning strangers will stand in for a parent's own presence for those hours. The alleged abuse of toddlers at an on-campus crèche of global IT firm Capgemini in Bengaluru, where children too young to articulate or comprehend their ordeal were locked in washrooms and washing machines to discipline them, strikes at the heart of that trust. The incident raises disturbing questions about a sector that has come up in response to changing family structures and rising workforce participation of women but still lacks commensurate oversight mechanisms.

Reliable childcare is crucial to women's participation in the labour market. A Dalberg-UNDP study published earlier this year found that India's public childcare system currently meets only around 5 per cent of urban demand, while private alternatives are largely unaffordable for low-income families. An estimated 6-7 million urban women need crèche access, a figure projected to reach 20-23 million by 2047. The Maternity Benefit (Amendment) Act, 2017 requires establishments with 50 or more employees to provide crèche facilities, but it covers only a fraction of India's workforce and leaves the unorganised sector entirely out of its ambit. While the female labour force participation rate has risen to 41.7 per cent in 2023-24, it is driven by rural, often unpaid or distress-led self-employment. Urban female participation has stayed stubbornly in the mid-to-high twenties. Each reported case of abuse leads to more women cutting back hours, turning down professional opportunities, or leaving the workforce entirely to take on the onus of care work.

While the investigation in Bengaluru must run its course, justice after the fact cannot substitute prevention. That task begins with recognising childcare as essential social and economic infrastructure rather than a discretionary employment perk. At present, daycare centres are governed by an uneven web of state rules, municipal by-laws and local licensing norms, with little uniformity in standards and even less consistency in enforcement. India needs a national regulatory framework that establishes minimum standards for registration, caregiver training, staff verification, child-to-caregiver ratios, inspections and grievance-redressal mechanisms. Regulation must also be matched by sustained public investment to expand access to quality childcare, ensuring that safety is a right, not a privilege.

FREEZE FRAME

Let us stick to the Japanese greeting for now, Sir. When you look up, there are more war clouds than rain clouds.



The Editorial Page

MONDAY, JULY 6, 2026

From the Iran conflict, four geopolitical shifts India cannot afford to miss



OVER THE BARREL
BY VIKRAM S MEHTA

THE FOG of conflict in the Middle East has lifted somewhat, and one can now discern the geoeconomic and geopolitical changes it has wrought. Whether these changes dissolve over time and conditions revert to the status quo ante February 28, the day American bombers took out the leadership of Iran, or calcify into an invariant structural shift remains to be seen. Irrespective, petroleum-import-dependent countries like India should factor these changes into their discussions on energy and national security.

In this article, I identify four such changes.

First, diminishing confidence in America as a guarantor of security. Other than the most hardened MAGA acolyte, everyone agrees that America was worsted by Iran in this conflict. It failed to achieve any of its stated objectives (regime change, elimination/dilution of Iran's cache of weapons-grade uranium and degradation of Iran as a regional power) despite, according to its Central Command, American bombers flying 10,000 sorties, hitting 1,30,000 targets inside Iran, destroying 85 per cent of Iran's missile manufacturing capabilities and 70 per cent of its missile launch infrastructure and sinking most of its navy between February 28 and April 8, the date of the first ceasefire.

Moreover, America failed to protect its Gulf allies from Iranian missiles and drones. Saudi Arabia, the UAE, Qatar, Bahrain and Kuwait all suffered physical and economic damage during the conflict. These countries had permitted America to establish military bases in their territory in exchange for the assurance of such protection. US Secretary of State Marco Rubio recently toured the region to smooth ruffled feathers, but more than anything he may have said, I suspect it was the words of his predecessor, Henry Kissinger, that resonated with the Middle East leaders: "It may be dangerous to be America's enemy, but to be America's friend is fatal". This dent in confidence opens up space for non-Western countries to deepen their security relationships in the region and, in particular, creates an opportunity for India's defence-related manufacturing and technology companies to explore mutually beneficial opportunities.

Second, the emergence of "choke points" as a lever of power. The Strait of Hormuz, through which 20 per cent of global oil supplies flow, has long been recognised as a potential source of market disruption, but essentially only in analysis. Conventional wisdom has held that Iran does not have the capability to enforce a shipping blockade. Indeed, the one time it sought to do so in 1988, the US 5th Fleet blew up two Iranian frigates, demolished oil platforms and cleared the sub-sea mines within days. Oil tankers were barely impeded. This wisdom has now been upended. Through a combination of missile threats, attacks by small but fast speed boats and adroit social messaging, Iran did halt shipping traffic. The economic and political impact was a

India can reduce its exposure by expanding the storage capacity for strategic petroleum reserves from the current roughly eight days to at least 30 days, or better still, 60 days.

In AI Age, America will need to lead with renewed generosity



SAM PITRODA

AS AMERICA celebrates 250 years of independence, I write with deep gratitude, great admiration and growing concern. I arrived in the US 62 years ago as a young immigrant from India. America and Chicago opened doors to me, gave me education, work, freedom, opportunity, confidence and the space to build a family and dream. I experienced the power of America's Constitution, the resilience of its democracy, the fairness of the rule of law, the openness of its universities, the energy of its entrepreneurs and the love of the American people.

For more than six decades, about 25 per cent of independent America's life, I have lived the American experiment. It is imperfect, yet extraordinary. America's greatness has never been only its wealth or military power. Its deeper greatness has been its spirit, optimism, openness, innovation, and belief in the individual.

America helped invent the modern world. Electricity, the telephone, the transistor, computers, the Internet, mobile communications and now AI have transformed the lives of billions. Much of this progress came from America's unique ability to combine science, capital, universities, immigration, entrepreneurship and freedom.

America also showed moral imagination after World War II. Rather than celebrating victory, it helped rebuild Europe and Japan. It invested in alliances, institutions and understood that a stronger world would also make America stronger. This outward-looking America inspired the world.

But as we celebrate, we must also be honest. The history of humanity — including that of America — includes colonisation, slavery, violence, racism, exclusion, hunger, poverty and inequality. Too often, power has been used to dominate. Too often, progress has uplifted some while leaving many behind.

America's genius has been its ability to confront its contradictions and renew itself. Today, humanity faces another turning point. AI will reshape every profession, institution and society. Climate change threatens the planet. Wars continue to destroy lives. Democracies are under pres-

America is already great. The larger task is to make humanity greater. On this 250th birthday, let us celebrate the American Dream. But let us also expand it

sure. Public trust is declining. Technology is connecting us, but also dividing us. No nation can solve these problems alone.

That is why America must resist the temptation to define the future mainly as a competition with China. The competition is real. America must invest in science, technology, education, infrastructure and national strength. But it did not become exceptional because it feared another nation. It became exceptional because it imagined a better future.

At 250, America should ask a larger question: How can we help humanity rise to the next level?

This is the moment for a new American pledge — humans deserve equal respect and dignity; opportunity must not depend on birth, race, gender, religion, geography or wealth; technology must serve people and the planet; democracy and the rule of law must be protected; freedom must include responsibility; prosperity must be shared.

AI gives America a historic opportunity to lead again — not merely in building powerful machines, but in building a more humane world. AI can help educate every child with a personal tutor. It can help doctors reach remote villages. It can improve agriculture, reduce waste, accelerate scientific discovery and make governments more responsive. But AI can also concentrate power, destroy trust, deepen inequality and manipulate minds.

This is where America's founding ideals remain essential. Liberty, justice, equality before the law, freedom of thought and respect for human dignity can be the foundation for the AI age as well. To make America great is not enough. America is already great. The larger task is to make humanity greater.

On this 250th birthday, let us celebrate the American Dream. But let us also expand it. The first 250 years were about building a nation. The next 250 should be about helping humanity dream bigger — with equal respect, equal dignity, equal opportunity and equal possibility for all.

The writer is a telecom inventor, entrepreneur, and policy maker who has spent 50 years in IT



AMULYA DHAWAN

Cockroaches and a reckoning with unkept promises

THE COCKROACH Janta Party began as a satire page, floating a half-serious idea in response to the Chief Justice of India's remark dismissing a generation struggling to find employment: What if we built a fraternity of our own? Within a day, it had gone viral. Since then, I have worked as a volunteer, and learned that the idea spread because years of suppression had finally found a language.

We are a generation conditioned to experiencing one another as threats, taught that scarcity is natural and suspicion the only rational posture toward our peers. So when someone proposed, half in jest, that we might instead form a community, talk to each other in our pain, stop being called parasites in isolation, it landed as a glimmer of something we had been denied. We disagree, fumble, and revise ourselves in public. There are ideological differences, and rather than papering over them into cohesion, the attempt is to work through them. Young people sometimes reproduce the very paternalism we say we are against, the reflex of a gerontocratic order that treats youth as a thing to be managed.

The sympathetic observer reads this as immaturity. However, when the movement reveals its ruptures, it is not failing to transcend the society that made it. It is rendering that society legible. The social and political cleavages in the room are reflections of those outside it, which need to be resolved. A movement that presented itself as already pure would be repeating the oldest lie in Indian public life, that emancipation can be declared from inside structures one has not yet worked through. The cockroaches refuse that lie. Theirs is a reflexive politics still forming, one that takes its own compromised formation as the first thing to be reckoned with. They stay in the argument, on exclusion, on who gets spoken over, on what representation actually requires, because this working-through is at the core of reform.

B R Ambedkar warned, on the eve of the republic, that we were entering a life of contradiction, a political democracy laid over a social order that denied the equality it proclaimed. The examination hall was supposed to be one of the few places where contradiction was resolved, the rare site where the accident of birth would yield to effort. When a question paper leaks, the resolution collapses, and the contradiction Ambedkar named arrives as a lived discovery that the one promised ladder out of inherited disadvantage was rigged. The youth is demanding to reclaim the redemption of that promise. And it is not only the young. The collapse of the education system is the collapse of a society's basic promise: That jobs and schooling are the route to upward movement.

The BJP is vulnerable and still being built. But I would not exchange its struggle for the composure of the babu-uncle culture of subservience that brought us here. The cockroaches are creating what resonates with the youth: A reckoning with how far social reality still sits from the equality the republic promised.

When the movement reveals its ruptures, it is not failing to transcend the society that made it. It is rendering that society legible

The writer, a student of Political Science and Sociology at Ashoka University, volunteers as a media coordinator with the movement led by Cockroach Janta Party

40 YEARS AGO

July 6, 1986



Akali Dal formally splits

THE AKALI Dal formally split when a convention of the dissidents elected Parkash Singh Badal, former chief minister, party president after "removing" the Punjab Chief Minister, Surjit Singh Barnala, from the post. The convention, which the organisers claimed was attended by 342 of the 468 delegates of the Akali Dal, also "expelled" Barnala from the primary membership of the party.

PM's Mauritius visit

THE PRIME Minister, Rajiv Gandhi, wound up his two-day visit to Mauritius, proposing a Commonwealth package to offset losses suffered by some countries as a result of sever-

ing links with the racist regime of South Africa. He reiterated India's stand on declaring the Indian Ocean a zone of peace and assured the island nation of India's support in its demand for restoration of the Chagos archipelago, which, he said, has been "prised loose to make Diego Garcia into a base".

Tamil militants meet MGR

THE FIVE Sri Lankan militant groups have told Tamil Nadu CM M G Ramachandran that the latest proposals of the island government for a solution to the ethnic problem are not acceptable in the present form. At their second round of discussions with MGR at the chief minister's residence, the Liberation Tigers of Tamil Eelam (LTTE), the Eelam Revol-

utionary Organisation (EROS), the Eelam People's Revolutionary Liberation Front (EPRLF), the Tamil Eelam Liberation Organisation (TELO) and the People's Liberation Organisation for Tamil Eelam (PLOTE) also told Ramachandran that they would not be going to New Delhi since the Indian government had not invited any of them for discussions.

5 killed in Goa bridge collapse

FIVE PERSONS were killed when the 15-year-old Mandovi bridge, forming the only surface link between Panaji and North Goa, collapsed. The government has ordered a judicial inquiry into the collapse, which has left the town totally stunned.

● **WHAT THE OTHERS SAY**
Those who cannot remember the past are condemned to repeat it.
— *George Santayana*

●

Rice-to-ethanol policy is deepening economic and environmental stress



FROM PLATE TO PLOUGH
BY ASHOK GULATI, RITIKA JUNEJA AND PURVI THANGARAJ

INDIA PRODUCED 154 million metric tonnes (MMT) of rice in 2025-26, surpassing China to become the world's largest producer. India is also the top rice exporter, with exports of 24.5 MMT in 2025. This accounts for roughly 40 per cent of the global rice trade (61.3 MMT), exceeding the total exported by the next four largest exporters — Vietnam, Thailand, Pakistan and Cambodia. India also gives free food (Rs 5/kg/person/month) to about 800 million people under the National Food Security Act (NFSA), of which almost two-thirds is rice. Even after this, the Food Corporation of India (FCI) held rice stocks of almost five times the buffer norm as of April 1. In 2024-25 (FY25), the carrying cost of this extra buffer stock was Rs 10,712 crore. The government has decided to divert significant quantities of broken/damaged rice to ethanol production to reduce these stocks and cut down carrying costs. In FY26, almost 5 MMT of rice has been used to produce ethanol. The economic cost of rice to FCI in FY27 is likely to be Rs 44/kg, while it is being given to ethanol plants at roughly Rs 23/kg, renewing the food-vs-fuel debate and raising questions about who is subsidising whom.

How did India, a country that lived from “ship to mouth” in the mid-1960s, become the world's largest rice producer, exporter, free distributor, and ethanol maker from the grain? The Green Revolution's success is only one part of the story. The other, more recent and disturbing, is the story of subsidies, which are wreaking havoc not only on the fisc but also on the environment, through higher greenhouse gas (GHG) emissions, soil degradation, groundwater contamination and biodiversity loss. Let us delve deeper and explore how India can rationalise rice pol-



ILLUSTRATION: C.R SASIKUMAR

icies for a financially and environmentally sustainable future.

Three interlocking policies seem to be responsible for this situation. First, the open-ended procurement at the minimum support price (MSP). Although the MSP for paddy is Rs 2,369/quintal (2025-26), states often outbid each other. Chhattisgarh pays about 40 per cent above MSP, Telangana about 20 per cent, while others, such as Andhra Pradesh, Odisha, Punjab and Haryana, have their own variants of this competitive largesse either in the form of input subsidy or bonus on top of MSP. Second, free or near-free power across the rice belt. Since rice is a flood-irrigated crop that demands up to 25 irrigations per season, free power is effectively a licence to mine groundwater without consequence. Third, urea is sold at a price that bears no relation to its cost. The retail price of urea has been frozen at Rs 242 per 45-kg bag for years, with the government absorbing 85-90 per cent of the economic cost. India's own landed import price for urea had spiked to \$935-\$959/tonne in May

The ethanol blending programme is not a bad idea, in itself — it involves at least 20 per cent blending. However, mandating that ethanol producers source a fixed share of feedstock from FCI rice is counterproductive

— thanks to a modicum of cooling in the Strait of Hormuz conflict, the price now has dropped to a little less than half this amount. Yet, this huge arbitrage drives chronic over-application of urea on paddy fields as well as diversion to other industries and across borders. According to an ICRIER study, the combined subsidies (power, fertiliser and canal water) for paddy cultivation in Punjab amounted to Rs 38,973/hectare in 2023-24. These distorted and politically motivated policies of bonuses over MSP, coupled with highly subsidised power and fertilisers, have resulted in FCI's stocks overflowing. Rather than fixing the distorted incentive structure that

has created such piles of rice, the government has chosen a second exit valve: Pour it into ethanol distilleries.

The ethanol blending programme is not a bad idea, in itself — it involves at least 20 per cent blending. However, mandating that ethanol producers source a fixed share of feedstock from FCI rice is counterproductive. This is like going back to Soviet-era con-

trols. Bureaucracy and politicians love controls as they benefit from rent-seeking. Industry wants freedom to choose the most efficient feedstock — whether maize, sugarcane, or rice — which government policies don't permit. So, the two strike a deal — rice, whose economic cost to FCI is Rs 44/kg, is sold to ethanol plants at Rs 23/kg on the justification that it is broken and damaged.

Production of a kilogram of rice requires, on average, about 4,000 litres of irrigation water. Even if one assumes half of it percolates back to aquifers, the other half is absorbed partially by the plant, and the remaining evaporates. Transplantation, the dominant practice in rice cultivation, emits large amounts of methane, which is 25 times more potent than carbon dioxide. And when states like Punjab and Haryana use almost 250/kg of fertiliser per hectare, they emit almost 5 tonnes of carbon dioxide/ha as the plant absorbs not more than 35-40 per cent of nitrogen — the rest goes into the environment as nitrous oxide, which is 273 times more potent as a GHG than carbon dioxide, or leaches into groundwater, contaminating it with nitrate. The contamination has been linked to blue baby syndrome, thyroid, diabetes and increased cancer risk. Why are we imposing such hazards on ourselves?

This must change. Otherwise, a boon of technology will become a bane of humanity. Wisdom lies in changing the course of the MSP policy. No bonuses, and limit the procurement in all states to not more than 40 per cent of its production. No compulsion on ethanol plants to use rice from FCI. Maize is a much better option for ethanol production. Limit the free supplies under PDS to only the most vulnerable — antyodaya — and charge the rest at least half the MSP. Promote direct-seeded rice to conserve water. And above all, fix fertiliser-related issues by moving from subsidies to income support to farmers and decontrolling fertiliser prices. If the Narendra Modi government can implement such reforms, it will do a great service to India's farmers and our planet.

Gulati is distinguished professor, Juneja a senior fellow, and Thangaraj a consultant at ICRIER. Views are personal



KIRIT S PARIKH

BY THE end of June, oil prices had come down to \$74 per barrel, the pre-crisis level of early February. I must confess to being pleasantly surprised by the fall in prices. Iran's bombing of the Middle East's oil infrastructure made me think it would take many months for global supply to recover and crude prices to fall to pre-crisis levels. However, price is an outcome of both supply and demand. With high prices, some reduction in consumption can be expected. But the demand for Gulf oil has also fallen because countries diversified their sources, and took measures to enhance long-term oil security.

India has managed the crisis very well. Supply was ensured. Hardly any retail outlet ran dry. Domestic consumption was reduced with 20 per cent ethanol blending. Electric mobility was pushed. Consumers were protected: Prices were not increased in step with import prices, and oil marketing companies and the government bore a large part of the burden. This was justifiable if the government expected the crisis to last no more than three to four months. Fortunately, it was proved right. The revenue forgone was Rs 1.7 lakh crore. The consumer price of petrol was later increased by Rs 3 per litre, around a 7 per cent increase. The price increase is by far the smallest among major oil-importing countries.

More than half of the LPG consumed by Indian kitchens would arrive through the Gulf, and that suddenly stopped. Government ac-

Supply was ensured. Domestic consumption was reduced with 20 per cent ethanol blending. Consumers were protected: Prices for them were not increased in step with import prices

tion was decisive. An LPG control order, issued within eight days of the disruption, directed domestic refineries to increase production. Within seven days, production increased from 35,000 to 54,000 tonnes per day. The regulated price of LPG was kept at Rs 942, and for the beneficiaries of the Pradhan Mantri Ujjwala Yojana at Rs 642, with a direct benefit transfer of Rs 300 per month to nearly 10.6 crore households. Commercial LPG supply was restrained for some time, and industrial and commercial users were encouraged to use other fuels.

The management of supply has been built on infrastructure developed over the last decade or so. Between 2011 and 2022, LPG import terminals doubled, to 22, increasing the country's LPG import capacity from 12 MMTPA to 32.3 MMTPA. At the same time, the city gas distribution network coverage increased from 55 cities to 300-plus cities. From 2011 to 2022, LNG import terminals doubled, and India expanded its crude oil sourcing network from 27 to 41 countries, which facilitated supply diversification and inter-fuel substitution.

India was also able to get a number of its ships through the Strait of Hormuz despite the blockade. This required coordination between more than one institution and ministry. The Ministry of Petroleum and Natural Gas identified and shared the list of priority vessels carrying India-bound cargo with the Ministry of Ports, Shipping

and Waterways. The latter compiled additional vessel-specific information and forwarded it to the MEA, which liaised directly with the Iranian embassy in New Delhi to seek clearances, while simultaneously instructing the Indian embassy in Tehran to expedite the processing of such requests by engaging with Iranian authorities. The Navy then coordinated with the vessels to ensure their safe passage through the Strait of Hormuz. This approach ensured that requests were pursued through both capitals at once, reducing the turnaround time for approvals.

India has long been concerned about disruptions in oil and gas supply from the Gulf. Its bilateral engagements with several countries, which predate the crisis, facilitated the diversification of imports. India continues exploration efforts domestically as well as beyond the country's shores and has procured oil and gas assets abroad. Thus, in a sense, the crisis has made India a little more energy secure.

However, the challenge for the government is not over. Consumers have been protected at a high cost to the government and oil marketing companies. The government faces a challenge in keeping inflation in check, the fiscal deficit on target and facilitating investment to ensure growth, while keeping expenditure on education and health on track. One hopes it will attain these targets.

The writer is chairman, Integrated Research and Action for Development (IRADE)

West Asia crisis has made India more energy secure



NIKITA AND BHARGABI GHOSH

ACCORDING TO data compiled by AQLin, 97 Indian cities featured among the world's top 100 hottest cities in May. Banda in Bundelkhand, Balangir in Odisha, Sasaram in Bihar and Varanasi in UP all hovered around 47-48°C. A few weeks before, the Union Cabinet approved India's revised Nationally Determined Contributions under the Paris Agreement, pledging to expand its carbon sink through forest and tree cover, increase non-fossil power capacity to 60 per cent, and reduce GDP emissions intensity by 47 per cent from 2005 levels by 2035. India has a strong record of meeting climate commitments. Yet the institutions dealing most di-

rectly with water stress, changing rainfall patterns and livelihood disruptions — gram panchayats — remain at the margins of climate planning.

Across rural India, climate change is reshaping everyday life. Farmers who once planned their sowing around fairly predictable monsoons now find themselves guessing when the rains will arrive and whether they will last long enough to sustain a crop. In many places, wells run dry before summer has ended and households are changing what they grow and eat. This is particularly consequential when set against rural-to-urban migration that is reshaping India's demographic geography.

It has been over three decades since the 73rd Amendment identified 29 subjects for devolution to gram panchayats, including water management, agriculture, social for-

estry and natural resource management, which sit at the centre of India's adaptation challenge today. The 16th Finance Commission, for the first time, integrated climate factors into its devolution recommendations. But the Panchayat Advancement Index 2.0 (PAI) and the Panchayat Devolution Index both show that functional devolution has declined in the same period. Without effective financial transfers, meaningful procedural authority, and genuine planning power, gram panchayats struggle to effectively respond to climate change.

There are many proven local models

When local representatives have opportunities to exchange what works, solutions travel faster

that demonstrate what becomes possible when gram panchayats are supported: Hiware Bazar in Maharashtra transformed a drought-prone landscape through watershed management, helped in part by lessons from neighbouring Ralegan Siddhi. A water conservation model from Bela in Maharashtra has direct relevance for a gram panchayat facing drought in Garhwal. The way a gram panchayat in Bokaro has used District Mineral Foundation funds for ecological restoration offers a working template for similar efforts in Chhattisgarh. Weather-risk management practices from Kerala's coastal gram panchayats can inform flood-prone communities in Assam. The Conference of Panchayats initiative, which has engaged more than 1,100 gram panchayats across five states, has shown that when local represen-

tatives have opportunities to exchange what works, solutions travel faster.

Three things would give ambitious climate targets a local foundation. First, the NAPCC and State Action Plans should formally bring gram panchayats in as planning partners with defined responsibilities and financial transfers. Second, PAI's nine thematic areas should connect high-performing panchayats with lagging ones in the same region, so that solutions move laterally rather than top down. Third, the 16th Finance Commission's climate-linked devolution must be paired with the procedural authority for gram panchayats to plan, not only to spend.

Nikita is consultant, Public Policy Advisory. Ghosh is associate director, Strategic Communications & Public Policy Advisory, Policy & Development Advisory Group

PM's Indonesia visit could lay foundations of nickel diplomacy



AJAI MALHOTRA

INDIA'S TRANSITION to electric mobility and clean energy requires secure access to critical minerals, especially nickel. The world's largest nickel reserves lie in Indonesia, where Chinese investment has established a dominant position in downstream processing. The future of clean energy will depend as much on nickel-processing plants as on EV factories. India may have only a few years to establish a meaningful presence in Indonesia's nickel value chain. Prime Minister Narendra Modi's visit to Indonesia from July 6 to 8 could offer India its best opportunity to secure a place in the critical mineral value chains that will shape its energy transition and supply-chain resilience.

The visit reciprocates President Prabowo Subianto's 2025 visit to India. It opens a six-day Indo-Pacific tour that will also take PM Modi to New Zealand and Australia. Indonesia is among India's oldest partners in Asia. Indian cultural links with Java, Bali and Sumatra stretch back centuries, while the 1955 Bandung Conference helped lay the foundations of the Non-Aligned Movement. Today, that shared legacy finds expression in a strategic partnership spanning the Indian Ocean and the wider Indo-Pacific. The world's largest archipelagic state, Indonesia straddles the Malacca Strait, one of the world's busiest maritime arteries, whose western approach India guards. As Asia's two largest democracies, their shared boundary in the Andaman Sea makes cooperation on maritime security and connectivity imperative. India's Act East Policy, too, aligns closely with Indonesia's maritime ambitions — Sabang port in Aceh province illustrates the strategic potential. Building on the 2018 Comprehensive Strategic Partnership, the PM's visit aims to translate strategic convergence into practical cooperation on critical minerals, connectivity, healthcare, space, digital public infrastructure and tourism.

Indonesia also possesses cobalt, bauxite, tin and rare earths. India requires a sustained commercial presence across Indonesia's critical-mineral value chains through joint ventures, upstream equity and mineral-processing partnerships. The strategy's success will depend on Indian industry's ability to match the speed of its Chinese counterparts in establishing a meaningful

presence in Indonesia's nickel value chain. If PM Modi's Jakarta visit propels that conversation, President Prabowo's expected visit to India for the BRICS Summit in September could provide an early opportunity to advance it.

Indonesia is India's second-largest ASEAN trading partner, but economic ties remain below potential. India runs a trade deficit of about US\$20 billion. The two governments aim to expand bilateral trade to US\$100 billion by 2030.

If critical minerals represent the visit's longer-term strategic opportunity, defence cooperation might provide its most tangible immediate outcome. Substantial progress in Jakarta towards acquiring BrahMos supersonic cruise missiles would strengthen Indonesia's deterrent capability. Building on the BrahMos export to the Philippines, it would burnish India's credentials as a reliable security partner for countries seeking stronger defence capabilities without becoming entangled in great-power rivalries.

China's growing maritime assertiveness forms the strategic backdrop. Beijing's “Nine-Dash Line” overlaps Indonesia's Exclusive Economic Zone around the Natuna Islands. While India works through arrangements such as the Quad, Indonesia maintains close economic ties with China even as it expands maritime cooperation with India and others.

As Southeast Asia's largest economy and a leading ASEAN voice, Indonesia has a central place in India's Indo-Pacific strategy. The two countries share an interest in preserving freedom of navigation, maintaining regional stability and strengthening ASEAN centrality. Indonesia's BRICS and Indian Ocean Rim Association memberships broaden the platforms through which both countries can advance shared interests.

Thanks in part to alphabetic seating at the UN General Assembly, Indian and Indonesian diplomats have for decades worked alongside one another, developing camaraderie and trust that underpins the bilateral partnership.

Connectivity is of growing importance. Limited direct flights, inadequate shipping links and restrictive visa protocols constrain ties. Initiatives linking the Andaman and Nicobar Islands with Indonesia's Aceh Province deserve greater momentum.

PM Modi's visit signals India's intent to deepen engagement with one of its most consequential maritime neighbours. The two countries do not merely share an ocean; they share responsibility for preserving its stability and openness, while deepening cooperation on critical minerals and supply-chain resilience.

The writer is distinguished fellow, TERI and a former senior diplomat

US at 250

IF AMERICA has always been accustomed to exceptionalism, then that prestige has been globally driven. However, the current US trajectory of stifling the very potential that “made America great” is an inescapable reality that cannot be overlooked (‘At 250, the US can still reinvent itself’ — and the world’, *IE*, July 4). The brains that steered the nation towards wielding such an unassailable influence have been the result of an unrivalled cosmopolitan allure. Replacing this attraction with coercion by imposing punitive sanctions on close allies to force compliance seems to be the reinvention Washington seeks for itself and the world.

Raghvi Sharma, Sunam



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If there are questions of current or contemporary relevance that you would like explained, please write to explained@indianexpress.com

• INFRASTRUCTURE

Why Kerala is against Adani selling its stake in Vizhinjam port

Shaju Philip
Thiruvananthapuram, July 5

ADANI PORTS and SEZ (APSEZ) Ltd is moving to sell 49% of its stake in Kerala's Vizhinjam port to Switzerland-based container shipping behemoth MSC Group for around \$1.4 billion (more than Rs 13,000 crore).

The state government, however, has said that it was kept in the dark about the development. According to the Congress-led government — as well as the Opposition CPI(M) — the concession agreement with Adani mandates the state's approval for such a deal.

First, what is the Vizhinjam project?

Vizhinjam is India's first deep-water container transshipment port. It has emerged as a major destination for the world's largest container ships.

The project is being developed as a public-private partnership between the Kerala government and Adani Vizhinjam Port Pvt Ltd (AVPPL) — the port's operating company and concessionaire — under the design, build, finance, operate and transfer (DBFOT) model. The Kerala government, then led by the Congress, signed the concession agreement with AVPPL on August 17, 2015. After several delays, the first phase of the port was commissioned in December 2024, with the next stage slated for December 2028. The Kerala government invested Rs 5,595 crore in the first phase of the project while the Adani group put in Rs 2,454 crore. The DBFOT is for 40 years with provisions to extend it by 20 years.

What did Adani Ports do?

On June 30, APSEZ disclosed to market regulator SEBI that it had entered into a share purchase and subscription agreement with Mundi Ltd on the previous day.

Mundi Ltd is a subsidiary of Terminal Investment Ltd (TiL) which, in turn, is the terminal operating arm of the MSC.

Under the deal, the MSC subsidiary was to acquire the 49% stake in AVPPL for \$1.397 billion (around Rs 13,000 crore). This would be the largest foreign private investment in domestic port infrastructure if it goes through. The disclosure to SEBI has not set any deadline for the share transfer.

• **SIGNIFICANCE OF VIZHINJAM PORT**

- The Vizhinjam port is India's first deep water container transshipment port.
- A transshipment port includes terminals where containers are shifted from one vessel to another before they reach their final destination.

Why did Kerala government object?

The Kerala government has stated that Adani's decision to sell the 49% stake constitutes a change in ownership under the agreement's terms and, thus, requires government permission.

On Thursday, Chief Minister V D Sathesaran communicated the state's displeasure to Adani Ports and SEZ Ltd. His office said in a statement that the state envisaged the port as a competitive global container transshipment hub, one where all stakeholders would get a level playing field. The government fears that the deal will lead to a monopoly in shipping and container traffic for MSC, which is the world's biggest container shipping company.

What is the Adani group's stand?

AVPPL issued a communication to the state's ports department about the deal on July 1, a day after it disclosed the matter to SEBI. AVPPL is of the view that it was mandatory to inform the SEBI before approaching the state government seeking its consent.

According to the concession agreement, Adani must retain 51% share in the port during the construction period and the first year of commercial operations. Beyond the first year, it has to maintain a minimum share of 26%. According to the Adani group, the Vizhinjam port is now in its second year of operations, allowing it to dilute up to 74% of its stake.

What does the agreement say?

The agreement doesn't prohibit a stake sale, as laid out above. But it does say that Adani shall not undertake or permit any change in ownership, except with the prior approval of the authority — that is, the government. The agreement also defines what a "change in ownership" is. It says that transfer of equity in aggregate of 25% or more of the total equity of the concessionaire "shall constitute a change in ownership requiring prior approval of the authority from national security and public interest perspective". But the agreement does not define the contours of public interest.

• SPORT

Cape Verde: The tiny African nation that scripted 2026 WC's underdog story

Abhinav Chakraborty
New Delhi, July 5

"SIZE DEFINES nothing in football." Argentina's talisman and arguably the greatest footballer on the planet, Lionel Messi, would probably agree with this assessment by Pedro "Bubista" Brito, the head coach of what has become the 2026 FIFA World Cup's most celebrated underdog.

When Cape Verde managed to hold Argentina to a 1-1 scoreline at the end of 90 minutes in their Round of 32 knockout match late Friday, there was a real possibility that the tiny African island nation could prevail, having already denied victory to two former world champions — Spain and Uruguay — in the group stage.

That was not to be, but the result ensured that the Blue Sharks — the nickname

Cape Verde's football team goes by — had etched its place on the world football map.

Archipelago in the Atlantic

The Cape Verde Islands, officially the Republic of Cabo Verde, is an archipelago of 10 islands — nine of them inhabited — and various islets located some 450 km off the west coast of Africa in the Atlantic Ocean.

The islands were uninhabited until the Portuguese discovered them in 1456. Over the next few years, Portuguese settlers arrived and brought African slaves with them to work on plantations. By the 16th century, it became a hub for the transatlantic slave trade. This history meant that Cape Verdeans are of mixed African and European origin. It shows in the languages spoken there: while Portuguese is the official language, most local people also speak Crioulo,



a Creole dialect based on archaic Portuguese but influenced by other languages. The rise of anti-colonialist nationalists



Argentina's Lionel Messi (R) with Cape Verde goalkeeper Vozinha after the World Cup match on Friday. AP

across Asia and Africa in the 20th century did not bypass the island nation. To suppress calls for independence, Portugal

changed Cape Verde's status to an overseas province in 1951. That failed to quell growing unrest, and on July 5, 1975, Cape Verde's newly elected National Assembly received the instruments of independence from Portugal. After almost a decade-and-a-half of one-party rule, the country conducted a multi-party general election in 1991.

Since then, Cape Verde has been a stable electoral democracy.

World Cup exploits

The Blue Sharks joined FIFA only in 1985. But that they managed to qualify for the 2026 World Cup with a stellar record (7 wins, 2 draws and 1 loss in 10 games) and their subsequent performance in the tournament seem to have vindicated FIFA's decision to go in for an expanded 48-team format and enable smaller countries to

shine on the global stage.

Cape Verde are only the third smallest nation (by population) in the history of the World Cup — after Iceland (which played in 2018) and fellow 2026 debutants Curacao. The team derives strength from its compact organisation and tactical discipline.

That a country with a resident population of just over 500,000 has managed such a feat is down to history: unfavourable climate and few natural resources forced natives to emigrate abroad over the years, with over one million people of Cape Verdean ancestry presently living in the US, Europe, and even African countries such as Senegal. This diaspora came to Cape Verde's service: more than half (14) of the 26-member squad came from these communities, with those selected hailing from France, Portugal, the Netherlands, and Ireland.

• TECH

AI is reshaping warfare: How India can keep pace



EXPERT EXPLAINS
LT GEN RAJ SHUKLA (RETD)
FORMER ARMY COMMANDER, UPSC MEMBER

THE TRINITY of artificial intelligence (AI), military autonomy and algorithmic warfare is redefining modern-day warfighting and deterrence. The workflows of combat are being infused with AI and driven by autonomy, but what is making them unfailingly lethal is algorithmic precision. Indeed, these three factors are poised to exponentially increase battlefield lethality over the next few years.

The strategic-military establishment in India would do well to take note of this 'Manhattan Project' moment in combat — the deployment of software at unprecedented speed and scale.

Tech in conflict: Ukraine, Venezuela and Iran

Drones are the greatest techno-military revolution since gunpowder and nuclear weapons. Their integration with AI and associated technologies has given birth to the art and science of drone warfare as warfare, even statecraft.

Their impact has been particularly visible in the Russia-Ukraine war. Ukraine, for instance, uses an AI-enabled data analytics platform called Delta that fuses multiple data inputs (from radar imagery to social media feeds) into one intelligent stream. Delta then plugs into a versatile inventory of drones to form a digital 'kill web' that compresses engagement times (detection to neutralisation) to a couple of minutes.

A 35-km corridor along the Russia-Ukraine frontier is nicknamed the "death zone". In this area, artillery has been pushed back and outranged, tanks don't move, and infantry soldiers are picked up by surveillance drones and neu-



Anduril's YFQ-44A began flight testing for the Collaborative Combat Aircraft Program in October 2025. ANDURIL

• From Ukraine to US: AI on the battlefield

UKRAINE'S DELTA battlefield management system has given it an edge in its grinding war against Russia. The system uses artificial intelligence to help with target selection, faster multi-sensor data analysis about enemy activity, and decision-making, among others.

THE UKRAINIAN defence ministry

has said that Delta enables "real-time battlefield awareness, supports operational planning, and facilitates information sharing within units, brigades, formations, and, when needed, with allies".

ANOTHER EXAMPLE is YFQ-44A Fury, an AI-powered unmanned fighter jet developed by the American

defence tech startup Anduril.

ANDURIL SAYS on its website that integration of autonomy into fighter aircraft is a "step change" in aviation. "We designed YFQ-44A for a specific Air Force mission: to enhance survivability, lethality, and mission effectiveness by teaming with crewed fighter aircraft or operating independently."

tralised by FPV (first-person view) drones in a matter of minutes. Unmanned platforms are taking over functions once performed by humans. This ranges from acquiring information and fixing targets to resupplying ammunition and rations, and evacuating casualties.

This year, Ukraine is buying eight million drones, more than the artillery it fired last year. These platforms provide commanders options ranging from close air support (25 km) to strategic air power (2,500 km).

In Venezuela, the US used Anthropic's Claude in the operation to capture ousted president Nicolas Maduro. AI platforms gave the US top brass insights into Maduro's movements and helped them anticipate what he would do.

Widening use cases

In Venezuela, the US used Anthropic's Claude in the operation to capture Maduro.

AI platforms gave the US top brass insights into Maduro's movements.

Electronic attacks and cyber exploits were then synchronised with the Delta Force's heliborne assault to telling effect.

In Iran, we saw the development of targeting packages at machine (not human) speeds, enabling precise strikes that wiped out almost the entire Iranian leadership in minutes on the morning of February 28.

Autonomous control

Military autonomy is making giant strides. Drone warfare is moving from remote to algorithmic control. The captains of naval platforms are increasingly going to be autonomous software systems, not humans. In the aerial domain, the development of the YFQ-44A Fury, an AI-powered autonomous fighterjet, by the defence tech startup Anduril, tells us that the future of airpower will be collaborative. This also shows that the business model is moving

steadily from traditional defence primes to agile startups.

Lethal technologies are seeing an unprecedented boom. Mythos is a virtual cyber-nuke that can disable any adversary operating system. DeepSeek and Tau's Law of Scaling (Huawei professing to achieve 1.4 nanometre transistor density by 2031 to challenge the Nvidia Blackwell chips which are in the range of 4 nanometres) are symbols of how Chinese digital innovations are turbo-charging strategic-military competition.

In combat theatres, software innovations are happening every three weeks, while new hardware is being deployed every three months. The Ministry of Defence, which has hitherto been a platform and weapons factory, will have to metamorphose into a software enterprise.

What India can do

The future of defence is also sovereignty. Beginning now, we can embrace the trinity of AI, autonomy and algorithmic warfare through these sovereign pathways:

- Urgently develop an AI-enabled data analytics platform, in the manner of Delta.
- Create software that can autonomously coordinate drones swarms; identify objects of interest; differentiate between birds, civilian aircraft and combat platforms; and direct shooters to destroy targets.
- Set up a diverse inventory of drones, with a target of five million by 2028.
- Deploy an array of counter-drone systems (such as laser and microwave weapons) with drone-hunting teams. This will help to establish drone-driven, AI-enabled "kill webs" along the LoC and LAC.
- Crowd the LEO (low-Earth orbit) space so that we transit from persistent surveillance to offensive ISR (intelligence, surveillance and reconnaissance).
- The 2027 defence budget must reflect the transition. At least 40% of the Rs 2 lakh-odd crore earmarked for modernisation should be spent on technological solutions.

This is a huge challenge that will require a cultural and structural transformation. Successful adoption, however, will be game changing. It will expand options in crisis situations while enabling India to attain "combat overmatch" with Pakistan and "asymmetric deterrence" with China.

• LAW

Inside West Bengal laws on property damage, preventive detention

Apurva Vishwanath
New Delhi, July 5

THE WEST Bengal Assembly recently passed two laws that mark the first major legislative move by the state's new BJP government: the West Bengal Public Safety and Control of Anti-social Activities Bill, 2026, and the West Bengal Maintenance of Public Order (Amendment) Bill, 2026.

Both cleared the House after a stormy debate, with the Public Safety Bill passing by 176 votes to 41. Chief Minister Suwendu Adhikari, the state's first BJP Chief Minister who also holds the Home portfolio, defended them as a solution to what he called the "goonda-neeti" and "jungle raj" of 15 years of Trinamool rule.

The two laws follow a familiar template, which began in Uttar Pradesh and is now common in several BJP-ruled states: stringent laws and unusual state powers to recover damage to public property.

What is the new recovery law?

The West Bengal Maintenance of Public Order (Amendment) Bill, 2026 establishes a legal framework for claiming compensation for damage caused to public and private property during incidents like riots or anti-social activities. The proposed law seeks to amend the West Bengal Maintenance of Public Order Act, 1972 to create a money recovery mechanism for property destroyed during riots, arson, vandalism and protests.

How does the law operate?

The Bill follows the Uttar Pradesh format, where a 2020 order by district magistrates issued notices to individuals to recover the entire cost of damage to public property as assessed by the state government.

West Bengal's proposed law sets up a "Claims Commission" headed by a bureaucrat, an officer of at least Additional District Magistrate rank and armed with the powers of a civil court. After damage occurs, the District Magistrate or Police Commissioner must file a claim petition for losses to public property, while owners of damaged private property may file their own.

The Commission applies strict liability once a link between the incident and the damage is shown, can fix liability not only on those who caused the damage but on those who instigated, financed or harboured them, and may award "exemplary damages" of up to twice the compensation. Compensation cannot fall below the property's market value, and unpaid amounts are recovered as arrears of land revenue, meaning property can be attached and auctioned. Crucially, every award is final, with no appeal to any court, and civil courts are barred from the subject matter.

After a Supreme Court rap, the UP government withdrew the Uttar Pradesh Recovery of Damages to Public and Private Property Act, 2020. In 2022, it enacted a new law, bringing in some independent

Stringent provisions

- After damage occurs, the District Magistrate or Police Commissioner must file a claim petition for losses to public property, while owners of damaged private property may file their own.
- The Commission applies strict liability once a link between the incident and the damage is shown, and can fix liability not only on those who caused the damage but on those who instigated, financed or harboured them.
- The proposed preventive detention law allows detention that cannot exceed 12 months, and also externment for up to a year.

former judges in the Claims Commission. Under the current law in UP, the tribunal is headed by a retired district judge. The new law is also under challenge before the SC.

The UP law grew directly out of the anti-CAA protests of December 2019.

The Yogi Adityanath government put up roadside hoardings naming and shaming those it accused of vandalism; the Allahabad High Court ordered the posters removed, and the Supreme Court observed that there was then no law to support the action. UP responded by promulgating an ordinance, later passed as an Act, setting up claims tribunals whose decisions could not be challenged in court.

In February 2022, the Supreme Court forced UP to withdraw 274 recovery notices and refund the money, holding that the State had acted as "complainant, adjudicator and prosecutor" in attaching the accused's properties, though it left the government free to start afresh through the statutory tribunal.

What is West Bengal's new preventive-detention law?

The Public Safety Bill is a standalone preventive detention statute aimed at "goondas" and "anti-social activities." Both terms are defined expansively: a *goonda* is defined as a person who is "generally reputed to be desperate and dangerous to the community" or is a "Habitual Offender."

An "anti-social activity" covers conduct that directly or indirectly causes "alarm or

insecurity among the public, danger to life or property, disturbance of public order, unlawful dispossession, or illegal mining, quarrying, sand or forest activity that drains the public exchequer."

West Bengal already has a preventive detention law dating back to 1970s. The present one is wider in its ambit.

Goonda laws exist in several states, most notably in Gujarat, as the Prevention of Anti-Social Activities Act, 1985. The Bharatiya Nyaya Sanhita also has provisions to deal with organised crime. Preventive detention is permitted under Article 22 of the Constitution with certain safeguards. Such issues are legislated under "public order" which is a state subject.

How does the preventive detention law operate?

The state government, or a district magistrate or police commissioner, once notified, may order a person detained to prevent such anti-social activity. Ordinarily, the person must have a conviction in the preceding seven years, or at least three separate charge-sheets.

Apart from a detention that cannot exceed 12 months, the proposed law allows externment, which entails removing a person from an area for up to a year.

It also allows for search and seizure, punishes the harbouring of a detained or externed person, grants officials good-faith immunity, and makes offences cognizable and non-bailable.

KOLKATA HAS THE GREATEST NUMBER OF UNINCORPORATED ENTERPRISES AT 8.84 LAKH

2 cr informal workers in India's big cities; Hyd tops with 15.7 lakh

Roughly 26% — or 52 lakh — of the informal workers in the country's most populous 46 cities are women

Siddharth Upasani
New Delhi, July 5

INFORMAL BUSINESSES are widely thought to operate largely in the rural heartland of the country. However, a new government report has shed light on the size of the informal sector in India's urban centres, estimating that the country's 46 most populous cities have 1.98 crore people working in 1 crore informal establishments.

Greater Hyderabad tops the list of cities with the highest number of informal workers at 15.7 lakh, with Kolkata home to the greatest number of informal establishments — 8.84 lakh.

As per the Ministry of Statistics and Programme Implementation's (MoSPI) report on urban unincorporated enterprises in cities whose population exceeded 1 million (10 lakh) as per Census 2011, six had more than a million informal workers: Greater Hyderabad, Delhi, Kolkata, Surat, Greater Mumbai, and Jaipur. Together, these six cities account for 40% of all informal workers in the country's 46 cities with more than a mil-

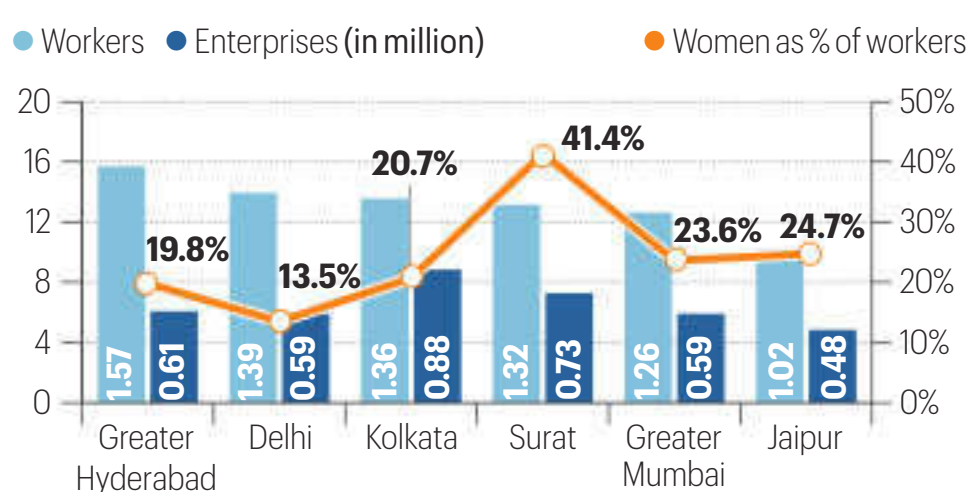
lion people each. The number of unincorporated establishments in these six cities is estimated to be nearly 39 lakh, or around 39% of the total in the 46 cities.

The total number of informal workers in India in 2025 was 12.81 crore.

Of the 1.98 crore informal workers in these 46 cities, roughly 26% — or 52 lakh — were women. Greater Visakhapatnam had the highest percentage of female workers at 42.5%, with Surat close behind at 41.4%. Srinagar was last at 10.5%, just below Varanasi at 12.1%. The report on the unincorporated enterprises in million-plus cities is the second such report released by MoSPI on India's biggest cities. The first was on their labour market dynamics, based on the results of the Periodic Labour Force Survey for 2025.

"This report presents, for the first time, a comprehensive statistical profile of 46 million-plus cities," Geeta Singh Rathore, Director General of MoSPI's National Sample Survey, said. She added that since the estimates are based on sample survey data, "differences observed across

• Cities with 1 million+ informal workers



NOTE: ESTIMATES ARE FOR UNINCORPORATED ENTERPRISES. SOURCE: MoSPI

cities may arise from variations in economic structure, industrial composition, local conditions and sampling variability".

The city-level estimates are generated from MoSPI's Annual Survey of Unincorporated Sector Enterprises (ASUSE) for 2025, which covers India's unincorporated, non-agricultural enterprises, excluding construction. These enterprises make up a sizable portion of the economy and include the likes of small manufacturers, service providers, and trading units.

Spread of cities

The 46 million-plus cities account for about 13% of establishments, 16% of workers, and 21% of Gross Value Added (GVA) of the unincorporated non-agricultural sector as per the ASUSE

2025 survey. These 46 cities are from 17 states and Union Territories: 10 from Maharashtra, seven from Uttar Pradesh, four each from Gujarat and Madhya Pradesh, three each from Tamil Nadu and Rajasthan, two each from Andhra Pradesh, Jharkhand, Punjab, and West Bengal, and one apiece from Bihar, Chhattisgarh, Delhi, Haryana, Jammu & Kashmir, Karnataka, and Telangana.

As *The Indian Express* had reported earlier this year in March, the number of informal establishments in the entire country rose by 58.5 lakh in 2025 to 792 crore, down from an increase of 83.5 lakh in 2023-24 (October-September). As a result, fewer jobs were created: 74.5 lakh in 2025 compared to 1.1 crore in the 12 months ended September

2024. Informal sector pay rose by just 3.9% in 2025, less than half the 13% increase seen in 2023-24.

Pay and productivity

In terms of total pay, emolument per worker was the highest in Jaipur, at Rs 2.33 lakh — although this only considers those unincorporated establishments with hired workers. Greater Hyderabad was second, at Rs 2.14 lakh. Emoluments refers to the total compensation a worker receives, inclusive of salary and benefits.

Meanwhile, informal enterprises in Gwalior paid hired workers the least at Rs 88,853, with Varanasi second from bottom at Rs 1 lakh. On average, emolument per worker in the 46 cities was Rs 1.5 lakh per year.

With the government releasing details for the 46 million-plus cities for the first time, comparative data on wages and the number of informal jobs is unavailable. Consequently, there is no way to calculate how much wages increased in 2025.

While informal workers in Jaipur got paid the most, they were not the most productive; that title belonged to Pimpri-Chinchwad, where the GVA per worker stood at Rs 2.9 lakh — significantly higher than Jaipur, which ranked 13th at Rs 2.23 lakh.

FULL REPORT ON
WWW.INDIANEXPRESS.COM

'Ethanol crucial for India; fastest, cheapest way to decarbonise road mobility'

AS INDIA is witnessing transition in mobility both on account of different energy powertrains and ethanol blend of petrol, **Vikram Gulati**, country head and EVP, Toyota Kirloskar Motors told **Sandeep Singh** that all cleaner technologies need to be supported to help reduce carbon emissions, bring down pollution, and reduce dependence on imported energy. Amid growing concerns over impact of ethanol blend on fuel efficiency, he said the studies showed that the shift from E10 to E20 had negligible material impact and the impact on fuel efficiency was in the range of around 3-5%. He, however, said that for E25, new and older vehicles need to be evaluated before making that transition. He also called for greater policy support for hybrids for faster displacement of petrol and diesel cars. Edited excerpts:

Where do you see EVs, hybrids, ethanol-based flex-fuels fitting in the country's mobility transition?

If you look at India's priorities from a macro perspective, the objectives are very clear — reduce fossil fuel consumption, reduce carbon emissions, bring down pollution, increase domestic value addition and reduce dependence on imported energy.

I think at this stage, it makes sense to support all cleaner technologies. It is not EV versus hybrid — it is EVs and hybrids. Along with that, we need flex fuels, CNG, compressed biogas, hydrogen and other solutions working together.

The task is so huge that even if all these technologies grow, there will still be a gap and fossil fuels will continue to remain part of the system.

Anyone who wants to buy an EV will buy an EV. A hybrid is not going to distract that customer. But someone who is considering buying a petrol or diesel vehicle may think twice if a hybrid gives them the right total cost of ownership. So every hybrid sold is actually replacing a petrol or diesel vehicle. That helps the country, the city and the environment. Policy should ensure that the customer is not inadvertently taxed more for choosing such a clean technology.

Ethanol, on the other hand, is extremely relevant for India as



VIKRAM GULATI
COUNTRY HEAD AND EVP,
TOYOTA KIRLOSKAR MOTORS

it is a domestic energy source, it supports the agricultural economy, helps reduce the amount of fossil fuel we consume and is the fastest as well as cheapest way to decarbonise road mobility. India's energy challenge is huge. There have been forecasts indicating that a significant part of the increase in global fossil fuel demand over the coming years will come from India because of economic growth and the increasing number of vehicles. The only way to address this is by improving efficiency and encouraging energy substitution through both electricity and ethanol.

India is pushing ethanol blending aggressively. Do you think this is the right time to accelerate the ethanol roadmap?

Definitely. If you look at the ethanol industry, there is significant available capacity today. The industry has been highlighting that plants are operating below their potential, and there is enough opportunity to scale up ethanol production. This can help India reduce petrol consumption and fossil fuel dependence. This is the right time to move in that direction.

Brazil's experience is very important. Initially, after the oil crisis, they pushed ethanol-only vehicles. But customer adoption had limitations because people wanted flexibility. The major change happened when flex-fuel vehicles (FFVs) were introduced. FFVs were promoted by the government through enabling policies that encouraged rapid customer adoption. Once customers had the ability to use different ethanol blends depending on availability and economics, ethanol adoption increased sharply.

That is the real learning —

make the FFV technology customer-friendly, affordable to buy and run.

India has a strong opportunity. If policies create economic value for customers — both while buying flex-fuel vehicles and while using ethanol fuel — adoption can grow very quickly. For manufacturers also, scale matters. If volumes increase, engine supply chains can be developed for flex-fuel technology at a larger scale, which will help bring costs down.

The important point is that the transition has to be designed properly and the customer has to accept it. The technology, policy and economics all have to work together and there has to be value for the customer.

There are concerns around higher ethanol blends and their impact on fuel efficiency and engines. How do you see that?

We need to clearly differentiate between different blends. E85 is meant only for flex-fuel vehicles that are specifically designed for flexibly using any higher ethanol content. There was also some discussion on moving existing vehicles beyond E20, for example towards E25. That requires careful evaluation. The issue is not that it cannot be done but requires adequate testing to be completed and evaluated as was done earlier for E20.

When India moved from E10 to E20, a lot of studies were conducted. Older vehicles from different manufacturers were tested. Material compatibility, component deterioration and fuel efficiency impact were evaluated. The conclusion was that there was very negligible material impact. Fuel efficiency impact was minimal and estimated in the range of around 3-5%. Therefore, the concerns being seen in social media recently are not backed by scientific facts and sound technical evaluation. But for E25, similar extensive testing has not yet happened.

New vehicles and older vehicles need to be evaluated before making that transition. Testing will provide the answer. However, we feel that FFV provides agility and is the optimal way ahead.

FULL INTERVIEW ON
WWW.INDIANEXPRESS.COM

GOLD PRICES FALL, BUT DEMAND REMAINS SLUGGISH

Mumbai jewellers eye festive relief as demand stays weak

Akash Mandal
Mumbai, July 5

IT'S A rainy weekday evening at Zaveri Bazaar, Mumbai's famous jewellery hub. Most jewellery shops seem deserted, and the narrow street is missing the usual cacophony of vehicles, workers hauling goods on their shoulders or on hand-drawn carts, and others hurrying through their daily routine.

The treacherous Mumbai monsoon might have contributed to the desolate jewellery showrooms, but many jewellers confirmed that business has been sluggish despite gold prices falling around 30% since hitting all-time highs earlier in the year. "The last couple of months have been very slow, with demand in the festive season also not being what it usually is," said an owner of a small jewellery shop in the area.

While gold prices have fallen sharply from their peak to make jewellery more affordable, retail demand will only pick up once prices stabilise, according to experts.

"Customers do not buy in a falling market. Instead, they buy when prices are high. When prices are falling, the customer waits for prices to fall even more before buying," said Rajubhai Solanki, who owns Zaveri Kapoorchand Lalchand, a jewellery store in Zaveri Bazaar.

Thus, while high prices were a concern a few months ago, a rapid decline in prices within a short period is not good for the industry either. "These (jewellers) are not must-buy things. It's either functional or for investment purposes. Investors will definitely look for a best-buy opportunity. While prices have steadied in the last week or so, it needs to remain stable for a longer period," he added.

While retail demand remains slow for now, some experts said buying has picked up on the industry level, especially after domestic prices fell under the psychologically crucial Rs 1.5 lakh per 10 gram mark. "We saw some demand come back to the market. So from our conversations (with channels of dealers), we understand buying is picking up. When I say buying is picking up, it could also mean at the B2B level, where people have started to build inventory," said Harshal Barot, lead consultant at Metals Focus.

Shifting demand, festive hopes

For now, little has changed

• SMALL RETAILERS CONTINUE TO STRUGGLE

LITTLE HAS changed for smaller retailers in Mumbai's Zaveri Bazaar

WHILE GOLD jewellery led their sales, demand has moved towards lower-carat jewellery, studded designs and gold exchange

THE TREND first emerged among larger listed retailers earlier this year as record-high gold prices made jewellery less affordable

HOWEVER, IF gold prices stabilise around current levels, demand is



expected to pick up during the festive and wedding season

for smaller retailers in the jewellery hub since *The Indian Express* visited the area in February, when gold prices were at their peak.

"In our business, the making charge is fixed. So, if I take Rs 1,500 making charges and my cost falls to Rs 13,000 from Rs 15,000 as gold falls, then margins will definitely improve. That has happened in the existing business we have, but sales (volumes) have not improved due to volatile prices," a jeweller explained.

While gold jewellery has historically dominated sales for these jewellers, demand has increasingly shifted towards lower-carat jewellery, studded designs and gold exchange. The trend first emerged among larger listed retailers earlier this year as record-high gold prices made jewellery less affordable for many consumers.

However, if gold prices stabilise around current levels, demand is expected to pick up during the festive and wedding season, which runs from October to February. That would mark a sharp contrast with last year's festive season, when record-high gold prices dampened demand.

"I have been looking to get a pair of gold earrings. I had deferred purchasing them earlier when I had a couple of weddings since it was out of my budget. But now that it's just about in my budget, I'd maybe wait a bit more and buy them for Diwali," said Roshni, a 25-year-old management professional based in Mumbai.

Global factors drive gold prices lower

After hitting a peak of around Rs 2.04 lakh/10 g in January, the August expiry contracts of the precious metal have dropped around 30% to around Rs 1.43 lakh, according

to data on the Multi Commodity Exchange of India. Spot prices have dropped 17% to around Rs 1.40 lakh, the World Gold Council data showed.

The fall is in line with international prices, which have dropped due to factors such as a strong US dollar amid expectations of Federal Reserve rate hikes, as well as a slowdown in gold purchases by most central banks worldwide amid the West Asia war.

The Fed adopted a more hawkish stance at its latest monetary policy meeting last month, indicating at least one hike this year.

Higher interest rates are negative for gold as it provides investors with more attractive interest-bearing investments, leading them to shift away from the precious metal to fixed-income assets.

In fact, the pass-through of falling international gold prices to the Indian market is limited due to high import duties, with the government hiking duty on gold imports to 15% (including basic customs duty and agriculture infrastructure development cess) from 6% in May.

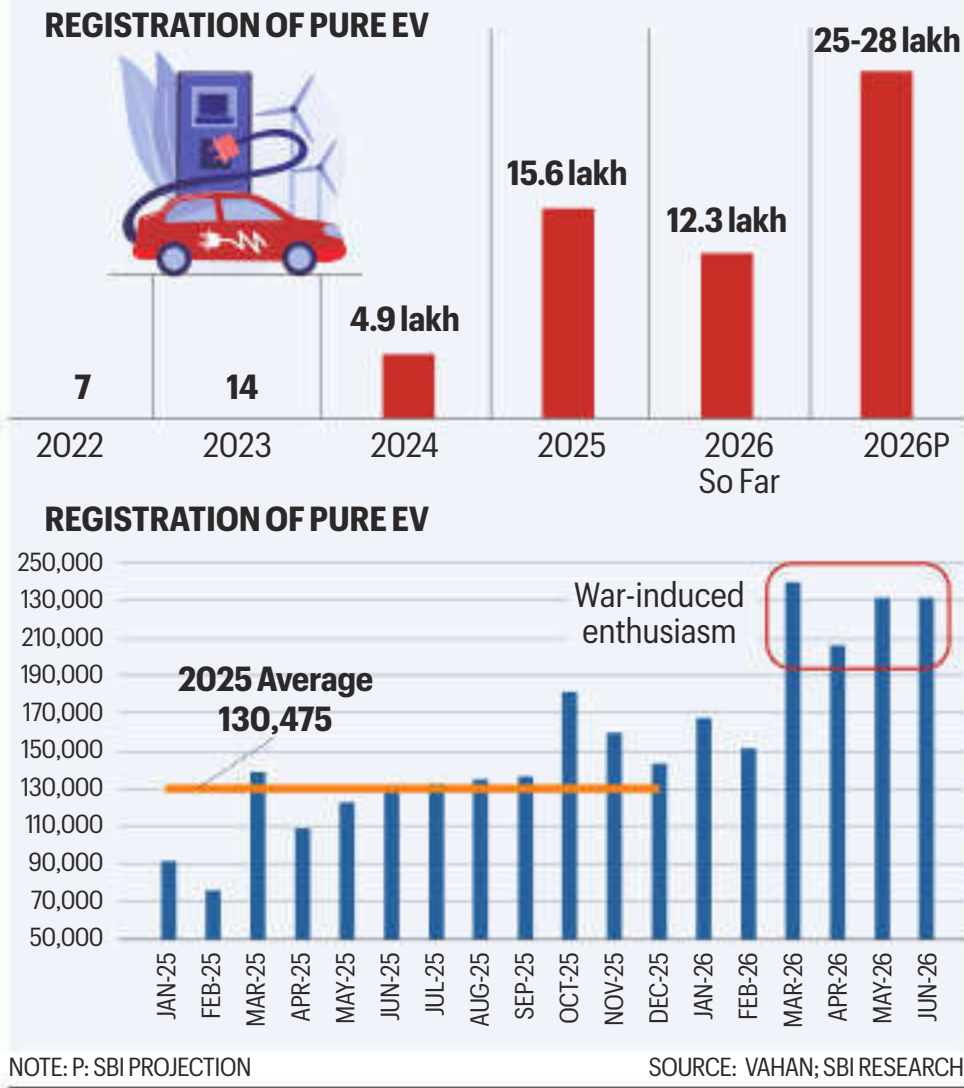
The spot price for the metal has fallen around 28% from its peak to \$4,000 an ounce in the international market, a much sharper decline than in domestic spot prices.

Domestic gold prices were also hit by Prime Minister Narendra Modi's austerity call in early May, which urged citizens to avoid non-essential gold purchases to ease pressure on forex reserves amid the crisis. "When Modi had made the (austerity) announcement, the impact on the market was immediate. Sales went down drastically," said Rajesh Rokde, Chairman of the All India Gem and Jewellery Domestic Council.

FULL REPORT ON
WWW.INDIANEXPRESS.COM

• EV SURGE

The registration of electric vehicles (EVs) soared significantly after the beginning of the West Asia war, which affected the energy supply from the Gulf region. During the March-June stretch of 2026, the average EV registrations shot up to 2.3 lakh, way above the 1.3 lakh registration seen in the same period of 2025.



NOTE: P: SBI PROJECTION

SOURCE: VAHAN, SBI RESEARCH

Govt woos pension, SWF money for infra financing

Prasanta Sahu
New Delhi, July 5

TO ACCELERATE infrastructure financing and support India's transition to a net-zero economy, the Centre is preparing a comprehensive strategy to attract long-term global investors such as pension funds and sovereign wealth funds to infrastructure sectors, including highways, railways, ports and airports. The move comes

as India faces massive financing needs for its climate and infrastructure goals.

A recent NITI Aayog report estimates that the country will require investments worth \$22.7 trillion by 2070 to achieve its net-zero target.

Of this, nearly \$6.5 trillion is expected to remain unfunded, highlighting the need for deep domestic financial reforms and greater integration with global pools of long-term capital. FE

OPEC+ okays further oil output increase

Reuters

London, July 5

OPEC+ HAS agreed a further increase in output targets from August, the group said in a statement on Sunday, adding to global supply at a time when oil prices are falling due to the gradual reopening of the Strait of Hormuz for oil exports.

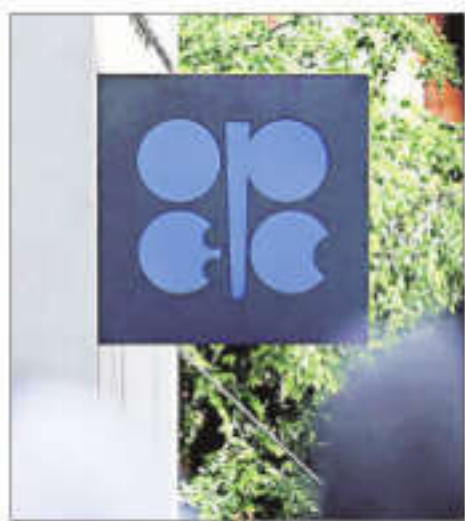
The oil-producing group agreed during an online meeting to increase quotas by 188,000 barrels per day (bpd) from August, on top of similar increases for June and July.

The seven core members of OPEC+, which groups OPEC and allied producers including Russia, have hiked their output quotas from April through July by almost 800,000 bpd. Yet the

increase has remained largely on paper because of the US-Israeli war on Iran, which closed the Strait of Hormuz to tanker traffic for some of the most important OPEC+ members, including Saudi Arabia, Kuwait and Iraq.

OPEC+ output fell to 33.13 million bpd in May, according to OPEC data, from 42.77 million bpd in February. It began to recover in June thanks to US efforts to help the UAE and other OPEC+ nations export more oil, but is still below pre-war levels.

Despite persisting supply disruptions, oil prices have returned to pre-war levels, pressured by lower Chinese imports, higher exports from non-Middle East producers, and a record global strategic stock re-



OPEC+ output fell to 33.13 million bpd in May, from 42.77 million bpd in February. REUTERS

lease coordinated by the International Energy Agency.

"The group of seven kept unwinding their production cuts as widely expected," UBS analyst

Copper demand seen growing 9% in 2026: ICA

New Delhi: India will require roughly 500,000 tonnes of additional refined copper capacity every five years to keep pace with rising demand of the metal, International Copper Association India (ICA India) Managing Director Mayur Karmarkar said on Sunday. Speaking on the outlook for the ongoing financial year, Karmarkar said copper demand is likely to track overall GDP growth and the association is anticipating at least around 9% growth over 2026. PTI

Crude oil, TCS earnings to drive mkt sentiment

New Delhi: Trading sentiment in the stock market this week will depend on crude oil prices, global trends and the start of corporate earnings season with IT bellwether Tata Consultancy Services (TCS) reporting its June-quarter financial results on July 9, analysts said. Apart from this, the advancement of the southwest monsoon and trading activity of foreign investors would also influence market trading, the analysts added. PTI

A memorandum of understanding between Washington and Tehran to end the war has also helped convince traders that supply will ultimately return to normal levels. Brent crude prices traded near \$72 per barrel on Friday, down from recent peaks of more than \$120 per barrel and back to levels traded just before the US and Israel attacked Iran on February 28.

Besides agreeing production targets, OPEC+ is also facing other challenges after the UAE left the group and Iraq signalled it wants higher quotas.

Adani Defence to invest Rs 2,500 cr in missile mfg unit in Madhya Pradesh

Shivpuri (MP): Madhya Pradesh Chief Minister Mohan Yadav and Union minister Jyotiraditya Scindia on Sunday laid the foundation stone for a defence manufacturing plant in Shivpuri district.

The unit, comprising a missile complex, a composite propellant complex and a TNT complex, is being set up by Adani Defence and Aerospace, a subsidiary of the Adani Group, at a cost of about Rs 2,500 crore, said officials.

It will provide new impetus to Prime Minister Narendra Modi's vision of industrial development under the Atmanirbhar Bharat and Make in India campaigns, the officials said.

The unit will create direct and indirect employment opportunities, including for local people, while small and medium enterprises in the region will have the opportunity to connect with the defence production supply chain, they said.

Speaking on the occasion, Yadav said July 5 is a historic day for Madhya Pradesh as it will now play a major role in the nation's defence sector. Missiles manufactured here will penetrate the enemy's homes and destroy them, he said. They will travel long distances and fall in the enemy country, enhancing India's honour and respect, Yadav added.

Adani Group's Karan Adani and Jeet Adani also took part in the foundation-laying ceremony. Jeet Adani said it was a special day as mission-ready missiles will be manufactured here. PTI

Idea Exchange

MONDAY, JULY 6, 2026

NEWSMAKERS IN THE NEWSROOM

WHY HIMANTA BISWA SARMA

Himanta Biswa Sarma is one of the most polarising and influential faces of the BJP and is considered one among the most successful chief ministers of the ruling NDA after he led the party to a resounding victory in the recent Assam Assembly elections. Extremely popular in his state, Sarma, who was instrumental in reducing their main Opposition — Congress — to a 19-member party in the 126-member State Assembly, has become an inimitable figure in BJP's election campaign across the country



ON EXPANDING BJP'S FOLD

'It is my duty to bring anyone in Congress, with some merit, or in CPM or in CPI, to the rightist fold and make them ideologically more inclined towards us... I want Hinduism and rightist ideology to flourish'



ON MANIPUR'S VIOLENT CONFLICT

'In Manipur, the conflict between the communities, Kuki and Meiteis, now Kuki and Nagas, will never be resolved by outside interference. The dispute is not related to law and order. It is related to the big trust deficit'

'Congress party's biggest problem is that as it shifts further Left, it may grow stronger ideologically but weaker numerically'

Assam Chief Minister Himanta Biswa Sarma on Assam's shift from insurgency to peace and development, politics of polarisation, citizenship debates and evolving challenges in Manipur and Bangladesh. The conversation was moderated by Liz Mathew, Deputy Editor, *The Indian Express*



Assam Chief Minister Himanta Biswa Sarma in conversation with Liz Mathew, Deputy Editor, *The Indian Express*

nationals. At that time, religion was discounted because, from a religious point of view, we were not insecure. We were insecure only in linguistic terms or that we were losing land, etc. As days went by, people realised that we were losing even on the religious front. As a society develops, when they came 25 years back, 30 years back, they came as 5,000. But as multiplication started, they became one lakh. So now they are not only threatening your land and culture, but they are threatening your religion also. So that became an added concern. When I see that my religion is at stake, then I do not go for language. Then there is a tendency to unite.

I think that is what happened during the Assam Agitation in 1979. Nowhere in Assam was Hinduism at the receiving end. That is why we treated every legal migrant equally. But gradually we realised that we were losing on the religious front also. When that happens, you become more empathetic to somebody who has come to Assam because of persecution. Not for economic advantage but because they cannot stay there. I do not say everybody subscribes to my notion or the BJP's. Many still feel every foreigner is the same. But people like me believe you cannot put everybody on the same pedestal. You have to safeguard those who came because of persecution. I think, gradually, more people are aligning with our view because religion is also now at stake.

Vikas Pathak: You have seen the Congress from the inside. Why do you think it is in terminal decline?

Congress has tilted to the Left. In India, the ideology of the Left has never become the ideology of the majority. I think Congress party's biggest problem is that as they have shifted more towards the Left, ideologically they will be stronger, but numerically they will be weaker. Which is why it is never accepted by the vast majority of the people. So when a Congress leader now speaks to the people, he looks like an alien. The more

Rahul Gandhi takes Congress to the Left, the more he will lose support from the centrists and rightists.

Jatin Anand: It's been 12 years since you joined the BJP, and you've seen many leaders switch. Do you see these shifts as political pragmatism or is there room for ideology still?

BJP is an ideologically inclined party. We want to expand the rightist footprint in the country. So it is my duty to bring anybody who is in Congress, with some merit, or in CPM or in CPI, to the rightist fold and make them ideologically more inclined towards us. I want that everybody should be in the BJP in India. Irrespective of anything. I want Hinduism to flourish. I want rightist ideology to flourish. Now the problem is staying. Because if you have come for power, you will not stay. In this party, you cannot carry the culture of the other party.



Srirupa Goswami: In Assam, infiltration is one of the key issues. But why was there no SIR in Assam?

SIR will come; there was a technical problem. SIR and NRC (National Register of Citizens) are complementary, not in conflict. Our NRC has not been fully published. If somebody's name is deleted in SIR but there in NRC, that contradiction will arise. We are in the process of publishing the NRC data, followed by the SIR. I met the Chief Election Commissioner Gyanesh Kumar, requesting for SIR. But he says that we cannot do it because the NRC has not been published. In all other Indian states, there is no NRC. That is why before the election, we could not do SIR. But we have done something called SR (Special Revision). In Assam, we deleted 12 lakh names. These include those who died, whose names were duplicated and who've been declared as foreigners by the tribunal.

ON CENTRE'S NON-INTERFERENCE

'The central leadership does not interfere with the affairs of a state, as long as it is going smoothly. But jab mai raaste se bhatak jaun (if I go off-track), then there will be control, there will be instruction, there will be interference'

P Vaidyanathan Iyer: Now that the new government is in place in Bangladesh, do you think that political rhetoric can come down and become more conducive for talks?

I think political rhetoric can be withdrawn or discontinued in the next two minutes, but the question is of practical reality, which follows political statements. So, if there is a substantial change within Bangladesh, and if Hindus in Bangladesh are feeling secure, I don't think that there is anything which will stop India from entering into a good relationship with Bangladesh. If that is ensured, then we are the closest neighbours.

Sandeep Singh: You spoke about restoring peace and tranquillity in Assam. Why do you think that peace has not been restored in Manipur?

I think in Manipur, the conflict between the communities, Kuki and Meiteis, now Kuki and Nagas, is very strong, and it will never be resolved by outside interference. The dispute is not something which is related to law and order. The dispute is related to the big trust deficit. We can restore law and order. But we cannot make two brothers sit and settle their dispute. That we can only encourage; we cannot force. If you see their agenda, there is no memorandum before the Government of India. That means there is nothing with the Indian government. The people in Delhi, people in the rest of India, are not realising that situation. A lot of process is going on; inter-community dialogue has been initiated.

Neerja Chowdhary: As the CM of Assam, you have walked in tandem with the Centre yet you have managed to carve out an autonomous political persona. What is your secret?

The central leadership does not interfere with the affairs of a state, as long as it is going smoothly. But *jab mai raaste se bhatak jaun* (when I go off-track), then there will be con-

trol, there will be instruction, there will be interference. If you are managing it nicely, you are not bringing problems to Delhi.

Asad Rehman: In 2024, the Gauhati High Court had ordered the Assam government to pay Rs 30 lakh in compensation to six families whose homes were illegally bulldozed in Nagaon. Doesn't bulldozer justice go against natural justice?

The problem is that we don't have any other equipment other than bulldozers when you have to perform evictions. In Assam, an accused will be tried in the eyes of the law through a legal process. But when one becomes an accused, they come under greater scrutiny. If their house was built illegally, then what is the problem with demolishing it? If I follow the 16-point judgement of the Supreme Court, then I can demolish it. What is the problem?

Asad Rehman: What if that person is later acquitted?

But the house was illegal, right? We made a mistake in Nagaon, so we gave the compensation. However, one wrong by the government does not mean that it was wrong everywhere else.

Vandita Mishra: You've said polarisation was needed in Assam and you became an agent of it. Does that mean it can simply be switched off? Is it really that easy, especially in the age of social media? Also, the distinction between illegal Muslim immigrants and Muslims has largely disappeared. How will you address this?

I meant that the dominance of Assam should be by the people of Assam. The people being the Assamese people, including the Muslims who have been in Assam. Forget dominance; we were being pushed into a corner. At one point, we just asked to be allowed to live there. From there we fought. Today we are strong and stable, but that doesn't mean we have done something wrong to the other camp; we just said follow the law. When they follow the law, it "switches off." There is no guilt on our side because we gave them everything. We asked valid questions: why do you take our temples, our land, our girls? They said they won't do it anymore, and that was the end of it.

The distinction between illegal Muslim immigrants and Muslims will last forever. It cannot end. Sometimes religion plays a bigger role, but that is temporary; the differentiation will always remain. You will see fewer marriages between them and interpersonal communication hasn't necessarily improved. They may say they are united to oppose the BJP, but relations between them cannot improve. Our indigenous Assamese Muslims know that if they (immigrants) grow, we will lose our culture. The main resentment in Assam comes from this.

Rangnath Singh (Jansatta): Regarding the Ram Mandir controversy, do you think the image of the VHP, RSS and BJP has been hurt among the supporters and there may be a fallout in the UP elections?

I don't think so. The Congress, which never went to Ram Mandir, is now raising slogans for it. The Samajwadi Party is talking about it. Even those who didn't accept Ram's existence and refused formal invitations to the inauguration are now raising the issue. If there is a scam, action will be taken against the culprits. But you shouldn't run a campaign to defame the temple or the Sangh.

Apurva Vishwanath: In the past 10 years, Assam has built detention centres that could become a model for the rest of the country. How much has the state government spent on these facilities and how many people are currently being held in them?

I haven't found out about that, but the concept of the detention camp was a bit wrong. We never read the law. The Illegal Immigration (Deportation) Act was an act from 1950 and was made by Jawaharlal Nehru. Recently, the Supreme Court has said that the Act is valid. So, instead of putting people in detention camps, you can evict them from India. Now the process has smoothened. There might be 10 or 12 people.

Apurva Vishwanath: You're saying that in Assam there will only be 10–12 people in detention camps?

It will be below 100, I can say. I can say it is below 50 also because whatever happens now, I agree to evict them from the country. Right now a judgment from a Constitutional Bench has come, which says that your Act of 1950 is valid. It empowers the District Commissioner (DC) to evict a foreigner if he is prima facie satisfied. He doesn't have to push him to a tribunal. So we mistakenly created tribunals. We never studied that Act. So, detention camps are gradually becoming irrelevant. Why should I feed them?

Apurva Vishwanath: If the tribunal decides they are not foreigners?

Where will he fight the case from? He is gone. From there, he cannot fight a case. If he files a case from the country where he has been sent, that is a different matter. So now the detention camp has become like a transit camp.

WEEKLY CAPSULE

Omega-3s don't impact brain health

FISH OIL supplements successfully delivered Omega-3s to the brain but a two-year study by the University of Southern California found no meaningful benefits for memory, cognition or Alzheimer's-related brain changes. The results challenge the idea that fish oil pills can help prevent Alzheimer's and shift attention toward overall diet and lifestyle instead. Brain scans showed that fish oil supplements did not slow shrinkage of the hippocampus, a brain region critical for memory that is commonly used as a marker of brain aging and Alzheimer's risk.



Lose fat without losing muscle

A SIX-MONTH study by the University of the Sunshine Coast of more than 120 adults in their 70s found that high-intensity interval training (HIIT) may offer a key advantage over other forms of exercise. It helped reduce body fat while preserving valuable muscle mass. While moderate and low-intensity workouts also led to some fat loss, only HIIT maintained lean muscle, which becomes increasingly important with age. The findings are particularly important because changes in body composition are linked to the development and progression of many chronic diseases later in life.



Pesticide doubles Parkinson's risk

SCIENTISTS at UCLA have linked long-term exposure to the pesticide chlorpyrifos with a sharply increased risk of Parkinson's Disease. People exposed to the chemical near their homes were more than twice as likely to develop the condition. Laboratory studies showed that chlorpyrifos damages dopamine neurons and interferes with the brain's ability to remove toxic protein buildup. The results suggest that chlorpyrifos can damage critical nerve cells involved in movement and may play a direct role in the development of Parkinson's disease.



Vitamin C for healthier brain

COULD SOMETHING as simple as Vitamin C help support a healthier aging brain? In a study of more than 2,000 older adults in Japan, researchers at Hiro-saki University found that people with lower vitamin C levels in their blood also tended to have less grey matter and weaker connections in a key brain network involved in memory, attention, and other cognitive functions. What they found most fascinating was that they were able to detect these subtle but significant associations between a single nutritional factor and large-scale brain networks.



A jab reverses osteoarthritis

RESEARCHERS FROM the University of Colorado Boulder, CU Anschutz, and Colorado State University have developed treatments that may help aging and damaged joints repair themselves in weeks. These have shown promising results in animal studies, where they reversed signs of osteoarthritis and restored joint health. The approaches include a regenerative injection designed to be administered directly into a joint, as well as a biomaterial-based repair system that encourages the body's cells to rebuild damaged cartilage. The shot repurposes an existing US Food and Drug Administration (FDA)-approved drug.



CONSULTATION ROOM

DRCYRIACBBY PHILIPS

CLINICAL SCIENTIST IN HEPATOLOGY
AT RAJAGIRI HOSPITAL, KOCHI

Immunity booster industry is selling hope, not science

They are the most effective marketing deception in modern wellness

WALK INTO any pharmacy or supermarket and you will find shelves of pills, teas, gummies, multi-herbals and juice-shots promising to "boost, strengthen or supercharge" your immunity. "Immunity booster" may be one of the most successful psychologically 'seductive' marketing phrases ever invented. But it is also one of the emptiest.

Let me start with the basics. Your immune system is not a single entity with a volume knob you can crank up and down. It is a sprawling, two-part defence network. The innate system, consisting of your skin, mucus and roaming scavenger cells, reacts to almost anything within minutes. The adaptive system, consisting of T and B cells, learns the precise identity of a specific microbe and remembers it for decades. So these cells can kill it, when the time comes. The immune system is hundreds of cell types and signalling molecules, constantly networking without your knowledge to protect you from various diseases. Telling people to "boost" that, with a gummy, is like telling an orchestra to improve by asking one violinist to play louder.

Do you need a booster? Here is the part the advertisements never mention: you do not actually want a 'boosted' immune system. An immune system turned up too high is exactly what makes people miserable. It is why we get allergies and autoimmune diseases like an army turning on its own citizens. In severe infections, patients often die not from the germ but from their own immune system overreacting, what is called the infamous cytokine storm. The goal is never to be "louder", but

An immune system turned up too high makes people miserable. It is why we get allergies and autoimmune diseases, like an army turning on its own citizens. In severe infections, this leads to complications

At one point, "natural" quietly stops meaning "harmless." In America's drug-injury registry, herbal and dietary supplements went from causing seven per cent of reported liver-injury cases in 2005 to 20 per cent today — a more than five-fold rise, driven largely by exactly the products marketed for immunity: turmeric and green tea extracts, ashwagandha and multi-ingredient "immunity blends." By buying an immune booster, you are inside an unlicensed trial you never consented to. Many of these products are unregulated, mislabelled or contaminated; you often have no real idea what is inside your immunity supplement. And the quietest harm is behavioural. Feeling "protected" by an immune booster in a bottle is exactly what the wellness industry wants you to believe, without evidence.

The good news is that you can spot this fraud without a medical degree. Real immunology is specific. It names the cell, the antibody, the pathogen. Marketing is generic and vague: "supports immunity," "strengthens defences." Ask one question of any product: boost which part, and measure how? If there is no answer, there is no science. Anything that claims to strengthen your entire immune system against everything at once is selling you a feeling, nothing functional.

But a genuine, proven way to upgrade your immune system does exist. It is not inside a supplement. It is a vaccine. Vaccines do exactly what every marketed fraud booster pretends to. They teach your adaptive immune system to recognise a specific dangerous germ in advance, and to remember it. Vaccines are among the greatest achievements in human history. Small pox, which killed hundreds of millions, has been wiped off the planet. Polio, which once paralysed hundreds of thousands of children a year, has been pushed to a tiny handful of cases. Measles, diphtheria, tetanus, whooping cough and hepatitis B have been crushed wherever vaccines are used.

The US declared measles eliminated in 2000. By 2025, (no) thanks to "Make America Healthy Again" cultists, with childhood vaccination rates slipping below the safety threshold, America logged its worst measles year in three decades — a live demonstration, playing out in real time, of what "unboosted" immunity actually looks like at population scale.

So, look after your immune system: adequate sleep, eating whole foods, aerobic activity, avoiding tobacco and alcohol and getting vaccinated for age. Your immune system does not need a supplement. It needs a good teacher. And we already invented one, the vaccine.



Purnima Sah

WHEN 86-YEAR-OLD Vijaya Khare answers the door at her home in Dadar, Mumbai, there is little to suggest she had a knee replacement a year ago. She has just finished making savouries in her kitchen, is laying them out on the table, taking out the china and arranging the room to welcome guests. "As long as I can move, life will be good," she says.

She and her husband, 91-year-old Captain PR Khare, have spent decades building an independent life together, determined to remain as self-reliant as possible. Their three sons live separately but visit them regularly. That determination is increasingly reflected in hospitals across Mumbai and the country, where surgeons are seeing a growing number of patients in their 80s, 90s and even beyond 100 undergoing surgeries that were once considered too risky because of age. Knee and hip replacements, bypass and cancer surgeries, gastrointestinal procedures and cataract surgeries are becoming increasingly common among elderly patients who are medically fit, driven by longer life expectancy, advances in surgery and anaesthesia. This is a generation unwilling to accept pain and dependence as an inevitable part of ageing.

My life, on my terms

Vijaya started experiencing arthritis-related knee pain when she was around 70. "As I turned 80, I wanted a better quality of life free of pain. My baseline health was good, and because my son is a doctor, I had complete confidence in him, the hospital and the treating doctors. I wasn't scared of the operation at all. Today I am 86 and my husband is 91. We live in our own home. With the help of domestic staff, I manage the household myself. Standing for long periods is no longer a problem," she says.

Vijaya is also the co-founder of Pragati Kendra and Meera Vidyalaya in Mumbai's Sion, a school for children with intellectual disabilities. The surgery has helped her go there regularly. Captain Khare himself underwent open-heart surgery when he was 76 and prostate surgery when he was 89. For the last 10 years, he has also been living with Parkinson's Disease. "Just recently our children celebrated our 63rd wedding anniversary and without these surgeries, I don't think we would have been able to stay active, remain independent and enjoy the little moments of family and social celebrations with our loved ones," says Vijaya.

Their son, Dr Sanjay P Khare, chief consultant and director of the Apollo Institute of Clinical Obesity and Metabolism, says longevity, nuclear existence and effective therapies have rewired the mindset among the elderly. "Getting operated on at the age of 85 or 86 is no longer considered extraordinary because advances in medicine have made surgery safer and recovery easier for older adults. Improvements in minimally invasive surgical techniques, anaesthesia, pre-operative evaluation and post-operative care have significantly reduced the risks associated with surgery, while better management of chronic conditions means many people remain healthier and more active well into their 80s," he says. With potential benefits outweighing risks, chronological age hardly matters.

Like Vijaya, 90-year-old Kapaldev Singh, a retired scientist from the Bhabha Atomic Research Centre (BARC), had his first knee replacement surgery in 2017 and then again in 2025. "Usually, our concern is whether the muscles would be too weak to support the implant. But the muscle strength in fit and active seniors is fairly good to support a speedy recovery," says his daughter, Dr Balvinder Sapra.

PUSHING 90, they chose surgery to stay independent

As life expectancy rises and surgery becomes safer, India's oldest patients are increasingly choosing to be active and free rather than live with pain and disability

In fact, Singh was able to walk on the second day after surgery. Within six weeks, he no longer required a walker. Today, he walks a kilometre or two every morning and evening with the support of a walking stick and spends nearly two hours each day exercising to maintain his muscle strength. "The surgery energised him. Before that, he had stopped going out because he feared falling, and the only alternative seemed to be a wheelchair. Today, he meets friends in his housing society, reads newspapers for hours every morning and continues to lead an active life," says Sapra.

Which surgeries top the list

Dr Rohan Sequeira, associate professor, Department of Geriatric Medicine at Sir JJ Group of Government Hospitals, says orthopaedic procedures account for the largest share of surgeries among older adults, followed by cardiovascular interventions. "We are seeing a large number of knee and hip replacements, spine and lower back surgeries, along with surgeries for neck-related issues. Angioplasties and bypass surgeries are also becoming increasingly common among the elderly," he says.

One of the reasons for increased bone and

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joint problems, he feels, is obesity, the triggers being a comfortable, sedentary lifestyle, limited physical activity and shrinking public spaces. "Obesity is contributing to osteoarthritis, chronic low back pain, cardiac diseases, poorly controlled diabetes and high cholesterol," he says. India's rapidly ageing population is also expected to increase the demand for surgery. "The younger generations of previous decades have now become senior citizens, and many are now facing the consequences of years of unhealthy lifestyles. As this population grows older, we are likely to see even more surgeries," he says.

Dr Sequeira attributes the rise in elderly surgeries to greater public confidence in modern medicine. "Families are better informed and now trust modern medicine after seeing results among their family members. Older adults now are regularly undergoing physiotherapy, strength training and structured exercise programmes," he says.

The spiral is in no small part aided by the laparoscopic and robotic surgeries, the gold standard for many procedures. As Dr Prashanth Rao, director of Surgical Gastroenterology and Minimal Access Surgery at Glenagles Hospital, Parel, says, "Complex

cancer surgeries are now routinely performed through keyhole techniques, resulting in less pain, reduced blood loss, smaller scars and much faster recovery. These benefits are particularly significant for older adults, who are the age group most commonly affected by cancer."

Who is eligible for surgery?

Dr Siddharth Yadav, senior consultant, Orthopaedics and Joint Replacement Surgery, Apollo Hospitals, Navi Mumbai, says surgery is recommended only after a thorough evaluation, including assessment of the heart, lungs and kidneys. "Those classified as ASA Grade I or Grade II, meaning they have either no major medical illness or only well-controlled conditions such as diabetes or hypertension, are generally suitable candidates. Patients with higher anaesthetic risk, such as ASA Grade III, are usually not advised elective joint replacement because our aim is to improve their quality of life, not expose them to unnecessary complications," he explains.

Having performed knee replacements on 90-year-old patients, he has seen that recovery following planned surgery is often quicker than many families expect. "The skin heals within about two weeks, while muscles and tissues continue healing over eight to 12 weeks. By around three months, most post-operative inflammation settles and patients are able to enjoy the full benefits of the surgery," he explains.

Dr Sandeep Wasnik, consultant, Joint Replacement and Orthopaedic Surgery at Kokilaben Dhirubhai Ambani Hospital and Medical Research Institute, has operated on a 106-year-old, too. "He had suffered a hip fracture after a fall, and we did a hip replacement. Today, we have advanced regional anaesthesia techniques such as a sacral plexus block, which numbs only the leg being operated on instead of the entire body, making surgery much safer for the elderly. Better tissue handling has also made a significant difference," he says.

Dr Rao recalls how a 94-year-old freedom fighter underwent laparoscopic hernia surgery and two patients, aged 89 and 84, adjusted to Whipple's procedure, a complex surgery to remove cancerous tumours in the head of the pancreas, the gallbladder, the bile duct and the upper part of the small intestine. One of those who benefited from advances in minimally invasive surgery is 92-year-old Ramesh Kulkarni, a retired bank manager from Mumbai. Living with his wife and son in a middle-class household, he spent nearly six months coping with recurrent bleeding, weight loss and altered bowel habits caused by colorectal cancer. Although initially fearful, he steadily recovered over six to eight weeks by following medical advice, taking regular walks, practising breathing exercises and maintaining a healthy diet. Today, he remains independent in his daily activities, regularly attends social and religious gatherings, and believes staying physically active is essential for maintaining both physical and mental well-being.

Sharing figures from his own practice, Dr Wasnik says his team now performs surgeries on at least 10 to 15 patients aged over 80 every month. Between 2018 and 2020, that number stood at only three to five patients a month. Dr Rao has seen a 30 per cent increase over the past decade.

Kulkarni's surgery cost around Rs 5 lakh and was largely covered by health insurance, significantly reducing the financial burden on the family. Even so, many families consider the expense worthwhile if it helps an older relative remain mobile, independent and free from chronic pain. "At least, I am not a dependent and I am not carrying a burden of guilt," says Vijaya.

*Names changed for privacy

GERIATRIC SURGERY COST IN INDIA

MOST HEALTH insurance policies now cover medically necessary surgeries in patients above 80 years, subject to policy terms, coverage limits and pre-existing disease clauses. "Wider insurance coverage has become one of the key factors encouraging families to proceed with surgery rather than delay treatment," says Dr Roy Patankar, Director, gastrointestinal surgeon at Zen Multispecialty Hospital, Mumbai.

THE COST of surgery varies widely depending on the procedure and hospital. Knee and hip replacements typically cost between Rs 2.5 lakh and Rs 5 lakh, while complex cardiac, gastrointestinal and cancer surgeries can cost considerably more. In addition to the operation itself, families also need to budget for rehabilitation, physiotherapy, medicines and follow-up consultations, all of which are essential for recovery.

DOCTORS POINT out that while health insurance has improved access to surgery for many older adults, it is not a complete solution. Senior citizen health insurance policies often come with significantly higher premiums



Heart Surgery
₹1,50,000 – ₹11,50,000
Ranges from stent placements to bypass (CABG) and valve replacements



Joint Replacement
₹1,50,000 – ₹4,50,000
Covers total knee or hip replacement; usually requires a brief ICU stay for seniors



Bone & Fracture Surgery
₹50,000 – ₹3,00,000
Includes implant use (plates/screws) & bone repair

than those for younger people, and may include waiting periods, co-payments, sub-limits or exclusions for pre-existing illnesses, particularly when purchased later in life. Those who have maintained insurance coverage over many years or are covered under employer or family floater policies are generally better protected against the financial burden of major surgery.

DR PRASUN CHATTERJEE, formerly of AIIMS and group clinical lead, Geriatric Medicine and Longevity Science, Apollo Hospitals, has seen that even when patients have health insurance, many families struggle with reimbursement or do not receive financial support from insurers at the time they need it most. "This means arranging large sums of money upfront and waiting for claims to be processed, which can delay treatment or place considerable stress on families," he says. "While schemes such as Ayushman Bharat have expanded access to healthcare, India needs dedicated healthcare and insurance policies that address specific needs of people over 80," he adds.

● RESULTS	
ROUND OF 16	
Canada 0-3 Morocco	
Houston Stadium	
Paraguay 0-1 France	
Philadelphia Stadium	
● MATCH SCHEDULE	
ROUND OF 16	
Portugal vs Spain	
Arlington, 12.30 am	(Tuesday)
USA vs Belgium	
Seattle, 5.30 am	(Tuesday)
ZEE5 OTT & UNITE8 CHANNELS	



Spain's Lamine Yamal will lead the attack against Portugal. AP

Spain focusing on free-kicks against Portugal

THE SPANISH men's national side honed their free kicks ahead of their round of 16 clash against Portugal. The game is set to be a clash of generations, with the 41-year-old Portugal icon Cristiano Ronaldo set to encounter the next generation of Spanish football, spearheaded by 18-year-old Lamine Yamal. The 2010 champions, Spain, who have not conceded in any of their FIFA WC 2026 games so far, will face a tough test against Cristiano's men, who are still searching for that perfect all-round game, especially against big sides in the World Cup. ENS

USA records highest overall attendance

FIFA SAID the United States has produced the highest combined attendance of any host nation in FIFA World Cup history. In a post on X, football's global governing body said the United States had surpassed all previous World Cup hosts in total attendance. The milestone comes as the United States co-hosts the 2026 edition alongside Canada and Mexico, with stadiums across the country drawing large crowds throughout the tournament. "The USA has the highest combined attendance (8,008,212) of any FIFA World Cup host nation in history. On the Fourth of July, we celebrate the country's immense love of football!" FIFA said. As per official statistics, a total of 46,44,549 people had attended the group stage. ENS

● MOROCCO DEFEAT CANADA

Rebel hero: Ounahi's brace takes Atlas Lions to yet another quarterfinal

Shuvaditya Bose
New Delhi, July 5

A GOAL is much more than the rudimentary act of pushing a synthetic sphere into a polypropylene net. Take Azzedine Ounahi's 50th-minute goal in Morocco's 3-0 rout of Canada at the FIFA World Cup, for instance. It had the finesse of cigarette smoke slipping through a cracked window. All 10 Canadian players swarmed the box when Ounahi took his shot. It had the craftsmanship of a seamstress threading a needle through a crowded eye. Between the path of the ball and the net lay three defenders and a goalkeeper.

But how preposterous is it to suggest that a goal can be classified as anti-establishment? Ounahi's was. Until then, Canada had done almost every-

thing right. Jesse Marsch's side had five attempts, one of which should have been tucked home by Tani Oluwaseyi. In stark contrast, Morocco's only previous effort was Soufiane Rahimi launching a speculative strike from a distance worth just 0.02 expected goals.

Morocco did little to justify taking the lead. The goal disrupted the status quo. It was another reminder that few footballers have developed a greater affinity for unsettling established orders than Morocco's No. 8.

Quiet rebel

The irony stretches beyond the pitch.

In four years from now, Morocco will be co-hosting the World Cup. The country is accelerating infrastructure projects worth an estimated \$190



Azzedine Ounahi scored two goals against Canada on Sunday. AP

billion - almost 12% of its GDP. This investment is happening against the backdrop of a youth unemployment rate of over 30% and a public healthcare system under mounting scrutiny. In September 2025, the

death of eight pregnant women sparked a youth-driven nationwide protest, called Gen Z 212, after Morocco's international calling code.

The question was: If Morocco can spend billions pre-

paring for the World Cup, why are women dying while giving birth in public hospitals? The placards had a unified message: "The stadiums are here, but where are the hospitals?" In Morocco, few things command greater affection than football. Childbirth is one of them.

The privileged need not care. For the footballers, the memo is simple: excel in Europe's biggest leagues, return home as a national hero and leave politics to politicians. Ounahi never read the memo. Or, he never cared to.

He became the first Moroccan international to publicly express solidarity. Soon, others would join.

Ounahi was already an icon in Morocco after the 2022 World Cup. Luis Enrique is seldom surprised, but even he acknowledged: "Oh my god! Who

is that number 8? Where did this guy come from? I was pleasantly surprised.

The boy never stopped running." That winter in Qatar had transformed him into a superstar. The autumn in Casablanca elevated him into something closer to a cult figure.

On Saturday, he played like both. Morocco were lacklustre, and the 3-0 scoreline flatters to deceive. Marsch was not entirely wrong afterwards when he argued: "I would rather be us than them." Canada produced more shots, more corners and more expected goals.

He even claimed that on another day, Canada would have won. Perhaps he is right. But even on that day, Ounahi's first shot would have still found its way through that forest of bodies to beat a diving Maxime Crépeau. It was that precise.

Even on that day, his second strike would have smashed into the top left. It was that lethal. Even on that day, Ounahi would have ensured Morocco's lack of attacking flair was compensated by work ethic.

Mindset matters

After a historic 2022 campaign, the midfielder was asked what made the difference between Morocco and other teams. He said: "Our mindset made the difference. You cannot show up at the World Cup, and then play only when you have the ball and make no effort when you don't have it. What defines us is our defence. It starts with our strikers, and all the way to our goalkeeper - everyone defends."

He practises what he preaches. Ounahi ranks among Morocco's top three players for

distance covered per 90 minutes at this tournament. The trait was borne out of compulsion. A late growth spurt meant that until he was 16, his lungs compensated for what his body lacked.

After the promise of 2022, Ounahi's career had dwindled. Marseille thought they had unearthed a bargain when they signed him for €8 million and watched him score on his debut, but a myriad of injuries stagnated his progress. Following a season in Greece, Ounahi rediscovered the self he had lost in Girona last season. Canada was another step in that renaissance. It was far from perfect and also unconvincing. But it did not need to be either. "The only thing that matters is whether we qualify." Courtesy of his two anti-establishment goals, Morocco did.

"The refereeing I've got nothing to say. You saw it for yourself. How many fouls were there? 30? 40? And no yellow cards. But it doesn't matter. We're in the quarterfinals"

FRENCH MIDFIELDER RAYAN CHERKI TO FRANCE24



(From left) Kylian Mbappe falling after a foul ; Paraguay and France players engaged in a scuffle during the match; Desire Doue lying on the ground after a tackle on him. AP

LES BLEUS TOOK SOME NASTY HITS FROM THE SOUTH AMERICANS FOR 90 MINUTES

DESIRE DOUE was felled in the box, leading to the winning penalty.

RIVER PLATE medio Matias Galarza struck Kylian Mbappe on the arm to take him off the ball on the right wing.

GALARZA ALSO smacked his

palm in Jules Kounde's face. Kounde was hit by an arm twice.

THE PARAGUAYAN collapsed to the floor holding his face in apparent agony after Michael Olise pulled his jersey. Uzbek referee Ilgiz Tantashev pulled out a yellow card for the Frenchman.

PARAGUAYAN DEFENDER Gustavo Velazquez kicked the penalty spot to scuff it up, while Ousmane Dembele stood with the ball in his hands as decoy. Dembele laughed it off. Mbappe scored.

PARAGUAYAN SUBSTITUTES kept rushing towards the referee appealing for free kicks, cards.

WORDS WERE said and Deschamps later said he "could've done without insults from the Paraguay bench." What was said wasn't elaborated, but Paraguay coach defended his camp.

WHEN MBAPPE ignored Paraguay goalkeeper Orlando Gill's hand after the game, Gill threw

the ball against the France captain's back.

DAYOT UPAMECANO had an elbow shoved in his ribs while defending.

ANDRES CUBAS ran through Adrien Rabiot as if he didn't exist with a nasty tackle. ENS

More than just flair: France show knockout grit vs Paraguay

Against physical aggression, the two-time champions prove resilience can be as decisive as style



Sandip G
Philadelphia, July 5

THE GLORIOUSLY multi-dimensional French know many ways to kill the pesky cat disturbing their sleep. They could baffle them with their touch; they could bemuse them with their wits; they could pin them down with their muscle; they could play the piano, which makes them the deadliest proposition in the tournament.

The 1-0 victory over Paraguay that ensured the quarter-finals was a triumph of their brawn, their capacity to out-match gnarled men who tried to wrestle them, sometimes literally, at times harm them with a brand of cynicism that was strangely left unpunished.

Wins like these don't build aura; they create the belief that nothing can shake them. It was not France's inability to score more goals that stood in a game that Thierry Henry commented, "football finally won", but their wherewithal and knowhow to nullify any strategies thrown at them. Kylian Mbappe, who scored the lone goal of the goal, after a penalty on Desire Doue, quipped, his

eyes burning with a happy rage: "They thought we were going to turn up in tuxedos, but we know how to play rough football — and even at that, we were better than them!" The line before was a warning to the world: "We've shown that we're not just a team that plays attacking football; if we have to put our hands in the s—, we will put our hands in the s—."

He ignored Paraguay goalkeeper Orlando Gill's handshake and turned his attention to the fans. Gill reacted by throwing a ball onto his back.

France's feistiness should surprise nobody. Many of their stars emerged from Paris's crime-ridden banlieues and overcame hardship long before football. Paraguay's ruffianism wouldn't. Their default method was to frustrate France's dogged defence, which they performed clinically. Five defended the backline, three screened them relentlessly, and two harried up front. But against as imaginative an orchestra as France, they need more than stoic resistance. With one unimaginable, unthought move, France could disarray the defensive labyrinth. So they decided to rile them, break France's rhythm, shatter their cohesion, and frustrate them under skin-peeling heat. Europe might be suffering a seasonal heatwave, but Paraguay endure similar punishing climates round the year. The deeper they drag the game, the

likelier they are to spin an unlikely upset. The longer France remained goalless, the likelier they started strumming falsetto notes. They were hoping.

The first target was the talisman Mbappe. He was suffocatingly marked, three fast and rugged men tailing, grappling and sometimes cuddling him. Perhaps the inhuman goal machine is human after all. His fabled precision deserted him. His long-range punts deserted him; he tried an audacious kung-fu kick goal, but swiped the thick air. The dark arts kicked in; Andres Cubas grabbed his body and pulled him down; he won a free kick; Matias Galarza smacked Mbappe when he was not even with the ball. The referee and his associates didn't spot it, or didn't bother. Corners were a shirt-pulling slugfests; just before the first hydration break, they were clutching at each other's throats, verbal frowns, and referees turned doves waving the white flag. Paraguay fans turned on the watts of hostility; those from France outnumbered

them. Paraguay's brass bands pierced the roar of the French throat boxes.

The scenes belonged in a Latin American gangster movie. France didn't flinch; they perhaps knew they had to flex their muscles more against the South American than against any other they have encountered. They gave the same currency back, in interest. William Saliba bundled out Manuel Almiron. Dayot Upamecano bulldozed Julio Enciso. In the

magnificence of their attackers, the impregnability of the backline has gone unsung. In five games, the blue wall was broken just twice.

Both centre-backs bullied Paraguay's attackers and outran them repeatedly. Paraguay did enjoy a pair of attempts on goal, one of which stretched the reflexes of Mike Maignan. If Paraguay arrived with the idea of roughening France up, they ended up being roughened up.

Yet for all their thuggery and rage-baiting, the yellow card count read: France 3; Paraguay 0. Even Diego Gomez's stud marks on Doue, tip-toeing through mangled limbs like he were walking through water, were left unattended before the VAR intervened. The foul was bleeding obvious, and Mbappe clattered it home with a ferocious shot.

He was venting out all his angst. He scowled at goalkeeper Gill when the ball crashed into the nets. Gill, Paraguay's shootout hero against Germany, had tried to wind up Mbappe before the kick. Chimed in some of Gill's colleagues. Mbappe has seen it all, the tricks and the tantrums. He remained unintimidated.

France showed they have many ways to kill the cat. And tame the lions that they could encounter.

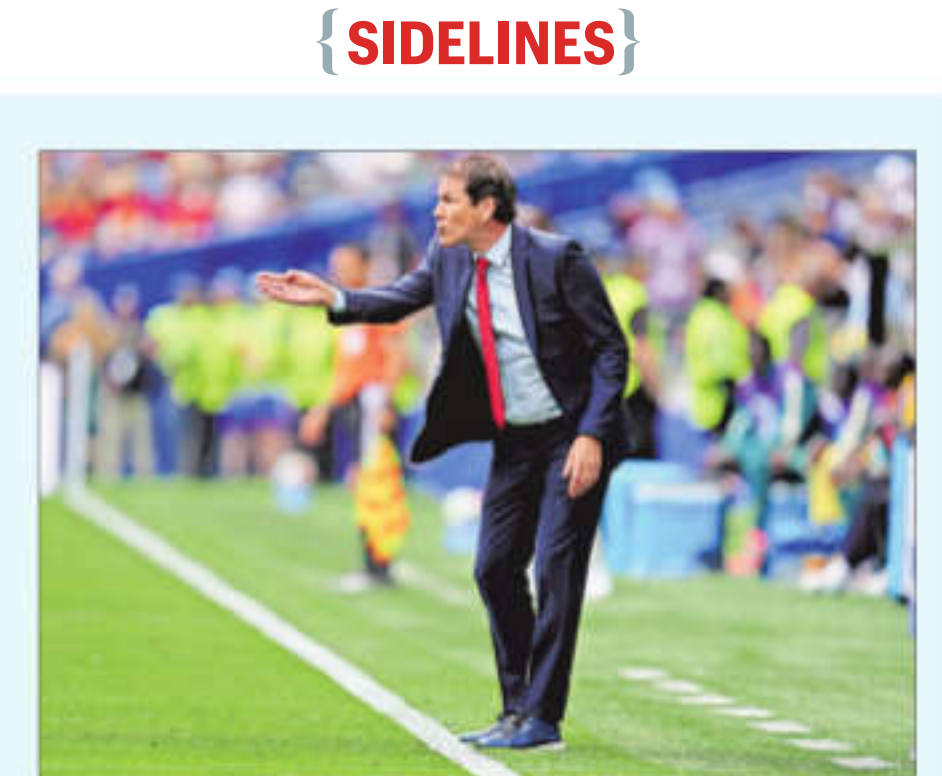


Kylian Mbappe scored his seventh goal of the tournament to lead France to the quarterfinals. AP



"I asked the two biggest lads to go and stand around Kylian at the end because they were going to chop him down. It wasn't easy. They used every resource possible."

DIDIER DESCHAMPS, HEAD COACH, FRANCE



Rudi Garcia's substitutions resulted in Belgium's comeback against Senegal in the Round of 32. AP

Belgian fans apologise to Rudi Garcia via a website

THE RESTLESS Belgium manager who is tasked with defending his talented but goal-shy stars like Romelu Lukaku and Kevin de Bruyne, as also the on-field hell-raisers Trossard and Tielemans, is getting some belated adoration. Reason: Belgium's unlikely comeback against Senegal to win 3-2. Garcia, the 62-year-old coach of the Red Devils (a not well known name), has been dissed on for everything: his players are washed, his players are old, his players argue and fight, his players like Lukaku don't play when needed, his players waste own talent and Belgium's time. And he defends them like Antwerp diamonds. He also scribbles notes on random loose sheets of paper, wearing a ridiculous red thin tie and a cap at times. The Frenchman copped intense criticism deep into

the Senegal game when he seemed to be heading into a disaster, before the team emerged to fight back against the African champions. Garcia has left things till late, assured that Lukaku will do his things and opponents will wilt under Belgian pressure if it's kept up. For that, he now has 9000 "atleast" who have written to him, telling Garcia they will not give up on him. The Brussels Times reported that over 9,000 people have left a message Garcia via the website sorryrudi.be, which was set up in the aftermath of Belgium's dramatic win against Senegal in the World Cup in the round of 32. The website asks, "Who still believed in Rudi Garcia in the 85th minute? Cursed en masse, answered masterfully. Time to apologize, together with Tout Bien Pills." EXPRESS NEWS SERVICE



Mexico's players forced to return luxury watches

MEXICO'S SQUAD have had to return Rolex watches that were gifted to them by American content creator Stephen Deleonardis, who goes by 'Stevewildoid' on YouTube. Deleonardis said on Instagram that he had given every player and member of staff an "expensive" watch ahead of their knockout encounter with Ecuador. He also posted a video that showed him gifting the players the watches, in which he said: "I love you guys and you guys are gonna f**** win tomorrow". The video then shows Deleonardis presenting presidential Rolex to the team, and members collecting one each. But FIFA's Code of Ethics are stringent about the offering and acceptance of gifts, with Article 21 stating that such gifts can only be offered or accepted if they "have symbolic or trivial value". As per the Mexico team's official X account, they returned the gifts by "mutual agreement". When asked why he gave the watches, Deleonardis had said, "I live in Mexico and I bet \$2 million on you guys tomorrow so everything's free." ENS

Aussie women win seventh T20 World Cup

Shankar Narayan
Mumbai, July 5

BEFORE SUNDAY'S Women's T20 World Cup final at Lord's, there seemed little to separate Australia and England. On the day, it was hardly a contest as Australian dominance continued. Their seven-wicket victory delivered a seventh Women's T20 World Cup crown.

Australia possess an embarrassment of batting riches, with power-hitters capable of clearing any boundary in the world. Yet, Beth Mooney is the quiet constant who binds the innings together. After an unbeaten 61 in the semifinal, the final presented another chase, another big stage, and another moment that demanded her calm.

After a watchful start, Mooney settled in quickly. She was proactive against both spin and pace, repeatedly backing away to leg to create angles and punish anything overpitched or short. A slog-swept boundary off Linsey Smith got her going before she drove and lofted Lauren Bell with authority. By the end of the dominant Powerplay, where Australia were 62/1, Mooney had already seized control of the chase, scoring fluently around the ground. Phoebe Litchfield walked out to bat in the second over, and the left-hander immediately injected momentum into the chase. Her first shot raced straight past the bowler before she swept, drove and danced down the track to launch Charlie Dean over extra cover for the innings' first six. No England bowler was allowed to settle into any rhythm as the pair tighten Australia's grip on the final.

Earlier, captain Nat Sciver-Brunt's unbeaten 58 and an 80-run stand with Freya Kemp carried them to 150/4.

BRIEF SCORES: England 150/4 in 20 overs (Nat Sciver-Brunt 58 not out) lost to Australia 153/3 in 17.1 overs (Beth Mooney 64, Phoebe Litchfield 48) by 7 wickets.

BELGIUM'S OLDEN GENERATION

Lukaku's Jekyll and Hyde act

Bench role suits striker who has had impact when introduced late, but hasn't excelled as a starter

Shuvaditya Bose
New Delhi, July 5

ROMELU LUKAKU mastered the art of deception when he was young. In 2026, Belgium reaching the World Cup round of 16 — where they will face the USA — feels almost routine. In 2002, it was anything but. Four years after the embarrassment of France '98, Belgium emerged unbeaten from the group stage. Leading the lines were Marc Wilmots — whom the nation admired, and Mbo Mpenza — whom Lukaku admired, considering he was Belgium's first black striker at a World Cup and, like Lukaku, had his roots in Congo.

Students at an Antwerp school, hence, had only one topic to discuss during the summer of '02 — the World Cup. They dissected Belgium's performances, marvelled at Wilmots' goals and discussed whether Brazil could be stopped.

There was only one problem. Lukaku had not watched a single minute. His father might have played in the World Cup qualifiers and AFCON for Zaire, but there was barely any money to eat twice a day. Television, hence, was a luxury.

His friends would not know that, though. Lukaku would analyse matches with enough conviction to assure them he had been minutely watching the World Cup. He was the master of pulling up facades.

For much of the next quarter-century, so too would be his football. Russia 2018 presented a version of Lukaku



Romelu Lukaku sparked Belgium's comeback against Senegal. AP

that will force you into believing he is one of the finest strikers of this generation. He scored four goals — only Harry Kane scored more. He did what Wilmots' generation could not — beating Brazil in a knockout. An astonished Rio Ferdinand said after the match: "He almost shouldn't be allowed to play with them! It was like a 16-year-old playing against the 11-year-olds."

Qatar disaster

But Qatar 2022 presented another version of Lukaku — one that will force you to believe he, as Ferdinand said, should not be allowed to play. Not because he was too good, but because he was awful. Like the fixture against Croatia at Qatar in 2022. Staring at their first group stage exit since 1998, Roberto Martinez brought on Lukaku to score. He had four opportunities — writers of the older generation would call those 'gilt-edged' — and generated 1.74 xG. All four were squandered. The dichotomy has followed him into America.

His inclusion in Belgium's squad felt improbable. A hamstring injury and persistent fitness problems restricted Lukaku to just 64 minutes for Napoli across the Italian season. Before the tournament, coach Rudi Garcia faced criticism simply for selecting him.

Lukaku answered in 23 seconds. Introduced when Belgium were trailing by a goal against Egypt, Lukaku exerted enough pressure on defender Mohamed Hany to force him into tucking the ball in his own net.

The cameo earned him a start against Iran. And then, inevitably, the dichotomy struck again. Lukaku had just 24 touches — fewer than every Belgian starter, including goal-keeper Thibaut Courtois. His only shot generated 0.03 xG. He drifted through the match almost unnoticed.

Garcia had no other option but to drop him against New Zealand. But when he was introduced in the 85th minute, he immediately became Belgium's most imposing presence. In

nine minutes, Lukaku scored once and created another for Alexis Saelemaekers.

Garcia appeared to embrace that unpredictability against Senegal, leaving Lukaku on the bench again. It worked. Belgium recovered from 2-0 down to win 3-2, and Lukaku sparked the comeback with his 86th-minute strike that reduced the deficit.

Lukaku's career has been marred by moments he would not look back upon. What he would, though, is his statistics — fifth-highest goal-scorer in men's international football (92), and a goals/match ratio (0.71) that eclipses some of the world's most prolific scorers, including Cristiano Ronaldo (0.63), Lionel Messi (0.61), Neymar (0.61) and Kylian Mbappe (0.61).

This World Cup has revealed another side of him too — his honesty. On being asked about why he let Youri Tielemans take the 125th-minute penalty against Senegal, he could have crafted an answer tailor-made for optics and PR. Instead, he admitted: "I'm not mentally ready for such difficult and crucial moments." Responding to whether he is content with bit-part roles, considering his stature, he admitted: "If you look at my season and how it went, I should never have been at the World Cup. So, I am just happy to be here."

Throughout his international career, Belgium have lived with two versions of Romelu Lukaku, and the public have responded to each very differently. When at his best, he is Belgium's very own Romelu. When at his worst, he is Lukaku Bolingoli of Congolese descent. A bit like how the unassuming Steve becomes Steven Peter Devereux Smith when he scores a century, except in Lukaku's case, the distinction has a racial undertone.

Against the United States, Rudi Garcia and Belgium are left with the same question everyone else has asked for years: Which Romelu Lukaku will turn up?

Iyer needs to find potent bowlers beyond Arshdeep

Venkata Krishna B
Chennai, July 5

ROHIT SHARMA and Suryakumar Yadav had Jasprit Bumrah and Kuldeep Yadav. Who does Shreyas Iyer turn to? As India's new T20I captain searched for an elusive win on his trip to the UK, in each of the three completed fixtures, Shreyas has instead found a headache, which he quickly needs to address before it turns into a migraine.

Within the India set up there is sympathy for the 31-year-old, who has to make do with a set of bowlers who still appear to be carrying the scars from bowling on flat, lifeless decks in the IPL, where scoring-rate of 9.68 rpo was a record high for the tournament.

Even if one wishes to brush the series defeat to Ireland under the carpet, the same cannot be said about India's defeat to England in the second T20I. Of course, there are some minor issues in the batting department, but since arriving in England, India has posted big totals that it is used to. Maybe, the extra 20 runs that would give the bowlers the cushion have been missing, but there are some encouraging signs.

However, it is with the ball that India have appeared totally flat. If they let Ireland off the hook in the matches in Ireland, in Manchester despite Arshdeep Singh beginning England's innings with two wickets in the first over (1/2), India never looked in control of the game. If anything, it appeared as if England just needed a couple of overs to seal the deal, and it duly occurred. While Ravi Bishnoi's back foot no-balls cost him severely, it wasn't the case of the leg-spinner costing India dearly.

That India would be without Bumrah in the format was a given. Beyond him, the next



Varun Chakaravathy has struggled lately for India. CREIMAS

best pacer Mohammed Siraj isn't in the T20 scheme of things. With Arshdeep being able to rise up as a lethal new-ball option and a reliable one at the death, the left-arm pacer was who both Rohit and Surya relied on alongside Hardik Pandya. Beyond them were the spinners — Varun Chakaravathy, Kuldeep Yadav and Axar Patel.

Now for this new cycle, Shreyas is yet to find a bowler who is the leader of this pack. For all the match-winning performances that Arshdeep has produced, in the absence of Bumrah, he hasn't evolved into one who can take responsibility and provide wickets when the team needs. Of course, he continues to make early inroads with the new ball, but has also been easy to put under pressure as Harry Brook showed on Sunday, taking him apart for 27 runs in his second over after he started the chase with two wickets down.

That over meant Shreyas immediately turned to spinners, which Surya or even Rohit seldom did. They did use spinners in the Powerplay, but those were rarely signs of desperation. At Manchester, Shreyas had to use Bishnoi and Axar for three overs in the middle-overs, he only had Varun — a spinner who has struggled of late.

Djokovic breaks Federer's Big W win record

Associated Press
London, July 5

NOVAK DJOKOVIC added another chapter to his Wimbledon legacy on Sunday as the Serb fought past Russian qualifier Roman Safiullin 7-6(6), 6-3, 3-6, 6-3 to earn a record 106th match victory at the All England Club and reach another quarter-final.

The victory moved Djokovic clear of his retired rival Roger Federer on the men's all-time match wins list at the grass court Grand Slam. The seventh seed will now have another piece of history in his sights as he bids to equal the Swiss great's haul of eight Wimbledon titles.

Also in pursuit of a standalone 25th Grand Slam trophy, the 39-year-old Djokovic has steadily gained momentum on the famous lawns of southwest London and heads into the last eight having again shown his knack for navigating danger.

"Another hard-fought win," Djokovic said. "Roman started very well and very aggressively. I didn't feel as comfortable from back on the court. I knew it was going to be a challenge, staying in the rally with him, particularly from the end where you played against the wind. He's just a very solid player and I respect him."

RESULTS:

Men's: Alexander Zverev def. Marcos Giron 6-2, 7-6, 6-4; Alexander Bublik def. Frances Tiafoe 4-6, 7-6, 7-6, 4-6, 6-3; Grigor Dimitrov def. Matteo Berrettini 6-3, 6-4, 3-6, 5-7, 6-3; Novak Djokovic def. Roman Safiullin 7-6, 6-3, 3-6, 6-3.

Women's Singles: Madison Keys def. Amanda Anisimova 3-6, 6-2, 6-3; Linda Noskova def. Sorana Cirstea 2-6, 6-3, 7-6; Jessica Pegula def. Iva Jovicic 4-6, 6-3, 6-1; Karolina Muchova def. Barbora Krejickova 7-5, 5-7, 6-3.

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